

Cārvāka (Indian materialist school) / Lokāyata (worldly doctrine)

COMPLETE MULTI-PAGE FLOWCHART COMPANION

Basic -> Optional Advanced -> Register Retrieval -> PYQ Routes & Answer Spine

Landscape visual edition | Source-complete learner-v2 | 21 August 2026

Reading rule: follow the vertical arrows. Each continuation card retains source-owned definitions, classifications, derivations, objections, replies, comparisons, traps and recall cues. Practice prose is not duplicated; only verified question routes and answer architecture are mapped.

TECHNICAL-TERM TRANSLATION GATEWAY

Every Sanskrit, Pali, Prakrit or Hindi technical expression used later is introduced here with its immediate exam-safe English meaning. Prominent visual maps repeat the translation so no diagram depends on untranslated labels.

Technical term (immediate English meaning)	Technical term (immediate English meaning)	Technical term (immediate English meaning)
āstika (Veda-affirming or orthodox school)	nāstika (Veda-rejecting or heterodox school)	ātman (enduring self or soul)
anātman (no permanent self)	anātmavāda (doctrine of no permanent self)	anīśvaravāda (denial of a creator God)
Īśvara (Lord or creator God)	karma (action and its morally consequential residue)	saṃsāra (cycle of rebirth and suffering)
mokṣa (liberation)	nirvāṇa (cessation of craving and conditioned suffering)	dharma (doctrine, duty or constitutive factor, as context requires)
adharma (non-duty or, in Jainism, the medium enabling rest)	pramāṇa (means of valid knowledge)	pramā (valid cognition)
pratyakṣa (perception)	anumāna (inference)	śabda (verbal testimony)
upamāna (comparison or analogy)	arthāpatti (postulation or presumption)	anupalabdhi (non-cognition used to know absence)
vyāpti (invariable concomitance)	upādhi (hidden limiting condition)	tarka (hypothetical or reductio reasoning)
anvaya (positive agreement in presence)	vyatireka (negative agreement in absence)	anvaya-vyatireka (joint method of agreement in presence and absence)
pūrvapakṣa (opponent's prima-facie position)	siddhānta (established conclusion)	śāstra (authoritative treatise or discipline)
sūtra (concise aphoristic text)	darśana (philosophical system or vision)	guṇa (quality)
dravya (substance)	paryāya (changing mode)	puruṣa (person or conscious principle)
prakṛti (primordial material nature)	manas (mind)	rūpa (material form)
vedanā (feeling)	saṃjñā (recognition or perception)	saṃskāra (mental formation or disposition)
vijñāna (consciousness)	avidyā (ignorance)	trṣṇā (craving)
upādāna (clinging or grasping)	jāti (birth)	jarā-maraṇa (ageing and death)
bija (causal seed or latent potency)	svabhāva (intrinsic own-nature)	sat (being or reality)
duḥkha (suffering or unsatisfactoriness)	ahiṃsā (non-violence)	apūrva (unseen ritual potency)
adrṣṭa (unseen causal force)	Mīmāṃsā (Vedic exegesis school)	Nyāya (school of logic and epistemology)
Vaiśeṣika (school of categories and atomism)	Sāṃkhya (dualistic enumeration school)	Vedānta (Upaniṣad-based end-of-the-Veda tradition)
Yogācāra (Buddhist consciousness-only school)	Mādhyamika (Buddhist middle-way emptiness school)	jīva (living soul or conscious being)

Technical term (immediate English meaning)	Technical term (immediate English meaning)	Technical term (immediate English meaning)
jñāna (knowledge)	Cārvāka (Indian materialist and perception-centred school)	Nyāya-Vaiśeṣika (combined realist traditions of logic and categories)
Sāṃkhya-Yoga (paired traditions of dualist enumeration and disciplined practice)	Vedāntic (relating to an Upaniṣad-based Vedānta tradition)	Upaniṣadic (relating to the philosophical Upaniṣads)
śruti (revealed Vedic scripture)	Naiyāyika (adherent of the Nyāya school)	pāramārthika (ultimate level)
arthakriyā (causal efficacy)	Śūnyavāda (doctrine of emptiness)	anekānta (many-sidedness)
bhaṅga (predicative mode)	bhaṅgas (seven predicative modes)	nairātmya (absence of a permanent self)
Nyaya (school of logic and epistemology)	Vaisesika (school of categories and atomism)	Samkhya (dualistic enumeration school)
Vedanta (Upaniṣad-based end-of-the-Veda tradition)	Mimamsa (Vedic exegesis school)	Isvara (Lord or creator God)
atman (enduring self or soul)	moksa (liberation)	nirvana (cessation of craving and conditioned suffering)
Lokāyata (worldly or common-people's doctrine)	Bārhaspatya (tradition attributed to Bṛhaspati)	Bṛhaspati-sūtra (lost aphoristic text traditionally attributed to Bṛhaspati)
pratyakṣaika-pramāṇavāda (doctrine that perception alone is an independent means of valid knowledge)	lokasiddha (established in ordinary worldly practice)	laukika (ordinary or worldly)
alaukika (extraordinary or non-ordinary)	vyāvahārika (practical or conventional level)	saṃvṛti (conventional truth)
paramārtha (ultimate truth)	liṅga (inferential sign)	sādhya (property to be proved)
hetu (reason or probans)	parāmarśa (reflective cognition linking the sign with the universal relation)	anumiti (inferential cognition)
karāṇa (operative instrument or cause)	nirvikalpaka (indeterminate perception)	savikalpaka (determinate perception)
sāmānyalakṣaṇa-pratyakṣa (extraordinary perception of a universal character)	pañcāvayava (five-membered syllogism)	aniṣṭa-prasaṅga (derivation of an unacceptable consequence)
bhūta (material element)	bhūtas (material elements)	ākāśa (ether or space as an element)
svabhāvavāda (doctrine that natural properties explain events)	yadṛcchāvāda (doctrine of chance or accidental occurrence)	bhūta-caitanya-vāda (doctrine that consciousness emerges from material elements)
dehātmavāda (doctrine that the conscious living body is the self)	caitanya (consciousness)	indriya (sense faculty)
prāṇa (vital breath)	sthūla śarīra (gross physical body)	santāna (causal continuum or stream)
pratisandhāna (continuity-linking connection)	ālaya-vijñāna (store-consciousness)	skandha (aggregate constituting the person-process)
skandhas (five aggregates constituting the person-process)	svarga (heaven)	śrāddha (ritual offering for ancestors)
jyotiṣṭoma (Vedic soma sacrifice)	puruṣārtha (goal of human life)	puruṣārthas (goals of human life)

Technical term (immediate English meaning)	Technical term (immediate English meaning)	Technical term (immediate English meaning)
artha (material prosperity or practical means)	kāma (pleasure or desire)	brahmacarya (disciplined celibacy or student conduct)
daṇḍanīti (science of punishment and government)	vārttā (livelihood sciences of agriculture, cattle and trade)	nāgarika-vṛtti (cultivated urban way of life)
suśikṣita (cultivated or refined)	dhūrta (cunning or crude)	apauruṣeya (not authored by a human being)
apauruṣeyatva (authorlessness)	viṭaṇḍā (destructive disputation without a positive thesis)	ahetuvāda (denial of determinate causation)
apavarga (release or liberation)	Jayarāśi (Cārvāka-associated radical sceptic)	Tattvopaplavasimha (The Lion that Overturns All Principles, Jayarāśi's sceptical work)
pramana (means of valid knowledge)	pratyaksa (perception)	vyapti (invariable concomitance)
upadhi (hidden limiting condition)	akasa (ether or space as an element)	svabhavavada (doctrine that natural properties explain events)
dehatmavada (doctrine that the conscious living body is the self)	anumana (inference)	sabda (verbal testimony)
Sarva-darśana-saṃgraha (Compendium of All Philosophical Systems)	Tattvasaṅgraha (Compendium of Principles)	Vedāntasāra (Essence of Vedānta)
Sāmaññaphala-sutta (Discourse on the Fruits of the Contemplative Life)	Majjhima Nikāya (Collection of Middle-Length Discourses)	vyāptigraha (apprehension of invariable concomitance)
bhūyodarśana (repeated observation)	sāmānyalakṣaṇa (universal character)	pramāṇa-anugrahaka (aid that supports a means of valid knowledge)
pratīyasamutpāda (dependent origination)	kṣaṇikavāda (doctrine of momentariness)	syādvāda (doctrine of qualified or conditional assertion)
anekāntavāda (doctrine of many-sided reality)	kevala-jñāna (perfect omniscience)	utpāda-vyaya-dhrauṇya (origination, decay and persistence)
bhāvabandha (psychic or intentional bondage)	bhūta-caitanya (consciousness emergent from material elements)	catuḥ-ṣaṣṭi-kalāḥ (sixty-four cultivated arts)
tāmbūla (betel preparation)	guḍa (molasses or fermenting sugar)	kāla (time)
manaḥparyāya (direct knowledge of another mind)	nayavāda (theory of partial standpoints)	nairātmyavāda (doctrine of no permanent self)
pudgala-nairātmya (no-self of the person)	Puggalavāda (Buddhist personalist school)	pramāṇa-status (status as an independent means of valid knowledge)
upādhi-elimination (removal of hidden limiting conditions)	pratyakṣa-only (restricted to perception alone)	deha-ātmavāda (doctrine identifying the conscious body with the self)
prasaṅga-style (reductio-based argumentative style)	yadṛcchā (chance or accidental occurrence)	Lokāyata-mata (worldly or common-people's doctrine)
dharma s (plural form: doctrine, duty or constitutive factor, as context requires)	pramāṇas (plural form: means of valid knowledge)	upādhis (plural form: hidden limiting condition)
sūtras (plural form: concise aphoristic text)	dravyas (plural form: substance)	paryāyas (plural form: changing mode)
bijas (plural form: causal seed or latent potency)	jīvas (plural form: living soul or conscious being)	Cārvākas (plural form: Indian materialist and perception-centred school)

Technical term (immediate English meaning)	Technical term (immediate English meaning)	Technical term (immediate English meaning)
Naiyāyikas (plural form: adherent of the Nyāya school)	Lokāyatas (plural form: worldly or common-people's doctrine)	pramanas (plural form: means of valid knowledge)

MASTER LEARNING SEQUENCE

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03 1. The three names, and what each one tells you	04 2. The source problem, stated precisely
05 3. The surviving fragments — what is actually quoted	06 4. Why Cārvāka (Indian materialist and perception-centred school) is <i>nāstika</i> (Veda-rejecting or heterodox school) — and the exact sense of the word
07 5. Why materialism arose — the historical setting	08 6. Jayarāśi (Cārvāka-associated radical sceptic) Bhaṭṭa — the one surviving text, and why it must be handled carefully
09 2. Epistemology — Perception as the Sole <i>Pramāṇa</i> (means of valid knowledge)	10 1. The core thesis, stated exactly
11 2. Two kinds of perception, and why the Cārvāka (Indian materialist and perception-centred school) needs both	12 3. Certainty versus practical belief — the distinction that saves the position
13 4. Why <i>śabda</i> (verbal testimony) falls — the argument in five steps	14 5. Why <i>upamāna</i> (comparison or analogy), <i>arthāpatti</i> (postulation or presumption) and <i>anupalabdhi</i> (non-cognition used to know absence) fall too

Read numbered cells left-to-right, then continue on the next row.

BASIC — COMPLETE TEACHING FLOW



Regeneration ledger

Source corpus	g3 treatment
Learner-v2 g2 Basic teaching	Retained in full
Learner-v2 g2 Optional Advanced	Retained in full after practice
g2 detailed register	Retained at the end beneath the new A–L retrieval register
g2 32+10 diagnostics	Replaced by standard 40+8 diagnostics
Verified PYQ corpus	Nine primary-owned questions rebuilt as complete solutions
Original Mains practice	Standardised to six solved models

Answer-worthiness. Perception-only epistemology, critique of inference, four-element materialism, body-self, emergent consciousness and rejection of transcendent entities are **CORE SYLLABUS**. Source historiography, strong versus softened readings, Jayarāśi and controlled modern comparisons are **CORE SUPPORTING DEPTH**. Crude hedonist caricature and invented primary-text certainty are excluded.



Contemporary-anchor discipline

FACT: **Search finding:** A live August 2026 search found continuing academic interest in Cārvāka/Lokāyata and broad philosophy conferences, but no direct official doctrinal development requiring insertion into the answer core. CAUTION: **Inference:** Contemporary labels such as empiricism, naturalism or dissent may aid comparison only when qualified; they cannot replace historically controlled reconstruction.

Complete Basic first. Optional interpretive depth is deliberately withheld until Section D so the core doctrine remains easy to learn and usable in a competent answer.



0. ONE-SCREEN MAP

SOURCE PROBLEM
-> PERCEPTION AS SOLE PRAMANA (means of valid knowledge)
-> INFERENCE CRITIQUE
-> NYAYA (school of logic and epistemology) DEFENCE
-> FOUR-ELEMENT MATERIALISM
-> BODY-SELF AND EMERGENT CONSCIOUSNESS
-> REJECTION OF TRANSCENDENT ENTITIES
-> THIS-WORLDLY ETHICS AND SOCIAL MEANING
-> COMPARATIVE SYNTHESIS

This is a route map, not a substitute for the nine complete Basic subtopics below.



1. Historical Reconstruction and the Source Problem



Plain-language visual - learning through an opponent's notes

ORIGINAL CARVAKA BOOK
|
X lost
|
What opponents quoted ---> our main evidence
|
One surviving sceptical work (Jayarasi)
|
CAREFUL RECONSTRUCTION, not blind certainty

In simple words: imagine trying to understand a debater when their own notebook is lost and only the rival team's rebuttal survives. We can still recover the main position because several opponents repeat the same core claims, but we must distinguish secure doctrine from hostile caricature.

Remember first	Meaning
Cārvāka (Indian materialist and perception-centred school) / Lokāyata (worldly or common-people's doctrine) / Bārhaspatya (tradition attributed to Bṛhaspati)	Three names associated with the materialist tradition
Lost primary text	The <i>Bṛhaspati-sūtra</i> (lost aphoristic text traditionally attributed to Bṛhaspati) does not survive
Main caution	Write "on the standard doxographical reconstruction"
Why <i>nāstika</i> (Veda-rejecting or heterodox school)?	Rejection of Vedic authority, not simply disbelief in God

One-line memory: Cārvāka is known mostly through its critics, so reconstruct firmly but quote cautiously.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Recommended opening definition: Cārvāka (Indian materialist school), also called Lokāyata (worldly doctrine), is a non-Vedic and this-worldly philosophy that accepts *pratyakṣa* (perception) as the only independent *pramāṇa* (means of valid knowledge) and rejects unverifiable transcendent entities; because its primary texts are lost, its doctrines must be stated as a cautious doxographical reconstruction.



VISUAL: VISUAL — How we know what we know about Cārvāka (Indian materialist and perception-centred school)

WHAT WOULD BE IDEAL WHAT WE ACTUALLY HAVE
=====

BRHASPATI-SUTRA (primary) (LOST)
| |
| direct transmission | about a dozen sutras and
v | verses quoted by OTHERS
Carvaka commentaries v
| +-----+
v | HOSTILE DOXOGRAPHY |
Living school with pupils | Sarva-darsana-sangraha |
| Sad-darsana-samuccaya |
| Prabodhacandrodaya (play)|
| Tattvasangraha (Buddhist)|
| Vedantasara (Advaita) |
+-----+
|
refutation-first framing:
strongest points omitted,
weakest points magnified
|
v
+ ONE surviving sceptical text
TATTVOPAPLAVASIMHA (The Lion that Overturns All Principles, Jayarāṣi's sceptical work)
(Jayarasi Bhatta, c. 8th c. CE)
-- but it is MORE sceptical
than the standard Carvaka

CAUTION: **Caption.** Every claim in this topic passes through a filter of refutation. That does not make reconstruction impossible; it makes *epistemic honesty about the reconstruction* itself a mark-earning move. The examiner rewards a candidate who writes "on the standard doxographical reconstruction" rather than one who quotes a lost text as though it were open on the desk.



1. The three names, and what each one tells you			
Name	Literal sense	What it signals	Evidence status
Cārvāka (Indian materialist and perception-centred school)	Possibly from <i>carv</i> , "to chew, to eat" — the doctrine of "eat, drink and be merry"; or from <i>cāru-vāk</i> , "sweet-worded / pleasant of speech"	Either a hostile nickname or a note that the doctrine is superficially attractive	FACT: Both etymologies are given in Chatterjee and Datta; C. D. Sharma adds a third gloss — one who "chews up" merit and demerit
Lokāyata (worldly or common-people's doctrine)	<i>Lokāyata-mata</i> (<i>worldly or common-people's doctrine</i>), "the view of the common people"; a <i>lokāyatika</i> is its holder	The school is popular, worldly, this-worldly; by implication in hostile sources, unrefined	FACT: Chatterjee and Datta; Sharma adds that "commoner" carries a pejorative implication of low taste in the sources
Bārhaspatya (tradition attributed to Bṛhaspati)	"Of Bṛhaspati"	Traces the school to Bṛhaspati as its traditional founder	FACT: Sharma: "Bṛhaspati, a heretical teacher, is regarded as the traditional founder of this school. His <i>Sūtra</i> (<i>concise aphoristic text</i>) ... has unfortunately perished."

FACT: There is a further doxographical curiosity, reported in both Chatterjee and Datta and Sharma: some accounts identify this Brhaspati with the *teacher of the gods*, who is said to have propagated materialism among the *asuras* precisely so that, following these attractive teachings, they would come to ruin. QUESTION: That story is polemical theology, not history; quote it only to illustrate how the tradition was framed by its enemies.

CAUTION: **Exam use.** The highlighted answer-grabbing line above is the preferred full opening. For a very short answer, write: "Cārvāka, also called Lokāyata and Bārhaspatya, is the materialist and *nāstika* (non-Vedic) school of Indian philosophy."



2. The source problem, stated precisely

FACT: **The facts, as the standard textbooks state them.**

- No systematic primary work of the school survives. Chatterjee and Datta: "we do not find any systematic work on materialism, nor any organised school of followers as the other philosophical schools possess."
- The *Brhaspati-sūtra* is lost. Sharma: about **a dozen** *sūtras* and verses are found quoted or referred to by other authors as the materialistic teachings of Brhaspati.
- "Almost every work of the other schools states, for refutation, the materialistic views. Our knowledge of Indian materialism is chiefly based on these" (Chatterjee and Datta).
- Sharma is blunter about the consequence: "the weak points in this school are exaggerated and the strong points are omitted. So we get only a faint caricature and not a true picture."
- Sharma adds the decisive historiographical warning: even the *Sarva-darśana-saṃgraha* summary "seems to be based on such accounts", so it does not give independent access to the school.

CAUTION: **What follows philosophically.** Three consequences, each usable as a line in an answer:

- (a) MODAL CAUTION : write "on the standard reconstruction", not "Carvaka says in his text".
- (b) CHARITY : where a doctrine has a crude and a defensible version, the crude one is the one an enemy would preserve. Reconstruct the strongest available reading and SAY that you are doing so.
- (c) NON-PARALYSIS : convergence across independent hostile sources on the same doctrinal core (perceptualism, anti-inferentialism, four elements, no soul, no afterlife) is itself evidence.



3. The surviving fragments — what is actually quoted

FACT: Sharma gleans the following from the *Brhaspati* material quoted across philosophical writings. These are the closest thing to primary text that exists, and they are quoted *by others*:

#	Sūtra (concise aphoristic text) (as transmitted)	Doctrine
1	<i>pr̥thivyāptejovāyuriti tattvāni</i>	Earth, water, fire and air are the elements
2	<i>tatsamudāye śārīrendriyaviśaya-saṃjñā</i>	Bodies, senses and objects are results of different combinations of the elements
3	<i>kiṇvādibhyo madaśaktivad vijñānam</i>	Consciousness arises from matter as intoxicating power arises from fermenting agents
4	<i>caitanya-viśiṣṭaḥ kāyaḥ puruṣaḥ</i>	The person is the body qualified by consciousness
5	<i>kāma (pleasure or desire) evaikaḥ puruṣārthaḥ</i>	Enjoyment is the only end of human life

#	Sūtra (concise aphoristic text) (as transmitted)	Doctrine
6	<i>maraṇam eva apavargaḥ</i>	Death alone is liberation

FACT: Alongside these, the second act of Kṛṣṇamiśra's allegorical play *Prabodhacandrodaya* summarises the doctrine in a single sweep: "Lokāyata is the only *śāstra*; perception is the only authority; earth, water, fire and air are the only elements; enjoyment is the only end of human existence; mind is only a product of matter. There is no other world; death means liberation."

QUESTION: **Caution to carry through the whole session.** A play written by an opponent, staged as allegory, is a *representation* of the doctrine. It is legitimate evidence of how the school was understood; it is not the school's own voice.



4. Why Cārvāka (Indian materialist and perception-centred school) is *nāstika* (Veda-rejecting or heterodox school) — and the exact sense of the word

FACT: This is a precision point that separates strong scripts from weak ones. Chatterjee and Datta set it out exactly:

Sense of <i>āstika</i> (Veda-affirming or orthodox school)	Meaning in Sanskrit philosophical literature	Is Cārvāka (Indian materialist and perception-centred school) <i>nāstika</i> (Veda-rejecting or heterodox school) in this sense?
Primary, classificatory sense	One who accepts the authority of the Vedas	FACT: Yes — this is the sense that generates the six- <i>āstika</i> (Veda-affirming or orthodox school) / three- <i>nāstika</i> (Veda-rejecting or heterodox school) division
Secondary sense	One who believes in life after death	FACT: Yes
Modern vernacular sense	"Theist" versus "atheist"	CAUTION: Misleading. Sāṃkhya (dualistic enumeration school), Mīmāṃsā (Vedic exegesis school) and early Yoga-adjacent readings are non-theistic yet <i>āstika</i> (Veda-affirming or orthodox school)

FACT: Chatterjee and Datta state the consequence directly: the six orthodox schools are *āstika*, "and the Cārvāka is *nāstika* in both the senses". Jaina and Bauddha schools are *nāstika* on the first criterion but would count as *āstika* on the second, since they accept life after death.

MNEMONIC: Trap, and it is examined: *Cārvāka* is *nāstika* primarily because it rejects Vedic authority, not merely because it denies God. If denial of God were the criterion, Sāṃkhya and Mīmāṃsā would also be *nāstika* — and they are not.



5. Why materialism arose — the historical setting

FACT: Sharma gives the standard account: the school "seems to be very old", with references in the epics and in early Buddhist literature; Garbe is quoted to the effect that "even in the pre-Buddhistic India proclaimers of purely materialistic doctrines appeared." Sharma locates its rise in the post-Upaniṣadic and pre-Buddhistic age and attributes it to:

- protest against the excessive monkdom of the Brāhmaṇa priests;
- the externals of ritualism, "which ignored the substance and emphasized the shadow";
- an Upaniṣadic idealism "unsuited to the commoners";
- political and social crises, exploitation of the masses by petty rulers, monks and the wealthy class.

FACT: Early Buddhist scripture confirms an environment of such thinkers. The <i>Sāmaññaphala-sutta</i> names four contemporaries of the Buddha whom Chatterjee and Datta group as "cunning (<i>dhūrta</i>) Cārvākas":	
Thinker	Position as reported
Pūraṇa Kassapa	Denies moral responsibility, virtue and vice
Makkhali Gosāla	Denies free will and the possibility of moral effort
Ajita Kesakambalī	Teaches the material origin and destructibility of man, the futility of good action, the impossibility of knowledge
Saṅjaya Belaṭṭhiputta	Will neither affirm, nor deny, nor both, nor even admit that he neither affirms nor denies
FACT: Sharma independently notes Ajita Kesakambalin in the <i>Majjhima Nikāya</i> as "a materialist ... who believed only in perception and in four elements", and records that Śāntarakṣita refers to him as <i>Kambalāśvatara</i> .	
CAUTION: Exam use. Naming Ajita Kesakambalī gives you a <i>pre-systematic historical anchor</i> for four-element materialism that is independent of the hostile Brahmanical doxography — a genuinely strong evidential move in a 15- or 20-marker on sources.	



6. Jayarāśi (Cārvāka-associated radical sceptic) Bhaṭṭa — the one surviving text, and why it must be handled carefully

FACT: The facts. Chatterjee and Datta: the <i>Tattvopaplavasīṃha</i> , by Jayarāśi , "probably of the eighth century A.D.", is a "recently discovered manuscript" and "an interesting specimen of Indian absolute scepticism"; its author "is believed to be a Cārvāka (or Lokāyatika) of an extreme type ." Sharma records the publication data: it is the "single exception" to the absence of extant works, published by the Oriental Institute of Baroda in 1940.
FACT: What Jayarāśi actually does. He "carries the scepticism of the ordinary Cārvāka to its logical conclusion by challenging the validity of perceptual knowledge and refusing to accept the existence of even the physical elements. With a relentless destructive dialectic he exposes the defects of all the usually accepted sources of knowledge." His conclusion, Chatterjee and Datta note, is that of "an anti-intellectualist pragmatist": even on the denial of all theoretical principles and doctrines, practical life will go on as ever with unreflective ease.
CAUTION: The distinction that must be preserved.
STANDARD CARVAKA JAYARASI'S SCEPTICISM ----- Perception is VALID Perception is ALSO attacked Four elements are REAL Even the elements are not admitted Positive materialist ontology NO positive ontology at all Rejects inference and testimony Rejects EVERY pramana (means of valid knowledge) = dogmatic empiricism = universal scepticism (tattva-upaplava, "the upsetting of all principles")
CAUTION: Why this matters for the exam. It is tempting, and wrong, to use Jayarāśi as evidence for what "the Cārvākas" held about perception. If Jayarāśi is used to establish the school's epistemology, the school's <i>defining</i> thesis — that perception alone is a <i>pramāṇa</i> — disappears. Use him for exactly two things: (i) as the sole surviving text-witness of the tradition, and (ii) as the internal limit-case showing where consistent Cārvāka scepticism, pressed hard, ends up.



Exam link
Source qualification improves every answer: the lost <i>Bṛhaspati-sūtra</i> , hostile doxography and contested attributions must be stated without allowing source caution to erase the convergent doctrinal core.



Traps and recap



UPSC traps

- QUESTION: Do not write that "Cārvāka wrote the *Bṛhaspati-sūtra*". The text is lost; about a dozen *sūtras* survive only as quotations in other authors' works.
- CAUTION: Do not treat the *Sarva-darśana-saṃgraha* as an independent primary source. Sharma explicitly says its summary "seems to be based on" the same refutational accounts.
- CAUTION: Do not use Jayarāśi's *Tattvopaplavasīṃha* to state the Cārvāka theory of knowledge. He attacks perception too, which no standard Cārvāka does.
- FACT: Do not say Cārvāka is *nāstika* "because it is atheist". It is *nāstika* because it rejects the authority of the Veda — and, in the second textbook sense, because it denies life after death.
- CAUTION: Do not present the "*asura*-deception" story about Bṛhaspati as history.
- CAUTION: Do not conclude from the source problem that "nothing can be known". Convergent hostile testimony still fixes a doctrinal core.
- CAUTION: Do not confuse *Lokāyata* ("view of the common people") with "folk religion". It names a philosophical position, not a devotional practice.



Revision notes

- FACT: Three names: **Cārvāka** (*carv*, to chew / *cāru-vāk*, sweet-worded), **Lokāyata** (*lokāyata-mata*, the view of common people), **Bārhaspatya** (of Bṛhaspati).
- FACT: Bṛhaspati is the traditional founder; his *Sūtra* is lost; about a dozen *sūtras* survive as quotations.
- FACT: Knowledge of the school comes chiefly from works that state its views **in order to refute them**.
- FACT: Sharma's verdict on transmission: strong points omitted, weak points exaggerated — "a faint caricature and not a true picture".
- FACT: Six transmitted *sūtras* to memorise: four elements · bodies-senses-objects from combination · consciousness like intoxicating power · person = body qualified by consciousness · *kāma* the only end · death alone is liberation.
- FACT: *Prabodhacandrodaya* Act II gives the classic one-sentence summary of the school.
- FACT: **Nāstika in both senses**: rejects Vedic authority; denies life after death. Vedic authority is the primary classificatory criterion.
- FACT: *Sāmaññaphala-sutta* names Pūraṇa Kassapa, Makkhali Gosāla, Ajita Kesakambali and Saṃjaya Belaṭṭhiputta as the environment of early scepticism and materialism.
- FACT: Ajita Kesakambali — "believed only in perception and in four elements" — is the best independent historical anchor for the doctrine.
- FACT: **Jayarāśi Bhaṭṭa**, *Tattvopaplavasīṃha*, c. 8th century CE, published Baroda 1940 — the single surviving text, but an extreme sceptic who attacks perception itself.
- CAUTION: Cārvāka was the **touchstone** every school had to answer; its historical value is critical rather than constructive.

• CAUTION: Two-sided verdict to carry: philosophically fertile as critique (Chatterjee–Datta), unsuccessful as a system (Sharma).



2. Epistemology — Perception as the Sole *Pramāṇa* (means of valid knowledge)

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Cārvāka (Indian materialist school) epistemology treats *pratyakṣa* (perception) as the only independent *pramāṇa* (means of valid knowledge), while accepting inference only as fallible practical expectation rather than certain knowledge.



Plain-language visual - the knowledge gate

Can I directly experience it?
|
YES v NO
accept inference/testimony may guide action,
as known but cannot guarantee philosophical certainty

In simple words: Cārvāka treats perception as the only secure entrance to knowledge. Inference and testimony may be useful in daily life, but their conclusions can fail; therefore they do not independently certify unseen realities.

Everyday case	Cārvāka (Indian materialist and perception-centred school) reading
Seeing fire	Directly known through perception
Seeing smoke and expecting fire	A useful expectation, not infallible knowledge
Hearing a trustworthy person	The words are heard; their truth still needs checking
Feeling pain or pleasure	Internally experienced and therefore perceptible

One-line memory: perception gives certainty; other routes may give practical probability.



VISUAL: VISUAL — The *pramāṇa* (means of valid knowledge) ledger of Indian philosophy, and where Cārvāka (Indian materialist and perception-centred school) stands

pratyaksa (perception) anumana (inference) upamana sabda (verbal testimony) arthapatti anupalabdhi (non-cognition used to know absence)
(percep.) (infer.) (compar.) (test.) (postul.) (non-cogn.)

CARVAKA YES no no no no no = 1
Vaisesika (school of categories and atomism) YES YES no no no no = 2
Buddhism YES YES no no no no = 2
Samkhya (dualistic enumeration school) / Yoga YES YES no YES no no = 3
Nyaya (school of logic and epistemology) YES YES YES YES no no = 4
Prabhakara Mimamsa (Vedic exegesis school) YES YES YES YES YES no = 5
Bhatta Mimamsa (Vedic exegesis school) / YES YES YES YES YES YES = 6
Advaita Vedanta (Upaniṣad-based end-of-the-Veda tradition)

^
|
CARVAKA SITS AT THE MINIMUM OF THE LEDGER.
Everything else in the system follows from that single cell.

CAUTION: **Caption.** This ledger is worth reproducing from memory in any *pramāṇa* question in Paper I. It shows at a glance that the Cārvāka position is not an eccentric outlier but the **lower bound** of a shared Indian debate about how many independent sources of knowledge there are. Nyāya sits at four; Cārvāka drives the number down to one and forces every other school to justify its additions.



1. The core thesis, stated exactly

FACT: ****Thesis (*pratyakṣaika-pramāṇavāda*).**** Perception alone is a *pramāṇa* — an independent, dependable source of valid knowledge (*pramā*).

FACT: Chatterjee and Datta frame the architecture of the whole system on this thesis: "The entire philosophy of the Cārvākas may be said to depend **logically** on their epistemology." Every later denial — of soul, God, *karma*, rebirth, heaven and liberation — is a consequence drawn from this one epistemic restriction, not a separate act of unbelief.

FACT: The vocabulary must be precise:

Term	Meaning	Why the exam cares
Pramā (valid cognition)	Valid cognition; knowledge of reality	The thing to be explained
Pramāṇa (means of valid knowledge)	The <i>means</i> by which <i>pramā</i> (<i>valid cognition</i>) arises	The disputed list
Pratyakṣa (perception)	Perception	The only item Cārvāka (Indian materialist and perception-centred school) admits
Anumāna (inference)	Inference	Rejected as uncertain
Śabda (verbal testimony)	Verbal testimony, including scripture	Rejected as derivative
Upamāna (comparison or analogy)	Comparison / analogy	Rejected with the rest

CAUTION: **The condition Cārvāka imposes.** Chatterjee and Datta state it as a conditional test: "If inference is to be regarded as a *pramāṇa*, it must yield knowledge **about which we can have no doubt** and **which must be true to reality**." Note the strength of the demand. This is not "usually reliable"; it is indubitability plus correspondence. Every subsequent Cārvāka argument is an application of this standard.



2. Two kinds of perception, and why the Cārvāka (Indian materialist and perception-centred school) needs both

FACT: Cārvāka accepts perception in both its classical forms, and the second is often forgotten by candidates:

PRATYAKSA (perception)
|
+--- BAHYA (external) : through the five external senses --
| sight, hearing, touch, taste, smell |
| > both admitted
+--- ANTARA / MANASA (internal) : the mind's immediate |
awareness of pleasure, pain, desire, and |
consciousness itself -----

FACT: This is not a decorative detail. Chatterjee and Datta present the strongest objection to Cārvāka materialism precisely through internal perception: "do we not have a kind of perception, called internal, which gives an immediate knowledge of our mental states? And do we not perceive in these consciousness which is nowhere to be perceived in the external material objects?" The objector's aim is to force the admission of an immaterial substrate.

FACT: **The Cārvāka answer, and it is subtle.** "The Cārvākas admit that the existence of consciousness is proved by perception. But they deny that consciousness is the quality of any unperceived non-material or spiritual entity." Consciousness is *given*; a soul is *not* given. What internal perception delivers is a state of the living body, not evidence of a separate substance.

CAUTION: **Exam-critical inference.** Cārvāka is therefore **not** a denier of consciousness. It is a denier of the *inference* from consciousness to an immaterial bearer of consciousness. A script that writes "Cārvāka denies consciousness" has confused materialism with eliminativism and has thrown away the 2024 twenty-marker.



3. Certainty versus practical belief — the distinction that saves the position

CAUTION: The most common failure in this topic is to write that "Cārvāka says nobody ever infers anything." That is not the doctrine, and the texts themselves block it.

FACT: Chatterjee and Datta record the Cārvāka's own concession: "It is true that in life we very often act unsuspectingly on inference. But that only shows that we act **uncritically** on the wrong belief that our inference is true. It is a fact that sometimes our inference comes true and leads to successful results. But it is also a fact that sometimes inference leads to error as well. **Truth is not then an unfailing character of all inferences; it is only an accident, and a separable one**, that we find only in some inferences."

CAUTION: **Unpack that last sentence, because it is the philosophical hinge of the whole topic.**

For inference to be a PRAMANA (means of valid knowledge), truth would have to be an ESSENTIAL and INSEPARABLE character of the inferential process.

But truth attaches to SOME inferences and not to others.

=> truth is ACCIDENTAL (agantuka) to inference, and SEPARABLE from it.

=> inference is not a truth-GUARANTEERING instrument.

...and yet people go on inferring, and often succeed.
The Carvaka does not deny THAT. He denies that success confers PRAMANA-STATUS.

FACT: The authored knowledge file records the same distinction under the heading <i>lokasiddha</i> or <i>laukika</i> inference: practical, corrigible, worldly inference tied to future perceptual confirmation is tolerated; transcendental inference — from ritual to unseen merit, from world to God, from body to soul — is the real target, because nothing could ever check it perceptually.		
Axis	Everyday (<i>laukika</i> (ordinary or worldly) / <i>vyāvahārika</i> (practical or conventional level)) inference	Transcendental (<i>alaukika</i> (extraordinary or non-ordinary) / <i>pāramārthika</i> (ultimate level)) inference
Example	Smoke on a hill, so probably fire; dark clouds, so probably rain	Ritual now, so heaven later; world exists, so God made it
Corrigibility	FACT: Can be checked by later perception	CAUTION: In principle uncheckable
Cārvāka (Indian materialist and perception-centred school) attitude	CAUTION: Tolerated as practical habit; denied <i>pramāṇa</i> (<i>means of valid knowledge</i>)-status	FACT: Rejected outright
What the exam wants	The distinction stated in one sentence	The target of the critique identified correctly



4. Why *śabda* (verbal testimony) falls — the argument in five steps

FACT: Chatterjee and Datta give a compact and precise argument, worth reproducing as numbered steps:

- Testimony consists of **words** (*śabda*). Insofar as words are heard through our ears, they are **perceived** — and knowledge of words is therefore perceptual and quite valid.
- But insofar as those words *suggest or mean* things not within our perception, and aim at giving knowledge of unperceived objects, "they are not free from error and doubt."
- Reliance on an authority always proceeds through a suppressed inference. The believer's mind runs: "This authority should be accepted because it is reliable, and all reliable authority should be accepted."
- That is an inference. "Being based on inference, knowledge derived from verbal testimony or authority is **as precarious as inference**."
- Therefore testimony is not an *independent* source of knowledge.

FACT: **The special case of the Veda.** Chatterjee and Datta report the Cārvāka verdict without softening: "The authority of the Vedas ... is held in high esteem by many. But in reality the Vedas are the works of some cunning priests who earned their living by duping the ignorant and the credulous. With false hopes and promises the Vedas persuade men to perform Vedic rites, the only tangible benefit of which goes to the priests who officiate and enjoy the emoluments."

CAUTION: **Two distinctions to keep clean.**

(1) WORDS AS SOUNDS : perceived, and therefore fine.
WORDS AS EVIDENCE : not perceived, and therefore suspect.

(2) REJECTING TESTIMONY $\neq$ REJECTING COMMUNICATION.
Language can guide action; it cannot CERTIFY what it reports until perception catches up with it.

FACT: Sharma adds the reinforcing point that testimony cannot be used to rescue inference either: "if testimony proves *vyāpti*, inference would become dependent on testimony, and then **none would be able to infer anything by himself**." That reductio is worth a line in any answer on the rejection of inference.



5. Why *upamāna* (comparison or analogy), *arthāpatti* (postulation or presumption) and *anupalabdhi* (non-cognition used to know absence) fall too

CAUTION: Cārvāka's argument is a single template applied repeatedly, and stating the template is more impressive than listing the *pramāṇas*.

<i>Pramāṇa</i> (means of valid knowledge)	Its claim	The Cārvāka (Indian materialist and perception-centred school) template applied
Upamāna (comparison or analogy) (Nyāya (school of logic and epistemology))	From "the <i>gavaya</i> resembles the cow" plus later sight of the animal, one knows the word's referent	CAUTION: The similarity is perceived; the <i>linkage of name to kind</i> is a generalisation reaching beyond what is perceived, hence inferential and insecure
Arthāpatti (postulation or presumption) (Mīmāṃsā (Vedic exegesis school))	Devadatta is fat, yet does not eat by day; therefore he eats by night	CAUTION: A postulation to remove an inconsistency — but the postulated fact is unperceived, and the necessity of the postulation is itself a generalisation
Anupalabdhi (non-cognition used to know absence) (Bhāṭṭa, Advaita)	Non-apprehension of the jar yields knowledge of its absence	CAUTION: Requires the rule "if it existed here it would have been perceived", which is a universal not given in any single perception

CAUTION: **The template in one line, for the answer script:** *every candidate pramāṇa other than perception depends on a universal proposition, and no universal proposition is perceived.* That single sentence disposes of the whole list and shows the examiner you understand the structure rather than the catalogue.



6. What the position buys, and what it costs		
	Strength FACT:	Cost CAUTION:
Epistemic	An austere, honest criterion; no unfalsifiable postulates	Knowledge shrinks to the present-and-perceived; science and history become impossible as <i>knowledge</i>
Ontological	No inflated metaphysics; explanatory economy	Cannot account for micro-entities, other minds or the past
Religious	Immunity to priestly manipulation and unverifiable promises	Loses any account of moral order beyond prudence
Dialectical	Forces every rival to justify each additional <i>pramāṇa</i> (means of valid knowledge)	Invites the self-refutation charge (Subtopic 3)



Exam link
Route this foundation into 2019 Q5(c), 2021 Q5(e) and 2025 Q5(a): define <i>pratyakṣaika-pramāṇavāda</i> , distinguish certainty from practical expectation, and derive the rejection of testimony and transcendence.



Traps and recap



UPSC traps
• CAUTION: Do not write "Cārvāka accepts only perception and ordinary experience" as if these were two things. Ordinary experience is admitted <i>as</i> perception.
• FACT: Do not forget internal perception. Its admission is what makes Cārvāka a materialist about consciousness rather than a denier of consciousness.
• CAUTION: Do not say Cārvāka rejects language or communication. It rejects testimony's claim to <i>independent pramāṇa-status</i> .

- CAUTION: Do not list the rejected *pramāṇas* without giving the single template that rejects them all: each rests on an unperceived universal.
- CAUTION: Do not attribute the *vyāvahārika* / *pāramārthika* level-distinction to Cārvāka as a historical doctrine. Sharma's point is precisely that Cārvāka lacks it; offering it is a philosophical *repair*, and it must be labelled as such.
- CAUTION: Do not confuse the Cārvāka's demand ("no doubt whatever, and true to reality") with modern fallibilist standards. The strength of the demand is what drives the entire critique.
- CAUTION: Do not say the Vedas are rejected "because they are old" or "because they are religious". They are rejected because their authority cannot be perceptually certified and their content promises the unperceivable.



- Revision notes
- FACT: *Pratyakṣaika-pramāṇavāda*: perception alone is a *pramāṇa*; everything else in the system follows logically from this.
 - FACT: Chatterjee and Datta: "The entire philosophy of the Cārvākas may be said to depend logically on their epistemology."
 - FACT: The Cārvāka's test for *pramāṇa*-hood: knowledge "about which we can have no doubt" and "which must be true to reality".
 - FACT: Both **external** and **internal** perception are admitted; consciousness is perceived, an immaterial soul is not.
 - FACT: Cārvāka denies the *inference* from consciousness to a soul, not consciousness itself.
 - FACT: "Truth is not an unfailing character of all inferences; it is only an accident, and a **separable** one."
 - CAUTION: Distinguish *laukika* (corrigible, practical) from *pāramārthika* (uncheckable, transcendental) inference; the second is the real target.
 - FACT: *Śabda* in five steps: words heard are perceived -> what they *mean* is unperceived -> acceptance runs through a reliability inference -> inference is precarious -> testimony is not independent.
 - FACT: Sharma's reductio: if testimony proved *vyāpti*, "none would be able to infer anything by himself".
 - FACT: The Veda is rejected as the work of "cunning priests" whose promises benefit only the officiants — an epistemic charge with a sociological edge.
 - CAUTION: The single template that kills *upamāna*, *arthāpatti* and *anupalabdhi*: each needs an unperceived universal.
 - CAUTION: Sharma's charge: Cārvāka accepts perception and rejects inference **from the same standpoint**, lacking the *saṃvṛti/paramārtha* or *vyāvahārika/pāramārthika* distinction that saves Śūnyavāda and Advaita.



3. The Critique of Inference — *Vyāpti* (invariable concomitance), *Upādhi* (hidden limiting condition), the Socrates Syllogism and Self-Refutation

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: The Cārvāka (Indian materialist school) critique argues that inference cannot establish certainty because *vyāpti* (invariable concomitance) cannot be universally known without circular inference and may always be defeated by an undiscovered *upādhi* (hidden limiting condition).



Plain-language visual - why smoke may mislead

Observed many times: SMOKE -> FIRE
|
v
Hidden condition may exist: wet fuel / special cause
|
v
So "all smoke has fire" is not guaranteed merely by past cases

In simple words: inference needs a universal link called *vyāpti*. Cārvāka asks how anyone can inspect every past, present, future and distant case. A hidden condition (*upādhi*) may explain why the relation held in observed cases but fail elsewhere.

Term	Easy meaning
Vyāpti (invariable concomitance)	Exceptionless relation used by inference
Upādhi (hidden limiting condition)	Hidden condition that limits an apparently universal rule
Induction	Moving from observed cases to a universal rule
Deduction	Applying that universal rule to a particular case

One-line memory: if induction cannot secure the universal premise, deduction cannot rescue the conclusion.



VISUAL: VISUAL — The three-door trap: how *vyāpti* (invariable concomitance) is cornered

EVERY INFERENCE NEEDS A UNIVERSAL: "wherever smoke, there fire"
(VYAPTI (invariable concomitance))
|
How could that universal be KNOWN?
|
+-----+-----+-----+
| | |
DOOR 1: PRATYAKSA (perception) DOOR 2: ANUMANA (inference) DOOR 3: SABDA (verbal testimony)
| | |
"perceive all "infer the vyapti (invariable concomitance)" "an authority says so"
cases of smoke | |
and fire" | |
| | |
IMPOSSIBLE: CIRCULAR: DOUBLY FATAL:
past, future, that inference (a) sabda (verbal testimony)'s own validity
distant cases needs ANOTHER is unproved;
are never given vyapti (invariable concomitance) -> regress (b) if inference rested on
| / petitio principii testimony, NO ONE could
| | infer anything BY HIMSELF
+-----+-----+-----+
|
v
VYAPTI (invariable concomitance) IS NEVER SECURED
|
v
ANUMANA (inference) IS NOT A PRAMANA (means of valid knowledge) (a truth-guaranteeing means)

CAUTION: **Caption.** Draw this in the answer booklet. Three doors, all shut — that is the entire 2025 ten-marker, and the spine of the 2018, 2019 and 2022 questions. Notice that Door 3 is shut *twice*, and the second bolt (Sharma's "none would be able to infer anything by himself") is the one most candidates miss.



1. The doctrine, stated exactly

FACT: **Thesis.** *Anumāna* is not a *pramāṇa*, because inference is "a mere leap in the dark" (Sharma): we proceed from the known to the unknown, and there is no certainty in this, "though some inferences may turn out to be **accidentally** true."

FACT: **The structural point.** Inference is a movement from a perceived mark (*liṅga*, e.g. smoke) to an unperceived *sādhya* (e.g. fire), licensed by an invariable concomitance (*vyāpti*) between them. Chatterjee and Datta present the Naiyāyika's own fuller statement of the inference — "all cases of smoke are cases of fire; this mountain is a case of smoke; therefore this is a case of fire" — and then locate the Cārvāka attack precisely: the argument "would be acceptable only if the **major premise**, stating the invariable relation between the middle term and the major, were beyond doubt."

CAUTION: **The move to memorise.** The Cārvāka never attacks the *form* of the inference. He grants that if the major premise were secure the conclusion would follow. He attacks the **licence** — the universal proposition that makes the movement legitimate. This is why the correct one-line statement of the doctrine is: *the Cārvāka critique of inference is a critique of the grounding of vyāpti, not of syllogistic validity.*



2. Door 1 — *vyāpti* (invariable concomitance) cannot be established by perception

FACT: Chatterjee and Datta: "this invariable relation (*vyāpti*) can be established only if we have a knowledge of **all** cases of smoke and presence of fire. This, however, is not possible, as we cannot perceive even all the cases of smoke and fire existing **now** in different parts of the world, to speak nothing of those which existed in the **past** or will exist in the **future**."

```
OBSERVED SET UNIVERSAL CLAIMED
-----
[ kitchen fire ] ALL smoke, everywhere,
[ hill fire ] ---- ? ----> at every time, past,
[ hearth fire ] present and future
[ ...n cases ]
finite, present, infinite, temporally
local, contingent unbounded, exceptionless
|
+--> the gap here is not a gap of DEGREE. It is a gap of KIND.
```

FACT: **The class-character (*sāmānya*) rejoinder, and the Cārvāka's answer. **This is the sharpest exchange in the topic and almost no candidate reproduces it. The Naiyāyika-style objector says: granted we cannot perceive all individual smokes, but can we not perceive the** class-characters** "smokeness" (*dhūmatva*) and "fireness" (*vahnitva*), and perceive a relation *between the universals*, and thereby license the inference?

FACT: Chatterjee and Datta record the Cārvāka's two-part reply verbatim in substance:

- Even granting perception of a relation between smokeness and fireness, "we cannot know therefrom any invariable relation between **all individual cases** of smoke and fire. To be able to infer a **particular** fire, we must know that it is inseparably related to the **particular** smoke perceived."
- Worse, "it is not possible even to **know by perception** what 'smokeness' ... is, because we do not perceive all cases of smoke."

CAUTION: **What this exchange really shows.** The Cārvāka refuses to let the Naiyāyika escape the particular–universal gap by relocating it in the universals: the same finitude that blocks the enumeration of instances blocks the perceptual grasp of the class-character. Chatterjee and Datta conclude for him: "the difficulty of passing from particulars to the universal, therefore, remains here as before."



3. Door 2 — *vyāpti* (invariable concomitance) cannot be established by inference

FACT: Chatterjee and Datta: "Neither can it be said to be based on another inference, because it will involve a **petitio principii**, since the validity of that inference again has to be similarly proved."

FACT: Sharma sharpens the same point into a pair:

DEDUCTION : "All men are mortal; Socrates is a man; so Socrates is mortal."
The conclusion is ALREADY CONTAINED in the major premise.
=> petitio principii, an argument in a circle.

INDUCTION : offered to establish the major premise.
But induction "proceeds unwarrantedly from the known to the unknown."
=> the major premise is never secured.

RESULT : "Induction is uncertain and deduction is argument in a circle.
The logicians, therefore, find themselves stuck up in the mud of inference." (Sharma, quoting the Carvaka gibe)

CAUTION: **Why this is not merely a dilemma but a trap.** Each horn is repaired only by the other. Deduction's circularity is cured by grounding the major premise inductively; induction's insecurity is cured by grounding it deductively. The Cārvāka's point is that the two cures are the same wound seen from two directions.

FACT: Chatterjee and Datta add the causal variant, which candidates often think is a way out: "can we not base our knowledge of the invariable relation between smoke and fire on a **causal** relation between them?" The Cārvāka reply: "a causal relation, being only a kind of invariable relation, cannot be established by perception owing to the same difficulties."



4. Door 3 — *vyāpti* (invariable concomitance) cannot be established by testimony

FACT: Two independent bolts, and both should appear in a 15-marker:

- FACT: "Nor can this *vyāpti* be based on the testimony (*śabda*) of reliable persons ... For, the validity of testimony **itself requires to be proved by inference**" (Chatterjee and Datta). Grounding inference in testimony and testimony in inference is a closed circle.
- FACT: "Besides, if inference always depended on testimony, **no one could infer anything by himself**" (Chatterjee and Datta; Sharma states the same reductio). Inference is manifestly a first-person cognitive capacity; making it parasitic on the word of another misdescribes what inference is.



5. The *upādhi* (hidden limiting condition) problem — the deepest cut

FACT: **Statement.** Even where two things are repeatedly observed together, an unnoticed condition (*upādhi*) may be doing the work; so observed constancy never establishes *unconditional* concomitance.

FACT: **The textbook example, exactly as Chatterjee and Datta give it** — and note that it runs in the direction most candidates get backwards:

A man perceives fire accompanied by smoke, many times.
On another occasion he perceives FIRE and infers SMOKE.
~~~~ ~~~~~

He is liable to ERROR.

Why? Because he failed to notice a CONDITION (upadhi (hidden limiting condition)):  
WETNESS OF FUEL -- on the presence of which ALONE fire is  
attended with smoke.

The relation "fire -> smoke" holds only ARDRENDHANA-SAMYOGA-SAHITE,  
i.e. where fire is joined with wet fuel. A red-hot iron ball is  
fire WITHOUT smoke.

FACT: Chatterjee and Datta draw the general conclusion: "So long as the relation between two phenomena is not proved to be **unconditional**, it is an uncertain ground for inference. And unconditionality or **absence of conditions cannot be established beyond doubt by perception, as some conditions may always remain hidden and escape notice**. Inference or testimony cannot be used for proving this unconditionality without a *petitio principii*, because its validity also is being questioned here."

CAUTION: \*\*Why the *upādhi* argument is stronger than the enumeration argument.\*\* The enumeration argument says: you have not checked enough cases. The *upādhi* argument says: **even if you had checked every case you can check, you could not know that you had identified the right property as the ground of the relation**. The first is a problem of quantity; the second is a problem of the *identification of the relevant variable*. Nyāya can answer the first with more observation. It cannot answer the second with more observation alone — which is why it must bring in *tarka* (Subtopic 4).



## 7. The self-refutation charge (2018, 2019, 2022) — and the Cārvāka (Indian materialist and perception-centred school)'s replies

FACT: **The charge, in its strongest form**. Sharma states it without mercy: "To refuse the validity of inference from the empirical standpoint is to refuse to think and discuss. All thoughts, all discussions, all doctrines, all affirmations and denials, all proofs and disproofs are made possible by inference. The Cārvāka view that perception is valid and inference is invalid **is itself a result of inference**. The Cārvāka can understand others only through inference and make others understand him only through inference. Thoughts and ideas, not being material objects, cannot be perceived; they can only be inferred. Hence the self-refuted Cārvāka position is called sheer nonsense and no system of philosophy."

CAUTION: Reconstructed as numbered steps, because the examiner wants the logic and not the invective:

1. The Carvaka asserts: "No inference is a valid source of knowledge."
2. That assertion is UNIVERSAL. It quantifies over all inferential acts, past, present and future.
3. No universal proposition is given in any single perception.
4. Therefore the thesis is either (a) itself inferential -- and so self-defeating -- or (b) not knowledge by its own standard.
5. Further: to REFUTE Nyaya (school of logic and epistemology), the Carvaka must reason. To be UNDERSTOOD, he must rely on his hearers inferring his meaning from his words.
6. Further still: other MINDS are never perceived. The Carvaka's very act of arguing with an opponent presupposes an inference to another mind.

CAUTION: **The Cārvāka's three available replies — a strong answer gives all three and grades them.**

| Reply                                                                                                | Formulation                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                   | Assessment                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                    |
|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| **R1 — The "no thesis" or <i>vitaṇḍā</i> (destructive disputation without a positive thesis) reply** | The Cārvāka (Indian materialist and perception-centred school) advances no positive doctrine; he only <i>destroys</i> the opponent's claim to certainty, using the opponent's own standards. A purely destructive dialectic incurs no commitments.                                            | CAUTION: Coherent, but it converts Cārvāka (Indian materialist and perception-centred school) from a philosophy into a method — and Cārvāka (Indian materialist and perception-centred school) <i>does</i> assert four elements, a body-self and <i>kāma</i> (pleasure or desire) as the end, so it cannot be a global reply. |
| R2 — The softened-thesis reply                                                                       | The thesis is not "no one ever infers" but "inference never yields <b>apodictic certainty</b> beyond what perception can check". As a claim about certainty rather than usability, it is not refuted by the fact that the Cārvāka (Indian materialist and perception-centred school) reasons. | CAUTION: The strongest reply. It is the reading the authored knowledge file endorses, and it rescues consistency at the price of weakening the doctrine into radical fallibilism.                                                                                                                                             |
| R3 — The level-distinction reply                                                                     | Concede <i>vyāvahārika</i> (practical or conventional level) validity to inference and deny only <i>pāramārthika</i> (ultimate level) validity.                                                                                                                                               | CAUTION: Effective against Sharma's "same standpoint" charge, but the level-distinction is, as Sharma says, "unknown to the Cārvāka (Indian materialist and perception-centred school)" — so it is a repair offered by the interpreter, and must be labelled as such.                                                         |

CAUTION: **The verdict to write.** Against the uncompromising formulation the self-refutation charge is decisive; against the softened formulation it loses its force but so does the doctrine, which becomes a fallibilist warning rather than a denial of a *pramāṇa*. The Cārvāka can be consistent or radical, but not both. That sentence answers 2019 Q5(c) almost by itself.



8. Sharma's counter-attack on perception — the tu quoque

FACT: Sharma turns the Cārvāka's weapon around: "Perception itself which is regarded as valid by the Cārvāka is **often found untrue**. We perceive the earth as flat but it is almost round. We perceive the earth as static but it is moving round the sun. We perceive the disc of the sun as of a small size, but it is much bigger than the size of the earth. Such perceptual knowledge is **contradicted by inference**."

FACT: And the constructive half, which is really a Kantian point made in an Indian idiom: "pure perception in the sense of mere sensation cannot be regarded as a means of knowledge unless conception or thought has arranged into order and has given meaning and significance to the loose threads of sense-data." Sharma cites the Buddhist *Tattvasaṅgraha* for this line of attack.

CAUTION: **Why this is devastating and must be handled, not avoided.** If perception is fallible *and* is corrected by inference, then the very hierarchy Cārvāka asserts is inverted: inference becomes the tribunal before which perception is judged. A 15- or 20-mark answer that reproduces the Cārvāka case without meeting this rejoinder is one-sided.

CAUTION: **Best Cārvāka response available:** the errors Sharma lists are corrected by **further perception plus practical checking**, not by pure inference — and a fallibilist Cārvāka can concede correction within perception while still denying that any *unperceivable* entity is established by it. That reply is decent for the flat-earth case and weak for the heliocentric case, and you should say so.



Exam link

Primary routes: 2019 Q5(c), 2019 Q6(c) and 2025 Q5(a). Reconstruct *vyāpti* through the three-door argument, add *upādhi*, then face self-refutation.



Traps and recap



UPSC traps



- CAUTION: Do not write that the Cārvāka says the syllogism is **invalid**. He says the major premise is ungrounded, and that deduction is therefore circular.
- FACT: Do not give the *upādhi* example backwards. The standard case is inferring **smoke from fire**, which fails because the *upādhi* of **wet fuel** was unnoticed.
- CAUTION: Do not omit the *sāmānya* / class-character exchange. It is the difference between a textbook answer and a top answer.
- CAUTION: Do not present the self-refutation charge without the Cārvāka's replies. A one-sided demolition scores poorly on "critically examine".
- CAUTION: Do not claim all inference is literally impossible for the Cārvāka. Distinguish *pramāṇa*-status from everyday expectation and practical action.
- CAUTION: Do not forget Door 3's second bolt: if inference rested on testimony, no one could infer anything by himself.
- CAUTION: Do not ignore Sharma's *tu quoque* about perceptual error. Meeting it is what "critically evaluate" means.
- CAUTION: Do not treat the causal-relation escape as untouched. A causal relation is itself a species of invariable relation and inherits the same problem.



Revision notes

- FACT: Inference is "a leap in the dark"; some inferences are true only "accidentally".
- FACT: The attack is on the **major premise** (*vyāpti*), never on syllogistic form.
- FACT: **Door 1 (perception)**: all cases past, present and future can never be surveyed.
- FACT: **Class-character reply**: even *dhūmatva* and *vahnitva* cannot be perceptually known, since all instances are not perceived; and universal-to-universal relation does not license a particular-to-particular inference.
- FACT: **Door 2 (inference)**: *petitio principii* or infinite regress; deduction is circular, induction unwarranted.
- FACT: Causal relation is only a species of invariable relation and inherits the same defect.
- FACT: **Door 3 (testimony)**: testimony's validity is itself inferred; and "if inference always depended on testimony, no one could infer anything by himself."
- FACT: **Upādhi**: the wet-fuel condition; unconditionality can never be perceptually certified because conditions may remain hidden.
- FACT: *Upādhi* is a problem of the *right variable*, not merely of *sample size* — which is why more observation alone cannot answer it.
- FACT: **Self-refutation**: the universal denial of inference is itself a universal; and other minds, thoughts and ideas are never perceived.
- CAUTION: **Three replies**: no-thesis (*vitaṇḍā*) · softened certainty-thesis · level-distinction. The second is strongest; the third is a repair, not a historical doctrine.
- CAUTION: **\*\*Sharma's *tu quoque*\*\*** flat earth, static earth, small sun — perception errs and is corrected *by inference*.
- CAUTION: **Verdict formula**: the Cārvāka may be consistent or radical, but not both.



4. The Nyāya (school of logic and epistemology) Defence of Inference — and a Critically Balanced Verdict

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Nyāya (school of logic and realism) replies that repeated observation, agreement and difference, tarka (hypothetical reasoning) and the elimination of upādhi (hidden limiting conditions) justify defeasible but rationally warranted inference.



Plain-language visual - Nyaya (school of logic and epistemology)'s repair workshop

Repeated agreement: where smoke, there fire (anvaya (positive agreement in presence))  
Repeated absence: where no fire, no smoke (vyatireka (negative agreement in absence))  
Search for hidden conditions (upadhi (hidden limiting condition) test)  
Reject absurd alternatives (tarka (hypothetical or reductio reasoning))  
Apply the tested rule to this hill (paramarsa)

In simple words: Nyāya does not claim that one casual observation proves a universal rule. It builds confidence through positive cases, negative cases, elimination of hidden conditions and rational testing. The final inference occurs when the tested universal relation is applied to the present case.

| Cārvāka (Indian materialist and perception-centred school) challenge | Nyāya (school of logic and epistemology) reply                                                                                        |
|----------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| You have not seen every case                                         | Universal features and systematic observation matter                                                                                  |
| A hidden condition may exist                                         | Actively search for and eliminate <i>upādhis</i> (plural form: hidden limiting condition)                                             |
| Inference is circular                                                | <i>Tarka</i> (hypothetical or reductio reasoning) and repeated agreement/disagreement support <i>vyāpti</i> (invariable concomitance) |

One-line memory: Nyāya answers "blind generalisation" with a disciplined method of testing.



VISUAL: VISUAL — How Nyāya (school of logic and epistemology) actually builds a *vyāpti* (invariable concomitance), step by step

STAGE 1 BHUYODARSANA (repeated observation)  
+-----+  
| ANVAYA (positive agreement in presence) : wherever smoke, there fire| positive co-presence  
| VYATIREKA (negative agreement in absence) : where no fire, no smoke | negative co-absence  
+-----+  
|  
STAGE 2 UPADHI-SANKA-NIRASA (elimination of suspected conditions)  
"is there a hidden qualifier making the relation conditional?"  
test each candidate: wet fuel? time? place? -> discard those  
that do not survive joint presence/absence testing  
|  
STAGE 3 TARKA (hypothetical or reductio reasoning) (hypothetical/reductio reasoning)  
"SUPPOSE smoke occurred without fire.  
Then an effect would occur without its cause.  
Then ANY effect could occur from ANY cause.  
Then all practical life and all cognition collapse.  
The supposition is therefore untenable."  
-> tarka (hypothetical or reductio reasoning) does not PROVE vyapti (invariable concomitance); it REMOVES the doubt that blocks it  
|  
STAGE 4 SAMANYALAKSANA-PRATYAKSA (extraordinary perception of the universal)  
through the perceived particular smoke, smokeness itself is  
presented -- giving cognitive access to the CLASS, not merely  
to the counted instances  
|  
STAGE 5 VYAPTIGRAHA (the universal is grasped) --> stored as knowledge  
|  
STAGE 6 LINGA-DARSANA : "there is smoke on that hill" (perception)  
STAGE 7 PARAMARSA : "this hill has smoke WHICH IS INVARIABLY  
ACCOMPANIED BY FIRE" <-- the operative cognition  
STAGE 8 ANUMITI (inferential cognition) : "this hill has fire" (inferential knowledge)

CAUTION: **Caption.** The Cārvāka argues as if *vyāpti* had to be acquired in one impossible act of total enumeration. Nyāya's reply is architectural: *vyāpti* is **assembled** through five distinguishable operations, and the burden of certainty is distributed across them. Reproducing this eight-stage ladder is the single most effective way to show an examiner that you understand what Cārvāka is actually up against.



## 1. Why Nyāya (school of logic and epistemology) cannot simply concede

CAUTION: Nyāya is the school of *pramāṇa*-theory. If inference falls, then *upamāna* falls with it, *śabda* loses its warrant, the proofs of God (*kāryāt*, *āyōjanāt*, *dhṛtyādeḥ*, *padāt/śruteḥ*) collapse, the atomic theory becomes unstateable, and the Nyāya proofs of the self go with them. The Cārvāka attack is therefore not a peripheral irritant but an existential threat, which is why the Naiyāyika reply is so highly developed.



## 2. Anvaya (positive agreement in presence) and vyatireka (negative agreement in absence) — the joint method

FACT: **The doctrine.** *Vyāpti* is established by **bhūyodarśana**, repeated observation, but of a particular disciplined kind:

| Method              | Sanskrit                                       | Form                                                                                                    | Function                                             |
|---------------------|------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------|
| Method of agreement | <b>anvaya (positive agreement in presence)</b> | Wherever <i>hetu</i> ( <i>reason or probans</i> ), there <i>sādhya</i> ( <i>property to be proved</i> ) | Establishes positive co-presence across varied cases |

| Method               | Sanskrit                                                             | Form                                                                                  | Function                                                                 |
|----------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Method of difference | vyatireka (negative agreement in absence)                            | Wherever sādhya (property to be proved) is absent, hetu (reason or probans) is absent | Rules out cases where the mark occurs without the probandum              |
| Joint method         | anvaya-vyatireka (joint method of agreement in presence and absence) | Both together                                                                         | The absence of a single counter-instance across wide, varied observation |

CAUTION: **The philosophical point to make explicit.** The Cārvāka treats repeated observation as mere counting. Nyāya treats it as **structured testing**: it is not the number of positive cases that matters but the survival of the relation through deliberate search for **negative** cases. A relation that survives systematic attempts to find *hetu*-without-*sādhya* has a warrant that a mere tally does not.



3. Upādhi (hidden limiting condition)-elimination — meeting the Cārvāka (Indian materialist and perception-centred school)'s strongest weapon

FACT: **The Nyāya procedure.** An *upādhi* is defined technically as a condition that pervades the *sādhya* but does not pervade the *hetu*. To test a suspected relation, the Naiyāyika asks whether any such condition can be found; where one is found, the *vyāpti* is reformulated to include it.

BAD VYAPTI (invariable concomitance) : "wherever fire, there smoke"  
UPADHI (hidden limiting condition) FOUND: wet fuel (ardra-indhana)  
REPAIR : "wherever fire joined with wet fuel, there smoke"  
RESULT : the conditional relation is not abandoned -- it is  
RESTATED at the correct level of generality.

CAUTION: **The concession Nyāya must make, and an honest answer states it.** Nyāya can eliminate *suspected* and *known upādhis*. It cannot demonstrate that **no upādhi** whatever remains undetected. What it claims instead is that a relation which survives systematic testing, negative-case search and *tarka* is **rationally warranted**, not that it is guaranteed by an omniscient survey.

CAUTION: **The move that decides the debate.** Nyāya shifts the standard from **impossible omniscience** to **disciplined rational warrant**. The Cārvāka has set a bar — indubitability plus correspondence — that nothing except present perception could clear, and even present perception clears it only if perceptual error is ignored. Nyāya's reply is that this bar is not a criterion of knowledge but a recipe for its abolition.



4. Tarka (hypothetical or reductio reasoning) — the argument the Cārvāka (Indian materialist and perception-centred school) has no answer to

FACT: **\*\*What tarka is.\*\*** *Tarka* is hypothetical reasoning, *reductio ad absurdum*: it assumes the contradictory of the proposed relation and exhibits the unacceptable consequence. It is expressly **not** an independent *pramāṇa* in Nyāya; it is a *pramāṇa-anugrahaka* — an auxiliary that removes doubt so that *vyāptigraha* can occur.

SUPPOSE : smoke without fire  
THEN : an effect exists without its cause  
THEN : the causal order is arbitrary  
THEN : no expectation, no action, no discourse, no refutation  
BUT : the Carvaka HIMSELF acts, expects, argues and refutes  
THEREFORE: the supposition is untenable (anista-prasanga)

CAUTION: **Why this is so powerful against Cārvāka specifically.** The Cārvāka concedes that people act on inference and that action often succeeds. *Tarka* converts that concession into a premise: the intelligibility of the Cārvāka's own practice — including the practice of arguing against Nyāya — presupposes the very regularities he refuses to certify. The Cārvāka can escape only by retreating to the softened thesis (Subtopic 3, reply R2), at which point the dispute becomes verbal rather than doctrinal.



5. *Sāmānyalakṣaṇa-pratyakṣa* (extraordinary perception of a universal character) — Nyāya (school of logic and epistemology)’s direct answer to the class-character objection

FACT: **The doctrine.** Nyāya admits an extraordinary (*alaukika*) perception in which, through a perceived particular, the **universal** itself is presented — smokeness through this smoke. The authored Nyāya file records the trap explicitly: it is an error to say that universals are not perceived in Nyāya; they are, through *sāmānyalakṣaṇa-pratyakṣa*.

CAUTION: **The exchange, laid out for the answer script:**

| Move                                                                 | Claim                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                 |
|----------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Cārvāka (Indian materialist and perception-centred school)           | FACT: You cannot perceive all smokes; therefore you cannot perceive smokeness; therefore you have no universal                                                                                                                                                        |
| Nyāya (school of logic and epistemology)                             | FACT: The universal is not reached by adding up particulars; it is <b>presented in</b> any particular through extraordinary perception                                                                                                                                |
| Cārvāka (Indian materialist and perception-centred school) rejoinder | CAUTION: <i>Sāmānyalakṣaṇa</i> (universal character) is a technical device invented precisely to plug the hole; it is theory-laden, not independently attested                                                                                                        |
| Assessment                                                           | CAUTION: Honest verdict: the device does real work inside Nyāya (school of logic and epistemology)’s realism about universals, but it will not convince anyone who does not already accept that realism. The debate here bottoms out in ontology, not in epistemology |



6. *Parāmarśa* (reflective cognition linking the sign with the universal relation) — what actually generates the inferential cognition

FACT: **The doctrine.** In Nyāya, inferential knowledge (*anumiti*) is produced by a specific operative cognition (*karāṇa*) called **parāmarśa**: the cognition of the mark *as qualified by* its invariable concomitance — "this hill possesses smoke, which is invariably accompanied by fire."

CAUTION: **Why this matters against Cārvāka.** The Cārvāka pictures inference as a **leap** across a gap: from perceived smoke, jump to unperceived fire. Nyāya’s analysis denies that there is any leap at all. What produces the conclusion is a single complex cognition in which the mark is *already* apprehended under the concomitance. There is no moment at which the mind is stranded between premises with a chasm to cross.

CAUTION: **A memorable line for the answer:** *For Cārvāka, inference is a jump in the dark; for Nyāya, it is a step taken in the light of a concomitance already grasped.*



7. The Nyāya (school of logic and epistemology) counter-attack on perception

FACT: Sharma reports this as the decisive counter-move, and it was set out in Subtopic 3 §8: perception itself errs — the flat earth, the static earth, the small solar disc — "such perceptual knowledge is contradicted by **inference**." And, following the *Tattvasaṅgraha*, "pure perception in the sense of mere sensation cannot be regarded as a means of knowledge unless **conception or thought** has arranged into order and has given meaning and significance to the loose threads of sense-data."

CAUTION: **The structural result, and it is a genuine reversal:**

CARVAKA'S PICTURE NYAYA (school of logic and epistemology)'S CORRECTED PICTURE  
-----  
perception = certain perception = fallible, and CORRECTED by inference  
inference = derivative inference = the tribunal that corrects perception  
| |  
hierarchy: P > I hierarchy: neither is self-sufficient;  
perception supplies content,  
inference supplies order and correction

CAUTION: **Note the Nyāya distinction that keeps this honest:** Nyāya distinguishes **nirvikalpaka** (indeterminate, pre-predicative) from **savikalpaka** (determinate, qualified) perception. Only determinate perception is judgemental — and determinate perception already involves conceptual qualification. The Cārvāka's "pure given" is therefore, on the Nyāya analysis, either pre-cognitive and useless, or already conceptually shaped and therefore not the innocent bedrock he supposes.



Exam link

Primary route: 2018 Q8(b); cross-link 2022 Q7(c). Answer all three limbs: rejection by other schools, their reasons, and a criterion-named verdict on whether they are justified.



Traps and recap



UPSC traps

- CAUTION: Do not say Nyāya "proves" *vyāpti* with certainty. It claims disciplined warrant and eliminates *suspected* conditions.
- CAUTION: Do not call *tarka* a *pramāṇa*. It is *pramāṇa-anugrāhaka*, an auxiliary that removes doubt.
- FACT: Do not write that Nyāya denies the perception of universals. It affirms it through *sāmānyalakṣaṇa-pratyakṣa*.
- CAUTION: Do not omit *parāmarśa*. Without it, you cannot explain why Nyāya denies that inference is a "leap" at all.
- CAUTION: Do not answer 2018 Q8(b) with only one school. The question says "the other systems" — plural — and asks for your own verdict as a third limb.
- CAUTION: Do not present Advaita as agreeing with Cārvāka about inference. Advaita's denial is at the *pāramārthika* level and applies to perception equally.
- CAUTION: Do not forget Nyāya's *nirvikalpaka* / *savikalpaka* distinction when replying to the "pure given" assumption.



Revision notes

- FACT: *Vyāpti* is built by **bhūyodarśana**, disciplined as **anvaya** (co-presence) and **vyatireka** (co-absence).
- FACT: **Upādhi**-elimination repairs a defective universal by restating it at the correct level of generality — "fire **with wet fuel**, there smoke".
- FACT: **Tarka** is hypothetical *reductio* reasoning; it is not a *pramāṇa* but removes the doubt blocking *vyāptigraha*.

- FACT: *Tarka*'s force against Cārvāka: his own acting, expecting and arguing presuppose the regularities he refuses to certify.
- FACT: **Sāmānyalakṣaṇa-pratyakṣa** answers the class-character objection by presenting the universal through the particular.
- FACT: **Parāmarśa** — the cognition of the mark as qualified by concomitance — is the *karaṇa* of *anumiti*; hence no "leap".
- FACT: The eight-stage ladder: *bhūyodarśana* -> *upādhi*-elimination -> *tarka* -> *sāmānyalakṣaṇa* -> *vyāptigraha* -> *liṅga-darśana* -> *parāmarśa* -> *anumiti*.
- FACT: Sharma's counter-attack: perception errs (flat earth, static earth, small sun) and is corrected **by inference**.
- FACT: *Tattvasaṅgraha* point: mere sensation is not knowledge until conception orders "the loose threads of sense-data".
- CAUTION: Nyāya's decisive move: replace **omniscient certainty** with **disciplined warrant** as the standard for *pramāṇa*-hood.
- CAUTION: Honest residue: *tarka* proves nothing alone; *sāmānyalakṣaṇa* presupposes realism about universals; undetected *upādhis* cannot be excluded in principle.
- CAUTION: 2018 Q8(b) has **three** limbs — is it accepted, why not, and are the objectors justified. Answer all three.
- CAUTION: Verdict formula: Cārvāka loses the war and wins a battle — inference survives as warranted, not as indubitable.



5. Metaphysics and Materialism — Four *Bhūtas* (material elements), the Rejection of *Ākāśa* (ether or space as an element), and *Svabhāvavāda* (doctrine that natural properties explain events)

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Cārvāka (Indian materialist school) materialism holds that perceptible *bhūtas* (material elements) combine according to *svabhāva* (inherent nature) to produce the world, without requiring *ākāśa* (ether), a creator, or a supersensible cause.



Plain-language visual - matter first

EARTH + WATER + FIRE + AIR  
|  
organised combinations  
|  
body + senses + mind-like functions  
|  
consciousness emerges

AKASA (ether or space as an element) is excluded because it is not directly perceived.

In simple words: Cārvāka accepts four perceptible elements and explains bodies and consciousness through their combinations. Consciousness need not exist separately before matter, just as an intoxicating power appears when ingredients ferment together.

| Claim                                | Simple analogy                                    |
|--------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------|
| Consciousness emerges from matter    | Red colour appears when betel ingredients combine |
| No separate soul-substance is needed | The living body itself is conscious               |

| Claim                                   | Simple analogy                                           |
|-----------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------|
| No creator is needed                    | Natural properties and combinations explain formation    |
| No ākāśa (ether or space as an element) | It is inferred from sound rather than directly perceived |

One-line memory: organised matter produces life and consciousness; do not add an unseen substance without evidence.



VISUAL: VISUAL — The elemental ledger, and the one cell that is empty

PRTHIVI AP TEJAS VAYU AKASA (ether or space as an element)  
(earth) (water) (fire) (air) (ether/space)  
-----  
NYAYA-VAISESIKA Y Y Y Y Y (+ kala, dik,  
atman (enduring self or soul), manas (mind)  
= 9 dravyas (plural form: substance))  
SAMKHYA (dualistic enumeration school) Y Y Y Y Y (from tanmatras)  
JAINISM (pudgala covers matter) Y (akasa (ether or space as an element) is a  
separate dravya (substance))  
MIMAMSA (Vedic exegesis school) / VEDANTA (Upaniṣad-based end-of-the-Veda tradition) Y Y Y Y Y  
-----  
CARVAKA Y Y Y Y -- NO --  
^^^^^^  
the empty cell  
that carries the  
whole epistemology

CAUTION: **Caption.** One empty cell, and it is not an accident of cosmology. *Ākāśa* is refused for exactly the reason inference and testimony are refused: it is not perceived, it is **inferred**. The elemental ledger is therefore the neatest possible demonstration that Cārvāka metaphysics is epistemology applied. This visual answers the first half of the 2020 fifteen-marker on its own.



1. The bridging principle — ontology follows epistemology

FACT: Chatterjee and Datta state the derivation in a single sentence: "The Cārvāka theory of reality **follows from** the epistemological conclusion just discussed. If perception is the only reliable source of knowledge, we can rationally assert only the reality of perceptible objects. God, soul, heaven, life before birth or after death, and any unperceived law (like *adr̥ṣṭa*) cannot be believed in, because they are all beyond perception."

CAUTION: **The principle, formalised for the answer script:**

P1. Only perception is a pramana (means of valid knowledge). (epistemology)  
P2. Ontological commitment should not outrun the  
reach of the pramanas (plural form: means of valid knowledge) one accepts. (bridging principle)  
-----  
C. Only perceptible entities may be admitted as real. (ontology)

CAUTION: **P2 is doing enormous work and is rarely noticed by candidates.** It is not a truth of logic. An opponent could accept P1 and yet hold that reality exceeds knowledge — that there are unknowable realities. Cārvāka refuses that gap: for him, what cannot in principle be presented in perception has no claim to be admitted. Naming P2 explicitly, and observing that it is a *presupposition* rather than a proof, is exactly the kind of move that separates a 60% script from an 80% script.





2. The four *bhūtas* (material elements)

FACT: \*\*The transmitted *sūtra*: *pr̥thivyāptejovāyuriti tattvāni* — "earth, water, fire and air are the elements." And the second: *tatsamudāye śarīrendriya-viśaya-saṃjñā* — "bodies, senses and objects" are the results of the different combinations of these elements.

FACT: Chatterjee and Datta add the biological consequence explicitly: "Not only non-living material objects but also **living organisms**, like plants and animal bodies, are composed of these four elements, by the combination of which they are produced and to which they are **reduced on death**." There is no separate vital principle and no separate psychic substance.

FACT: Sharma adds the ontological refinement that many candidates miss: "**The elements are eternal, but their combinations undergo production and dissolution.**"

CAUTION: **This is a significant doctrinal point.** Cārvāka is not a philosophy of universal flux. The material elements are permanent; only configurations arise and perish. That gives Cārvāka a stable ontological substrate — and it is why the school is classified as a **realist** materialism rather than as a scepticism. It also sharpens the contrast with Buddhism (Subtopic 6) and with Jainism (Subtopic 8).



3. Why *ākāśa* (ether or space as an element) is rejected — the 2020 question's first half

FACT: **The argument, in four steps.**

- Earth, water, fire and air are each **perceptible**: they present themselves through manifest sensible qualities — solidity, fluidity, heat and light, motion and touch.
- Ākāśa* is **not** perceived as an entity. Chatterjee and Datta: the Cārvākas "reject ether, because its existence cannot be perceived; **it has to be inferred**." Sharma: "he rejects the fifth, the ether, because it is not perceived but inferred."
- The inference in question is the Nyāya-Vaiśeṣika one: sound (*śabda* as a quality) is a quality; every quality must inhere in a substance; sound is not a quality of earth, water, fire, air, *ātman*, *manas*, time or space; therefore there is a ninth-listed substance, *ākāśa*, as its unique substrate.
- Since inference is not a *pramāṇa*, that argument cannot establish anything. Hence the world is composed of **four** elements.

CAUTION: **The exchange in table form**, which is what a 15-marker needs:

| Move                                                             | Position                                                                                                                                                                                                                                       |
|------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Vaiśeṣika (school of categories and atomism)                     | FACT: Sound is heard; qualities require substrates; by elimination the substrate is <i>ākāśa</i> (ether or space as an element), which is one, eternal, all-pervading and imperceptible                                                        |
| Cārvāka (Indian materialist and perception-centred school)       | FACT: The hearing of sound is perceptual; the <i>substrate</i> is not. The move from quality to imperceptible substance is an inference and inherits the whole <i>vyāpti</i> (invariable concomitance) problem                                 |
| Vaiśeṣika (school of categories and atomism) rejoinder           | CAUTION: Then sound is left without a bearer, and the doctrine that qualities inhere in substances is broken                                                                                                                                   |
| Cārvāka (Indian materialist and perception-centred school) reply | CAUTION: Either sound is a state of the perceptible air-medium, or the demand for a bearer is itself a metaphysical prejudice; positing an imperceptible substrate is an unnecessary multiplication                                            |
| Assessment                                                       | CAUTION: The Cārvāka (Indian materialist and perception-centred school) is consistent, and the cost is real: he must either naturalise sound into the air or abandon the substance–quality framework that his own four-element realism assumes |

CAUTION: **The self-critical point that earns the highest marks on this question.** The Cārvāka accepts the four elements as *substances*. But if he accepts the substance–quality scheme for earth, water, fire and air, he cannot simply refuse it for sound without argument. His most defensible line is therefore **not** "qualities need no substrates" but "sound is a modification of perceptible air", which is a naturalising move rather than a sceptical one. Saying this shows you have thought past the textbook.



4. Consciousness from matter — *bhūta-caitanya-vāda* (doctrine that consciousness emerges from material elements)

FACT: **\*\*The transmitted sūtra:\*\*** *kiṃvādibhyo madaśaktivad vijñānam* — "consciousness [arises] from matter as the intoxicating power [arises] from fermenting agents."

FACT: **The problem the doctrine answers.** Chatterjee and Datta pose the objection sharply: "we do not perceive consciousness in **any** of the four material elements. How can it then come to qualify their product, the body?"

FACT: **The Cārvāka reply — the emergence thesis and its two canonical analogies.**

| Analogy                                                      | The ingredients                                                                              | The novel property                            | The point made                                                                                       |
|--------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>**Betel (<i>tāmbūla</i> (<i>betel preparation</i>))**</b> | Betel leaf, lime and areca nut — "none of which is originally red"                           | A reddish tinge, "when chewed together"       | A property may appear in a <b>combination</b> that is present in <b>no ingredient</b> separately     |
| <b>Fermentation</b>                                          | Molasses ( <i>guḍa</i> ( <i>molasses or fermenting sugar</i> )), "originally non-intoxicant" | Intoxicating power, "when allowed to ferment" | The <b>same substance</b> under a <b>different condition</b> may develop qualities originally absent |

FACT: Chatterjee and Datta draw the conclusion: "In a similar way, it is possible to think that the material elements combined in a particular way give rise to the conscious living body. **Consciousness is an epiphenomenon or bye-product of matter**; there is no evidence of its existence independent of the body." Sharma reports the same doctrine and quotes the striking Western formulation used of it: "Matter secretes mind as liver secretes bile."

CAUTION: **Read the two analogies carefully, because they are not the same argument.**

BETEL : combination of DIFFERENT ingredients -> new quality  
(structural / compositional emergence)

FERMENTATION: the SAME ingredient under a NEW CONDITION -> new quality  
(processual / transformational emergence)

Together they block two different objections:  
(i) "consciousness is in none of the elements" -> betel answers it  
(ii) "the elements are the same before and after" -> fermentation answers it

CAUTION: **The explanatory gap, stated honestly — and this is what distinguishes a philosophical answer from a report.** Both analogies establish that **novel observable qualities** can arise from combination. Consciousness, however, is not an observable third-person quality like redness or intoxicating power. It is the *condition of observation itself* — subjective, first-personal, and, as Sharma notes, **private** in a way redness is not: consciousness "is neither smelt nor tasted nor seen nor touched nor heard", and "consciousness of an individual cannot be shared by others". The analogies therefore establish emergence of the wrong logical type.

CAUTION: **The Cārvāka's best available reply**, which a fair answer must supply: positing an immaterial soul does not close the gap either — it **renames** it. To say "consciousness arises because there is a conscious substance" explains nothing that "consciousness arises from a specifically organised living body" does not; the dualist has bought a word, not an explanation. CAUTION: Assessment: the reply neutralises the dualist's claim to explanatory superiority without discharging the Cārvāka's own explanatory debt. Both sides face the gap; only one side pretends to have crossed it.



5. Why no God is needed — the pot-and-potter exchange and *svabhāvavāda* (doctrine that natural properties explain events)

FACT: **The objection, in Chatterjee and Datta's exact form.** "Can the material elements by themselves give rise to this wonderful world? We find that even the production of an object like an earthen jar requires, in addition to **clay** which is its **material cause**, a **potter** who is the **efficient cause**, that shapes the material into the desired form. The four elements supply only the material cause of the world. Do we not require an efficient cause, like God, as the shaper and designer?"

FACT: **The Cārvāka reply.** "The material elements themselves have got each its **fixed nature** (*svabhāva*). **It is by the natures and laws inherent in them that they combine together to form this world.** **There is thus no necessity for God.** There is no proof that the objects of the world are the products of any design.\*\* They can be explained more reasonably as the fortuitous products of the elements."

FACT: Chatterjee and Datta then supply the three technical labels, all of which should appear in a 10-marker on Cārvāka metaphysics:

| Label                     | Sanskrit                                                                 | Meaning                                                                                                             | Textbook wording                                                                                                                                                       |
|---------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Naturalism                | <i>svabhāvavāda</i><br>(doctrine that natural properties explain events) | The world is explained "only by nature"; things behave by their own inherent natures                                | FACT: "Insofar as this Cārvāka (Indian materialist and perception-centred school) theory tries to explain the world only by nature, it is sometimes called naturalism" |
| Mechanism / accidentalism | <i>yadr̥cchāvāda</i><br>(doctrine of chance or accidental occurrence)    | Denies conscious purpose behind the world; explains it as "a mere mechanical or fortuitous combination of elements" | FACT: "It is also called mechanism ( <i>yadr̥cchā-vāda</i> )"                                                                                                          |
| Positivism                | —                                                                        | Believes "only in positive facts or observable phenomena"                                                           | FACT: "The Cārvāka (Indian materialist and perception-centred school) theory on the whole may also be called <b>positivism</b> "                                       |

CAUTION: **Note carefully for the 2024 question:** the label "positivism" is not an examiner's invention or a modern imposition. It is applied to Cārvāka **by the standard textbook itself**, and with a stated reason. That is a decisive evidential point for Subtopic 9 and for the workbook's 2024 answer — although, as we shall see, the label still needs heavy qualification.

CAUTION: \*\*A refinement on *svabhāvavāda* that strengthens any answer.\*\* *Svabhāva* is invoked twice in Cārvāka, at two different points, and they must not be confused:

(1) EPISTEMOLOGICAL USE : "why is fire always hot and water cool?"  
-> because of their inherent natures; no supernatural principle is needed, AND "there is neither any guarantee that uniformity perceived in the past would continue in future."  
(Chatterjee & Datta)

(2) COSMOLOGICAL USE : "who arranged the world?"  
-> nothing did; the elements combine by their own natures; no designer is required.

CAUTION: Use (1) is a **deflationary** appeal: "nature" is a label for observed regularity, deliberately not an explanatory power, and the Cārvāka refuses to guarantee its persistence. Use (2) is a **substantive** appeal: nature is doing real cosmological work in place of God. The obvious objection — that "nature" is an empty word unless analysed — bites hard on use (2) and hardly at all on use (1). Separating them is the most sophisticated move available in this subtopic.



6. How many materialisms? Sadānanda's fourfold classification

| FACT: Sharma records, from Sadānanda's <i>Vedāntasāra</i> , that <b>four</b> different materialist schools were distinguished by their identification of the self:                                                                                                                                                                                              |                             |                                            |
|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------|--------------------------------------------|
| Variant                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                         | The self is identified with | Sanskrit                                   |
| 1                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                               | The gross body              | <i>sthūla śarīra (gross physical body)</i> |
| 2                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                               | The senses                  | <i>indriya (sense faculty)</i>             |
| 3                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                               | The vital breaths           | <i>prāṇa (vital breath)</i>                |
| 4                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                               | The mental organ            | <i>manas (mind)</i>                        |
| FACT: Sharma adds: "All the schools agree in regarding the soul as a <b>product of matter</b> ." He also records Śāntarakṣita's report that the materialist <i>Kambalāśvatara</i> held that consciousness arises out of the material body <b>associated with vital breaths</b> .                                                                                |                             |                                            |
| CAUTION: <b>Exam value</b> . This single table shows that "Cārvāka" names a <b>family</b> of materialist positions, not a monolith. It supports the source-caution of Subtopic 1, it forestalls the objection that the school was crude and undifferentiated, and it gives you a precise, citable internal differentiation almost no other candidate will have. |                             |                                            |



| Exam link                                                                                                                                                                                          |
|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Primary route: the first half of 2020 Q6(b). Derive four-element materialism and the rejection of <i>ākāśa</i> from the epistemic rule, then evaluate emergence without calling it modern science. |



| Traps and recap |
|-----------------|
|-----------------|



| UPSC traps                                                                                                                                                                        |
|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| • FACT: <b>Four elements, not five</b> . This is the single most examined factual trap in the topic.                                                                              |
| • FACT: Do not say Cārvāka "does not know of" <i>ākāśa</i> . He knows the Vaiśeṣika argument for it and rejects it, precisely because it is inferential.                          |
| • CAUTION: Do not say Cārvāka denies the reality of sound. He denies the inference from sound to an imperceptible substrate.                                                      |
| • CAUTION: Do not say the elements are impermanent. Sharma: "the elements are eternal, but their combinations undergo production and dissolution."                                |
| • CAUTION: Do not present the betel and fermentation analogies as one analogy. They answer two different objections — compositional and transformational emergence.               |
| • CAUTION: Do not claim the analogies solve the problem of consciousness. State the explanatory gap <b>and</b> the Cārvāka's reply that dualism merely renames it.                |
| • CAUTION: Do not translate <i>svabhāvavāda</i> as "scientific naturalism". It is a metaphysical refusal of teleology, not an experimental programme.                             |
| • CAUTION: Do not forget <i>yadr̥ccchāvāda</i> . The denial of purpose is a distinct thesis from the affirmation of inherent natures, and the two sit together somewhat uneasily. |
| • CAUTION: Do not treat "Cārvāka" as one uniform doctrine. The <i>Vedāntasāra</i> records four materialist identifications of the self.                                           |



| Revision notes                                                                                                                                                                                                                     |
|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| • FACT: <b>Bridging principle:</b> ontological commitment must not outrun the accepted <i>pramāṇas</i> . Name it as a presupposition, not a proof.                                                                                 |
| • FACT: <i>prthivyāptejovāyuriti tattvāni</i> — four elements; and <i>tatsamudāye śarīrendriya-viśaya-saṃjñā</i> — bodies, senses and objects from their combination.                                                              |
| • FACT: Living bodies too are elemental combinations, "reduced on death" to the elements.                                                                                                                                          |
| • FACT: <b>The elements are eternal; only their combinations arise and perish</b> (Sharma).                                                                                                                                        |
| • FACT: <i>Ākāśa</i> is rejected "because it is not perceived but inferred" — the Vaiśeṣika sound-to-substrate inference is refused.                                                                                               |
| • FACT: <i>kiṇvādibhyo madaśaktivad vijñānam</i> — consciousness arises as intoxicating power arises from fermenting agents.                                                                                                       |
| • FACT: <b>Betel</b> = compositional emergence (leaf, lime, nut -> red). <b>Fermentation</b> = transformational emergence ( <i>guḍa</i> -> intoxicant).                                                                            |
| • FACT: Consciousness is an "epiphenomenon or bye-product of matter"; "matter secretes mind as liver secretes bile."                                                                                                               |
| • CAUTION: <b>Explanatory gap:</b> redness and intoxication are third-person properties; consciousness is private and first-personal. The Cārvāka's best reply is that the soul-hypothesis renames the gap rather than closing it. |
| • FACT: <b>Pot-and-potter:</b> the objector needs an efficient cause; the Cārvāka answers with <i>svabhāva</i> and denies that design is proved.                                                                                   |
| • FACT: Three labels from the textbook: <b>**naturalism</b> ( <i>svabhāvavāda</i> ), <b>mechanism</b> ( <i>yadr̥cchāvāda</i> ), <b>and positivism**</b> ("believes only in positive facts or observable phenomena").               |
| • CAUTION: Separate the <b>deflationary</b> use of <i>svabhāva</i> (regularity, with no guarantee of future uniformity) from the <b>substantive</b> cosmological use (nature in place of God).                                     |
| • FACT: <i>Vedāntasāra</i> : four materialist schools identify the self with gross body, senses, vital breaths, or <i>manas</i> .                                                                                                  |
| • CAUTION: Cārvāka's materialism is anti-inferential; modern materialism is thoroughly inferential. Same conclusion, opposite method.                                                                                              |



| 6. Self, Body and Consciousness — <i>Dehātmavāda</i> (doctrine that the conscious living body is the self), and Cārvāka (Indian materialist and perception-centred school) versus Buddhist <i>Anātman</i> (no permanent self) (2024, 20 marks)                                                                       |
|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: <i>Dehātmavāda</i> (doctrine that the body is the self) explains consciousness as an emergent property of the living body, whereas Buddhist <i>anātman</i> (no-permanent-self doctrine) analyses the person as a causal continuum without identifying self and body. |



| Plain-language visual - two different denials of a permanent soul                                                                                                                                                              |
|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| CARVAKA BUDDHISM<br>living body = conscious self changing five aggregates<br>continuity of body explains "I" causal continuity explains "I"<br>no body-independent atman (enduring self or soul) no permanent substance at all |

**In simple words:** Cārvāka does not deny the everyday person; it identifies the person with the conscious living body. Buddhism also rejects a permanent *ātman*, but analyses the person as a changing causal stream rather than as one material body.

| Test                   | Cārvāka (Indian materialist and perception-centred school) answer |
|------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------|
| What is the self?      | The body qualified by consciousness                               |
| Why say "I am strong"? | The first-person predicate applies directly to the body           |
| What happens at death? | The organised body dissolves; consciousness ends                  |
| Main difficulty        | Explaining memory, unity and personal identity fully              |

One-line memory: Cārvāka is body-self theory; Buddhism is no-substance process theory.



VISUAL: VISUAL — Three ways of denying the transcendental self (they are not the same denial)

THE QUESTION: what am I?

NYAYA (school of logic and epistemology) / VEDANTA (Upaniṣad-based end-of-the-Veda tradition) (the target) CARVAKA BUDDHISM

```
-----
+-----+ +-----+ +-----+
| ATMAN (enduring self or soul) | | BODY | | (no owner)|
| permanent | | qualified | +-----+
| substance | | by con- | | | |
| OWNER of | | sciousness| rupa vedana
| states | +-----+ samjna samskara
+-----+ ^ vijñana
^ | (5 skandhas (five aggregates constituting the person-process))
| "caitanya- |
states inhere visista deha a causal STREAM
in a substance eva atma" (santana), no
| substance, but
SUBSTANCE REAL continuity
RETAINED -- |
relocated to SUBSTANCE
the BODY ABOLISHED
| |
no rebirth, rebirth WITHOUT
no karma (action and its morally consequential residue) a self; karma (action and its morally consequential residue)
(death = end) preserved
```

CAUTION: **Caption.** This single diagram is the answer to the 2024 twenty-marker. Cārvāka **relocates** the self into matter; Buddhism **dissolves** the self into a process. One keeps a bearer and changes its nature; the other removes the bearer altogether. The moral and soteriological consequences then diverge completely: Cārvāka's denial ends the moral story at death, while Buddhism's denial is designed precisely to keep the moral story running without an owner.



1. Dehātmavāda (doctrine that the conscious living body is the self) — the doctrine stated exactly

FACT: **The transmitted formula:** *caitanya-viśiṣṭaḥ kāyaḥ puruṣaḥ* — "the person is the body qualified by consciousness"; and, in Chatterjee and Datta's rendering of the Cārvāka position, "What people mean by a soul is nothing more than this **conscious living body** (*caitanya-viśiṣṭa deha eva ātmā*)."

CAUTION: **Read the formula carefully — every word is load-bearing:**

CAITANYA-VISISTA : QUALIFIED BY CONSCIOUSNESS  
-> not any body; the LIVING body  
KAYAH : THE BODY  
-> the perceptible material organism  
PURUSAH / ATMA : IS the person / IS the self  
-> identity, not correlation

CAUTION: **Three misreadings to avoid**, each of which has sunk otherwise good answers:

- It is **not** "the self is the corpse". The self is the *living, conscious* body; consciousness is the qualifier that makes a body a self.
- It is **not** "there is no self". There is a self; it is material. Cārvāka is not an eliminativist about persons.
- It is **not** "consciousness is identical with any one element". Consciousness belongs to the **organised** body-complex, as the emergence analogies establish.



## 2. The argument for *dehātmavāda* (doctrine that the conscious living body is the self)

FACT: **Step 1 — the negative argument.** "The non-material soul is **never perceived**" (Chatterjee and Datta). What internal perception delivers is a state, not a substance behind the state.

FACT: **Step 2 — the positive argument from ordinary first-person judgements.** This is the Cārvāka's most distinctive and most quotable move: "we have **direct evidence of the identity of the self with the body** in our daily experiences and judgments like, 'I am fat,' 'I am lame,' 'I am blind.' If the 'I', the self, were different from the body, these would be **meaningless**."

CAUTION: **The logic of the argument from first-person statements, reconstructed:**

1. In ordinary speech, bodily predicates are attached directly to "I":  
I am fat; I am lame; I am blind; I am hungry; I am tall.
2. Predication of this kind is intelligible only if the SUBJECT and the BEARER of the predicate are the same thing.
3. If "I" named an immaterial soul, "I am fat" would be a CATEGORY MISTAKE -- as odd as "the number seven is blue".
4. But these statements are not category mistakes; they are the ordinary currency of self-description.
5. Therefore "I" refers to the body.

CAUTION: **The dualist's standard reply, and the Cārvāka's rejoinder.** The dualist answers that such expressions are **figurative** — the soul speaks of *its* body as a person speaks of "my house". The Cārvāka's rejoinder is that the figurative reading is a **theory-driven reinterpretation** of language, adopted only to save a doctrine that has no independent perceptual support; and that "my body" and "I am lame" are not on a par, since no one says "my body is lame, therefore I am figuratively lame" in the natural course of speech. CAUTION: Assessment: the argument does not *prove* materialism, but it correctly shifts the burden onto the dualist to explain why ordinary self-ascription runs the way it does.

FACT: **Step 3 — the argument from covariation.** The authored knowledge file records the standard supporting evidence: injury, intoxication, ageing, sleep and disease visibly alter awareness. Consciousness tracks the states of the body with a fidelity that would be inexplicable if it belonged to something else.

FACT: **Step 4 — the consequence.** Chatterjee and Datta: "If the existence of a soul apart from the body is not proved, there is no possibility of proving its immortality. On the contrary, **death of the body means the end of the individual.** All questions about previous life, after-life, rebirth, enjoyment of the fruits of actions in heaven or hell, therefore, become **meaningless.**"

CAUTION: Note the word Chatterjee and Datta use twice: *meaningless*, not merely false. That is a quasi-verificationist register, and it is a genuine evidential asset for the 2024 "positivism" question — though it must be used carefully, since the Cārvāka has no explicit theory of meaning.



3. The objections — Sharma's full battery, and the Cārvāka (Indian materialist and perception-centred school)'s replies

CAUTION: This is the richest objection-set in Indian philosophy, and reproducing four or five of these with replies is what turns a 12/20 into an 16/20. Sharma sets them out at length; each is paired below with the best available Cārvāka answer.

| # | Objection (Sharma)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                       | Best Cārvāka (Indian materialist and perception-centred school) reply                                                                                                                         | Residual pressure                                                                                                                                                                                                                                    |
|---|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 1 | <b>Self-consciousness.</b> If consciousness means <i>self</i> -consciousness, it cannot be identified with the living body, since animals have living bodies without rational consciousness                                                                                                                                              | CAUTION: Only a <b>particular combination</b> of elements, obtaining in the human body, produces consciousness; so no counter-example arises from animals                                     | CAUTION: Sharma calls this "wrong": it makes consciousness essential to a specific organisation, which invites objection 2                                                                                                                           |
| 2 | <b>Separability.</b> If consciousness were an essential property of the living body it would be inseparable from it. But "in swoons, fits, epilepsy, dreamless sleep etc. the living body is seen <b>without</b> consciousness"                                                                                                          | CAUTION: These are states in which the relevant <i>organisation</i> is disrupted; the property is essential to the organisation, not to bare bodily existence                                 | CAUTION: Strong reply, but it moves the doctrine from "body" to "functional organisation", which is a real concession                                                                                                                                |
| 3 | <b>Dream-consciousness.</b> "In dreams, consciousness is seen <b>without</b> the living body"; the dreamer on waking disowns the dream-body but <b>owns</b> the dream-consciousness                                                                                                                                                      | CAUTION: The dreaming subject is the sleeping physical body; the dream-body is imagined content, not a second body                                                                            | CAUTION: The reply is decent; Sharma's inference that consciousness therefore "persists through" waking, dream and deep sleep already presupposes the Vedāntic (relating to an Upaniṣad-based Vedānta tradition) three-state argument                |
| 4 | <b>Subject-object asymmetry.</b> "The subject, the knower, cannot be reduced to the object, the known, since all objects presuppose the existence of the subject"; the subject is enjoyer, the object enjoyed                                                                                                                            | CAUTION: A material organism can be both knower and known, as a hand can touch itself; asymmetry of <i>role</i> does not entail difference of <i>substance</i>                                | CAUTION: This is the deepest objection and it is not fully answered; it is the ancestor of the modern subjectivity problem                                                                                                                           |
| 5 | <b>Co-existence is not causation.</b> "The eye cannot see in darkness. Sight is not possible without light, yet light cannot be regarded as the cause of sight"; "the two horns of a bull which are always found together cannot be regarded as causally related." The body may be the <b>instrument</b> of consciousness, not its cause | CAUTION: Correct as logic — but the instrument-hypothesis needs an independent user, and no such user is perceived; the materialist hypothesis is the more economical of two unproven options | CAUTION: Genuinely undecided; both sides are arguing from the same evidence to different best explanations                                                                                                                                           |
| 6 | <b>Imperceptibility of the alleged property.</b> "If consciousness is a property of the body, it must be perceived like other material properties. But it is <b>neither smelt nor tasted nor seen nor touched nor heard</b> "                                                                                                            | CAUTION: It <b>is</b> perceived — by internal perception, which Cārvāka (Indian materialist and perception-centred school) admits                                                             | CAUTION: But then the Cārvāka (Indian materialist and perception-centred school)'s own criterion has been stretched: internal perception delivers something with no external sensory mode, which is precisely the anomaly the dualist is pointing at |
| 7 | <b>Privacy.</b> A material property "should be known by all in the same manner and should not be private. But we find that consciousness is intimately private and consciousness of an individual cannot be shared by others"                                                                                                            | CAUTION: Privacy is explained by the <i>locality</i> of the organism: each body has its own internal states, as each fire has its own heat                                                    | CAUTION: The reply confuses <i>causal locality</i> with <i>epistemic inaccessibility</i> ; the objection retains real force                                                                                                                          |



| # | Objection (Sharma)                                                                                                                                                                                   | Best Cārvāka (Indian materialist and perception-centred school) reply                                                                                                                                      | Residual pressure                                                                                                                                                                                                            |
|---|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 8 | <b>Self-manifestation regress.</b> If consciousness is a property of the body, "why should the body, qualified to produce consciousness, itself stand in need of being manifested by consciousness?" | CAUTION: Being a producer of awareness and being an object of awareness are different roles, and one thing may play both                                                                                   | CAUTION: A fair reply, though it again concedes a role-distinction that dualists exploit                                                                                                                                     |
| # | Objection (Sharma)                                                                                                                                                                                   | Best Cārvāka (Indian materialist and perception-centred school) reply                                                                                                                                      | Residual pressure                                                                                                                                                                                                            |
| 9 | <b>Symmetry of ignorance.</b> "If the existence of the soul surviving death cannot be demonstrated, its <b>non-existence</b> too cannot be so demonstrated"                                          | CAUTION: The Cārvāka (Indian materialist and perception-centred school)'s principle is asymmetrical by design: the burden lies on the one who <i>posits</i> an entity, not on the one who withholds assent | CAUTION: This exposes the difference between <i>not asserting</i> and <i>denying</i> , and most doxographies attribute outright denial rather than agnosticism to Cārvāka (Indian materialist and perception-centred school) |

CAUTION: **The single most useful evaluative sentence to carry from this table:** *Sharma's objections 2, 3 and 5 show that the Cārvāka's evidence establishes at most a dependence of consciousness on the body, and dependence is compatible with the body being the instrument rather than the cause — so the materialist conclusion is under-determined by the materialist's own evidence.* That sentence is worth reproducing in any answer on the Cārvāka self.



4. Memory and personal identity

CAUTION: **The objection.** Memory reaches across time: I remember what I did. What sustains the "I" through the constant replacement of bodily material? A permanent substance seems required.

CAUTION: **The three answers on the table, and the exam requires you to distinguish them:**

| School                                                                                        | What secures the identity of the rememberer                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                  |
|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Nyāya (school of logic and epistemology) / Vedānta (Upaniṣad-based end-of-the-Veda tradition) | FACT: A permanent <i>ātman</i> ( <i>enduring self or soul</i> ) which is the single owner of past experience and present memory                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                              |
| Cārvāka (Indian materialist and perception-centred school)                                    | CAUTION: Bodily-psychological continuity: the same living organism persists, so the same organism that experienced now recalls. Memory is a bodily-mental trace in a continuing body                                                                                                                                                                                                                         |
| Buddhism                                                                                      | FACT: <i>Santāna</i> ( <i>causal continuum or stream</i> ), the causal stream; memory belongs to the same causal continuum, reinforced by <i>pratisandhāna</i> ( <i>continuity-linking connection</i> ) (relinking), and in Yogācāra (Buddhist consciousness-only school) by <i>ālaya-vijñāna</i> ( <i>store-consciousness</i> ) carrying <i>bījas</i> ( <i>plural form: causal seed or latent potency</i> ) |

CAUTION: **The comparative point that examiners reward.** Cārvāka and Buddhism both reject the permanent owner, but they replace it with different things: Cārvāka with a **material continuant** (a body that endures), Buddhism with a **causal continuant** (a stream in which nothing endures). The Cārvāka answer is metaphysically cheaper and psychologically thinner; the Buddhist answer is metaphysically subtler and must work much harder, which is why it develops *santāna*, *pratisandhāna* and eventually *ālaya-vijñāna*.



Exam link

Primary route: 2024 Q6(a), 20 marks. Use shared denial but different reconstruction: Cārvāka relocates self into body; Buddhism dissolves self into a causal process.



Traps and recap



UPSC traps

- FACT: **Never write that Cārvāka and Buddhism deny the self "in the same way"**. This is the exact error the 2024 question was designed to catch.
- CAUTION: Do not say Cārvāka denies the self *simpliciter*. He denies a transcendental self and affirms a material one.
- CAUTION: Do not say Buddhism reduces the person to the body. *Rūpa* is only one of five *skandhas*, and is itself denied selfhood.
- CAUTION: Do not say Cārvāka denies consciousness. He denies that consciousness needs an immaterial bearer.
- CAUTION: Do not omit *santāna* when handling memory in Buddhism; and do not smuggle a soul into it.
- CAUTION: Do not present Sharma's objections as unanswerable. Give the Cārvāka's reply and *then* assess.
- CAUTION: Do not miss the asymmetry point: Cārvāka's denial ends the moral narrative; Buddhism's denial is constructed to continue it.
- CAUTION: Do not forget the first-person statements — "I am fat", "I am lame", "I am blind". They are the Cārvāka's own positive argument and are frequently omitted.
- CAUTION: Do not treat "death alone is liberation" as a serious soteriology. It is a *rejection* of soteriology expressed in soteriological vocabulary.



Revision notes

- FACT: *caitanya-viśiṣṭaḥ kāyaḥ puruṣaḥ* / *caitanya-viśiṣṭa deha eva ātmā* — the person is the **living** body qualified by consciousness.
- FACT: Negative argument: "the non-material soul is **never perceived**."
- FACT: Positive argument: "I am fat", "I am lame", "I am blind" — bodily predicates attach directly to "I"; on dualism they would be meaningless.
- FACT: Covariation: injury, intoxication, ageing, sleep and disease alter awareness.
- FACT: Consequence: death of the body is the end of the individual; questions of rebirth, heaven and hell "become meaningless".
- FACT: **Sharma's objections**: swoon and dreamless sleep (body without consciousness) · dreams (consciousness without body) · subject cannot be reduced to object · co-existence is not causation (light and sight; the two horns of a bull) · consciousness is neither smelt, tasted, seen, touched nor heard · consciousness is **private** · non-existence of the soul is equally undemonstrable.
- CAUTION: Best evaluative line: the evidence establishes **dependence**, and dependence is compatible with the body being the **instrument** rather than the cause.
- FACT: Memory: Nyāya/Vedānta invoke *ātman*; Cārvāka invokes bodily-psychological continuity; Buddhism invokes *santāna*, *pratisandhāna* and *ālaya-vijñāna*.
- FACT: **2024 contrast in one line**: Cārvāka **relocates** the self into matter; Buddhism **dissolves** the self into process.
- FACT: Cārvāka's ground is epistemic; Buddhism's is ontological (*pratīyasamutpāda*, *kṣaṇikavāda*) and soteriological (self-belief breeds craving).

- FACT: Cārvāka rejects rebirth, karma and *mokṣa*; Buddhism retains rebirth, karma and *nirvāṇa* without a self.
- CAUTION: *Rūpa* is one of the five *skandhas* — so Buddhist *anātman* refutes the Cārvāka body-self **by name**.
- CAUTION: **Puggalavāda** (Vātsīputrīya) is the internal Buddhist foil; **Sadānanda's four materialisms** are the internal Cārvāka foil.



7. The Rejection of Transcendent Entities — God, Soul, Karma (action and its morally consequential residue), Rebirth, Heaven, Mokṣa (liberation), Veda and Ritual

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Cārvāka (Indian materialist school) rejects God, an immortal soul, karma (moral causation across lives), rebirth and mokṣa (liberation) because none is established by perception, and it rejects Vedic ritual authority as epistemically unsupported.



Plain-language visual - one rule removes seven unseen claims

Only perception is certain  
|  
+--> no separate soul  
+--> no God  
+--> no unseen karma (action and its morally consequential residue)/adrista  
+--> no rebirth  
+--> no heaven or hell  
+--> no mokṣa (liberation) after death  
+--> no infallible Vedic authority

In simple words: these denials are not seven unrelated opinions. Each follows from the same rule: if an entity can be reached only through inference or testimony, Cārvāka does not accept it as established knowledge.

| Unseen claim                                                     | Why it falls                                                                                             |
|------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| God                                                              | Known through design inference, which Cārvāka (Indian materialist and perception-centred school) rejects |
| Karma (action and its morally consequential residue) and rebirth | Require an unseen moral force and a surviving carrier                                                    |
| Heaven, hell and liberation                                      | Post-mortem states are not perceived                                                                     |
| Vedic ritual                                                     | Scriptural testimony has no independent authority                                                        |

One-line memory: epistemology is the root; rejection of transcendence is the branch.



VISUAL: VISUAL — The demolition tree: one premise, seven casualties



CAUTION: **Caption.** This tree is the answer to the 2021 ten-marker in diagram form. The examiner's phrase — "the **bearing** of Cārvāka epistemology on the rejection of transcendental entities" — asks for exactly this: not a list of denials, but the demonstration that a single epistemic cut severs them all at once.



1. The general form of every Cārvāka (Indian materialist and perception-centred school) denial

CAUTION: Every denial in this subtopic instantiates one template. Learn the template, not the list.

- 1. X is claimed to exist.
- 2. X is not, and cannot in principle be, presented in perception.
- 3. The only routes to X are inference or scriptural testimony.
- 4. Neither inference nor testimony is an independent pramana (means of valid knowledge).
- 5. Therefore there is no valid means by which X could be known.
- 6. Therefore X should not be admitted into our ontology.

CAUTION: **The precision point at step 6.** There is a real difference between *withholding assent* (agnosticism) and *denying* (atheism, in the broad sense). QUESTION: The doxographical sources overwhelmingly present Cārvāka as **denying** — "the Cārvākas, therefore, prefer atheism" (Chatterjee and Datta) — but the argument as stated licenses only the weaker conclusion. Sharma records the opposing school's exploitation of exactly this gap: "if the existence of the soul surviving death cannot be demonstrated, its **non-existence** too cannot be so demonstrated." A first-class answer notes the gap and states which reading it is defending.



2. God — and why *svabhāvavāda* (doctrine that natural properties explain events) is the operative reason

FACT: Chatterjee and Datta: "God, whose existence cannot be perceived, **fares no better than the soul**. The material elements produce the world, and the supposition of a creator is unnecessary."

| CAUTION: Two distinct arguments are at work, and separating them is worth marks:       |                                                                                                                                                                                                    |                                             |
|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------|
| Argument                                                                               | Form                                                                                                                                                                                               | Force                                       |
| Epistemic                                                                              | God is imperceptible; the only routes to God are inference (the design and causal arguments) and <i>śabda</i> (verbal testimony); both are denied <i>pramāṇa</i> (means of valid knowledge)-status | FACT: Removes the <b>warrant</b> for theism |
| Explanatory ( <i>svabhāvanavāda</i> (doctrine that natural properties explain events)) | Even granting the explanatory question, the fixed natures of the elements suffice; "there is no proof that the objects of the world are the products of any design"                                | FACT: Removes the <b>need</b> for theism    |

CAUTION: Note that the second argument is logically independent of the first, and is the more interesting one, because it engages Nyāya on Nyāya's own ground. Nyāya's *kāryāt* inference argues from the world as a composite **effect** to an intelligent efficient cause. The Cārvāka's *svabhāvanavāda* rejoinder does not merely say "you cannot know that"; it says "the explanandum is discharged without you". CAUTION: Chatterjee and Datta record the further Cārvāka move: the objects of the world "can be explained more reasonably as the **fortuitous** products of the elements" — which is *yadr̥cchāvāda*, and which sits in some tension with a strong *svabhāvanavāda* that grounds regularity in fixed natures. Noting that internal tension is a genuinely advanced observation.



### 3. Karma (action and its morally consequential residue), *adr̥ṣṭa* (unseen causal force) and the moral order

FACT: Chatterjee and Datta name *adr̥ṣṭa* explicitly among the casualties: "God, soul, heaven, life before birth or after death, and **\*\*any unperceived law (like *adr̥ṣṭa*)\*\*** cannot be believed in, because they are all beyond perception."

CAUTION: **\*\*Why *adr̥ṣṭa* is the decisive test case.\*\*** *Adr̥ṣṭa* — "the unseen" — is by its own definition imperceptible. It is the Nyāya–Vaiśeṣika and Mīmāṃsā device for connecting an act performed now with a fruit enjoyed later, sometimes in another life. The Cārvāka's objection is therefore not incidental but **definitional**: an entity whose name announces its imperceptibility is precisely what an epistemology of perception must refuse.

FACT: **The objection from moral order, and the Cārvāka's reply.** The authored knowledge file records the exchange: without *karma* and rebirth, moral order is said to collapse. The Cārvāka answer is that "morality need not be underwritten by cosmic bookkeeping; human pain, pleasure, prudence, and social consequences are enough for practical conduct."

CAUTION: **Assessment to write.** The reply establishes that a *this-worldly* account of moral motivation is available; it does not establish that such an account can support obligations that run against self-interest with no observer. This is the enduring weak point of Cārvāka ethics and connects directly to Subtopic 8.



### 4. Rebirth and transmigration — the 2020 question's second half

FACT: **Exact question (2020, Q6(b), 15 marks).** "Critically evaluate Cārvākas' rejection of *Ākāśa* as one of the elements of reality and examine their criticism of transmigration of Soul."

CAUTION: **What transmigration requires, and where Cārvāka cuts each requirement:**

| Requirement of transmigration                | Cārvāka (Indian materialist and perception-centred school)'s cut                                                                                             |
|----------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| (a) A self distinct from the body            | FACT: <i>Dehātmanavāda</i> (doctrine that the conscious living body is the self): the self <b>is</b> the living body; no separable subject exists to migrate |
| (b) Survival of that self after bodily death | FACT: "Death of the body means the end of the individual"; the elements disperse, and the combination that carried consciousness is dissolved                |

| Requirement of transmigration                | Cārvāka (Indian materialist and perception-centred school)'s cut                                                                                                                                              |
|----------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| (c) A carrier of moral desert across the gap | FACT: <i>Karma</i> (action and its morally consequential residue) and <i>adr̥ṣṭa</i> (unseen causal force) are unperceived and hence unwarranted                                                              |
| (d) Knowledge that any of (a)–(c) obtains    | FACT: Only scripture and inference could supply it; both are denied <i>pramāṇa</i> (means of valid knowledge)-status                                                                                          |
| (e) Meaningfulness of the claim              | CAUTION: Chatterjee and Datta report that questions about "previous life, after-life, rebirth, enjoyment of the fruits of actions in heaven or hell" become <b>meaningless</b> — a quasi-verificationist step |

CAUTION: **The critical evaluation the question explicitly demands.** A "critically evaluate" question is not answered by exposition. Supply both sides:

STRENGTHS of the Carvaka position

(i) consistency: the same criterion cuts akasa (ether or space as an element), atman (enduring self or soul) and rebirth alike

(ii) economy: nothing unobservable is posited

(iii) anti-exploitation: it removes the machinery on which ritual prescription and priestly authority rested

(iv) it forces every rival school to say HOW an unseen bearer of desert is known -- a demand Nyaya (school of logic and epistemology) answers only inferentially

WEAKNESSES

(i) the argument rests on the rejection of inference, which is itself vulnerable (Subtopics 3-4)

(ii) dependence of consciousness on the body does not entail production by the body (Sharma's instrument objection)

(iii) "not established" is slid into "does not exist"

(iv) the disappearance of moral continuity leaves desert and obligation without any ground beyond prudence

(v) Sharma: the non-existence of a surviving soul is as undemonstrable as its existence

CAUTION: **Verdict formula for this question:** *The rejection of ākāśa and of transmigration are the same argument applied twice — once to cosmology and once to soteriology — and their force is exactly the force of the underlying epistemology. Where that epistemology is defensible, as a demand that metaphysical postulates earn their keep, the rejection is powerful; where it over-reaches, in converting "unestablished" into "unreal", the rejection outruns its warrant.*



## 5. Heaven, hell and mokṣa (liberation)

FACT: **Heaven.** Chatterjee and Datta: the Mīmāṃsakas hold that the highest goal is heaven (*svarga*), "a state of unalloyed bliss that can be attained hereafter by performing here the Vedic rites. **The Cārvāka rejects this view, because it is based on the unproved existence of a life after death.** 'Heaven' and 'hell' are the **inventions of the priests** whose professional interest lies in coaxing, threatening and making people perform the rituals. Enlightened men will always refuse to be duped by them."

FACT: **Liberation.** The Cārvāka argument is a dilemma, and it is elegant:

What could "liberation" mean?

HORN 1: freedom of the SOUL from bondage to physical existence  
-> "absurd, because there is no soul"

HORN 2: attainment, IN THIS LIFE, of a state free from ALL pain  
-> "an impossible ideal. Existence in this body is bound up with pleasure as well as pain."

RESIDUE: "Liberation in the sense of complete cessation of sufferings can only mean DEATH." -> maranam eva apavargah

FACT: Both horns and the residue are given verbatim in substance by Chatterjee and Datta, and the residue is one of the six transmitted *Bṛhaspati sūtras*.

CAUTION: \*\*How to present *maranam eva apavargah* without caricature. **It is not a recommendation of death and it is not nihilism. It is a** reductio of the concept of liberation\*\*: if *mokṣa* means the total cessation of suffering, then the only state that satisfies the definition is the one no wise person would work for. The verse is a critique of the *coherence* of the goal, not an endorsement of dying. Saying this in one sentence is worth a mark and protects you from the commonest misreading in the topic.



**6. The Veda, priestcraft and the ritual reductions**

FACT: **The epistemic charge.** *Śabda* is not an independent *pramāṇa* (Subtopic 2); Vedic authority therefore has no certified standing. Claims of authorlessness or infallibility are not perceptually available.

FACT: **The sociological charge.** Chatterjee and Datta report it plainly: "in reality the Vedas are the works of some **cunning priests** who earned their living by duping the ignorant and the credulous", and the tangible benefit of the rites goes to "the priests who officiate and enjoy the emoluments."

FACT: \*\*The *Sarva-darśana-saṃgraha* summary, **as reproduced by Sharma, is the sharpest form of the polemic and should be used with an explicit source-caution: "There is no heaven, no final liberation, nor any soul in another world; nor do the actions of the four castes, orders etc. produce any real effect. The Agnihotra, the three Vedas, the ascetic's three staves and smearing one's self with ashes, were made by Nature as the livelihood of those destitute of knowledge and manliness...** (All the ceremonies are) a means of livelihood (for) Brāhmaṇas. The three authors of the Vedas were buffoons, knaves and demons.\*\*"

FACT: **The three ritual reductions** — each is a genuine argument, not merely abuse, and each has the same logical shape: *take the ritual's own premise seriously, and derive an absurdity the practitioner will not accept*.

| # | The reductio                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                           | The premise it tests                               | The absurdity generated                                                                                  |
|---|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 1 | **The <i>śrāddha</i> (ritual offering for ancestors) argument.** If the food offered at the funeral ceremony can appease the hunger of the departed, "what is the use of a traveller's taking food with him? Why should not his people make some offerings in his name at home to satisfy his hunger?" | That an offering here nourishes a person elsewhere | CAUTION: Nourishment at a distance would make travel provisions pointless — a consequence no one accepts |
| 2 | <b>The upstairs argument.</b> "Food offered on the ground floor should satisfy a person living upstairs."                                                                                                                                                                                              | The same, in miniature                             | CAUTION: A vivid <i>reductio</i> of action-at-a-distance nourishment                                     |

| # | The reductio                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                | The premise it tests                                | The absurdity generated                                                                                               |
|---|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 3 | **The <i>jyotiṣṭoma</i> ( <i>Vedic soma sacrifice</i> ) argument. "If the priests really believe, as they say, that the animals killed at a sacrifice are sure to reach heaven, why do they not rather sacrifice their own old parents** instead of animals and make heaven sure for them?" | That ritual slaughter secures heaven for the victim | CAUTION: The priest's refusal reveals that he does not believe his own premise — an argument from revealed preference |

CAUTION: **The philosophically important observation to add.** The *jyotiṣṭoma* argument is not a joke; it is an early and powerful use of **revealed preference** as evidence about belief. It says: your unwillingness to apply your doctrine where it would cost you shows that you do not hold it in the way you profess. That is a serious epistemic argument and deserves to be presented as one.

CAUTION: **The balance an answer must strike.** Chatterjee and Datta themselves describe the Cārvākas as raising "cheap laughter at the customary rites". An answer that reproduces only the abuse looks unserious; an answer that reproduces only the epistemology misses the school's historical bite. Present the polemic **and** extract the argument inside it.



Exam link

Primary routes: 2020 Q6(b) on transmigration and 2021 Q5(e) on the bearing of epistemology. Show one premise generating each denial rather than listing conclusions.



Traps and recap



UPSC traps

- CAUTION: Do not present the denials as a list. Show the **derivation** from the single epistemic premise — that is what "bearing" means in 2021 Q5(e).
- CAUTION: Do not slide from "not established" to "does not exist" without noticing. Sharma exploits exactly that slide.
- CAUTION: Do not read *maraṇam eva apavargaḥ* as a recommendation of death. It is a *reductio* of the concept of liberation.
- CAUTION: Do not reduce the ritual criticisms to abuse. The *śrāddha* and *jyotiṣṭoma* arguments are genuine *reductios*, and the second is an argument from revealed preference.
- CAUTION: Do not quote the *Sarva-darśana-saṃgraha* invective without a source-caution; it is a summary preserved by an opponent.
- CAUTION: Do not say "Cārvāka is the only atheist school in India". Sāṃkhya, Mīmāṃsā, Jainism and Buddhism are all non-theistic. Cārvāka is the only school whose atheism follows from its **epistemology** and which also discards karma, rebirth and liberation.
- CAUTION: Do not forget *adr̥ṣṭa* by name. It is the perfect test case, since its name means "the unseen".
- CAUTION: Do not miss the internal tension between *svabhāvavāda* (fixed natures grounding regularity) and *yadr̥cchāvāda* (fortuitous combination). Noting it is a mark of independent thought.



Revision notes

- FACT: **The template:** X is imperceptible -> only inference or testimony could reach X -> neither is a *pramāṇa* -> X is unwarranted -> X is rejected.



- CAUTION: Note the gap between withholding assent and denying; the doxographies attribute denial, the argument licenses only the weaker conclusion.
- FACT: God falls twice over: **epistemically** (no *pramāṇa*) and **explanatorily** (*svabhāva* suffices; "no proof that the objects of the world are the products of any design").
- FACT: *Adṛṣṭa* is named explicitly among the casualties — "any unperceived law (like *adrṣṭa*)".
- FACT: Transmigration requires a separable self, its survival, a carrier of desert, and knowledge of all three; Cārvāka cuts every one.
- FACT: Heaven and hell are "the inventions of the priests"; *svarga* is rejected because it rests on "the unproved existence of a life after death".
- FACT: **The liberation dilemma**: freedom of a soul (absurd — there is no soul) or freedom from all pain in this life (impossible — embodiment mixes pleasure and pain); residue — *maraṇam eva apavargaḥ*.
- FACT: **Three ritual reductions**: *śrāddha* and the traveller's food · food downstairs for a person upstairs · *jyotiṣṭoma* and "why not sacrifice their own old parents".
- FACT: *Sarva-darśana-saṃgraha*: Agnihotra, the three Vedas, the three staves and ashes are "the livelihood of those destitute of knowledge and manliness"; "the three authors of the Vedas were buffoons, knaves and demons" — quote with a source-caution.
- CAUTION: The *jyotiṣṭoma* argument is an argument from **revealed preference** about what the priest actually believes.
- CAUTION: Cārvāka is not the only non-theistic Indian school; it is the only one whose atheism is generated **epistemologically**, and the only one that also discards karma, rebirth and *mokṣa*.
- CAUTION: Internal tension worth noting: *svabhāva*vāda grounds regularity in fixed natures, while *yadṛcchā*vāda calls the world's objects "fortuitous products".



8. Ethics and the Political-Social Meaning — and Cārvāka (Indian materialist and perception-centred school) versus Jaina Reality (2020, 15 marks)

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Cārvāka (Indian materialist school) ethics is best read as prudent this-worldly well-being rather than crude hedonism: pleasure is valuable, pain is a cost, and action requires intelligent calculation within embodied social life.



Plain-language visual - the purpose-of-life filter

DHARMA (doctrine, duty or constitutive factor, as context requires) -> rejected as scripture-dependent  
ARTHA (material prosperity or practical means) -> accepted as a means  
KAMA -> accepted as the final this-worldly end  
MOKSA (liberation) -> rejected as an unproved post-mortem ideal

ARTHA (material prosperity or practical means) -----> KAMA  
means end

In simple words: because this life is the only life securely known, Cārvāka values attainable well-being here. Wealth matters as a tool for enjoyment, not as an end by itself. The tradition must not be reduced automatically to reckless pleasure: sources distinguish crude and cultured forms.

| Crude reading                   | Refined reading                                        |
|---------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------|
| Immediate sensual gratification | Intelligent enjoyment shaped by skill and self-control |
| Ignores social discipline       | Recognises that society requires restraint             |

| Crude reading             | Refined reading                                                                                          |
|---------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Common hostile caricature | Supported by the <i>dhūrta</i> (cunning or crude) / <i>suśikṣita</i> (cultivated or refined) distinction |

One-line memory: this-worldly enjoyment is central, but intelligent enjoyment is not identical with reckless indulgence.



VISUAL: VISUAL — The *puruṣārtha* (goal of human life) ledger, and the two axes of the Cārvāka (Indian materialist and perception-centred school) position

THE FOUR PURUSARTHAS CARVAKA'S VERDICT  
-----  
DHARMA (doctrine, duty or constitutive factor, as context requires) (virtue / duty) -----> REJECTED : "distinctions made by the scriptures, whose authority cannot be rationally accepted"  
ARTHA (material prosperity or practical means) (wealth) -----> ACCEPTED as MEANS, not as end  
KAMA (enjoyment) -----> ACCEPTED as THE END  
MOKSA (liberation) -----> REJECTED : obtainable "only by death, and no wise man would work for that"

+-----+  
| ARTHA (material prosperity or practical means) ---- means ----> KAMA |  
| (ultimate) |  
+-----+

AND WITHIN "KAMA" THERE ARE TWO CARVAKAS:  
  
DHURTA (cunning/crude) SUSIKSITA (cultured/refined)  
-----  
gross sensual pleasure pleasure disciplined by the immediate gratification sixty-four fine arts, self-egoistic hedonism control and urbanity  
the caricature the Vatsyayana's Kama-sutra as the opponents preserved "best positive evidence"  
(Chatterjee & Datta)

CAUTION: **Caption.** Two axes, not one. The first axis is which *puruṣārthas* survive; the second is *what kind* of hedonist is doing the surviving. Almost every weak answer collapses the second axis and presents only the *dhūrta*. The textbooks themselves refuse that collapse.



1. The doctrine, stated exactly

FACT: **\*\*The transmitted *sūtra*:\*\*** *kāma evaikaḥ puruṣārthaḥ* — "enjoyment is the only end of human life."

FACT: **The four-fold verdict**, in Chatterjee and Datta's exact terms: "Of these four, the Cārvāka rejects the last two. Liberation in the sense of destruction of all sufferings can be obtained only by death and no wise man would willingly work for that end. **Virtue and vice are distinctions made by the scriptures, whose authority cannot be rationally accepted.** Therefore neither liberation nor virtue should be our end. Wealth and enjoyment are the only rational ends that a wise man can toil to achieve. But **enjoyment is the ultimate end; wealth is not an end in itself, it is good only as a means to enjoyment.**"

CAUTION: **Two things to notice, both examinable.**

- The rejection of *dharma* is **epistemically** driven, not merely appetitive. *Dharma* is rejected because it is a *scriptural* category and *śabda* is not a *pramāṇa* — the same cut that removed *ākāśa* and *ātman*. Writing "Cārvāka rejects virtue because he loves pleasure" reverses the direction of the argument.
- *Artha* is subordinated, not co-ordinate. Cārvāka is not a materialist about *wealth*; wealth is instrumental. That is a real ethical thesis and it separates Cārvāka from mere acquisitiveness.



## 2. The standard of right action, and its consequentialist form

FACT: Chatterjee and Datta: "A **good action** is one which leads to a **balance of pleasure** and a **bad action** is one which brings about **more pain than pleasure**. This Cārvāka ethics may be called, therefore, **hedonism** or the theory that pleasure is the highest goal."

CAUTION: **The structure of the criterion, made explicit:**

VALUE THEORY : pleasure is the sole intrinsic good;  
pain the sole intrinsic evil  
NORMATIVE THEORY : the right action is the one whose balance of  
pleasure over pain is greatest  
SCOPE : the doxographies present the scope as EGOISTIC --  
"pleasure of the senses in this life and that too  
of the individual is the sole end" (Sharma)  
BUT : Chatterjee & Datta explicitly deny that ALL  
materialists were egoistic hedonists

CAUTION: **The scope question is where the real philosophy is.** Egoistic hedonism and universalistic hedonism share a value theory and differ entirely in their normative consequences. Chatterjee and Datta record the decisive consideration: "**Egoistic hedonism in its gross form is not compatible with social discipline. Life in society is impossible if man does not sacrifice a part of his pleasures for others.**" And they immediately supply the evidence that some Cārvākas saw this: "Some Cārvākas, we are told, regard the **king as God**. This implies their great faith in the necessity of society and its head."



## 3. Refined hedonism — the evidence, and why it matters

FACT: \*\*The *dhūrta* / *suśikṣita* distinction. **Chatterjee and Datta: "a distinction found sometimes between the** cunning (*dhūrta*) **and** cultured (*suśikṣita*) **Cārvākas makes it likely that the Cārvākas were** not all of the same gross, uncultured type\*\*." Sharma records the same twofold division of "Crude and Refined Materialists".

FACT: **The evidence for refinement**, as Chatterjee and Datta present it:

| Evidence                           | Detail                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      |
|------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| The fine arts                      | Materialists "devoted themselves also to the pursuit of more refined pleasures by cultivating, for example, the fine arts, the number of which is as large as <b>sixty-four</b> ( <i>catuḥ-ṣaṣṭi-kalāḥ</i> ( <i>sixty-four cultivated arts</i> )), according to Vātsyāyana" |
| Political philosophy and economics | "**Political philosophy and economy ( <i>daṇḍanīti</i> ( <i>science of punishment and government</i> ) and <i>vārttā</i> ( <i>livelihood sciences of agriculture, cattle and trade</i> )) came to be incorporated at some stage in the philosophy of the Lokāyatikas**"     |
| The king as God                    | Reported of some Cārvākas (plural form: Indian materialist and perception-centred school) — implying "great faith in the necessity of society and its head"                                                                                                                 |

| Evidence                | Detail                                                                                                                                                       |
|-------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Vātsyāyana's Kāma-sūtra | "The best positive evidence of refined hedonism is found in the ethical philosophy propounded by Vātsyāyana in the second chapter of the <i>Kāma-sūtra</i> " |

FACT: **Vātsyāyana's position, stated precisely — and note the important qualification.** Chatterjee and Datta are careful: "Though Vātsyāyana **believes in God and in life after death** and, therefore, is **not a materialist in the ordinary sense**, yet he may be regarded as one, according to a **wider** sense of the term, namely, one who tries to explain 'higher phenomena by lower ones'." His materialist tendency "consists in holding that *dharma* and *artha* are to be treated only as **means** to enjoyment, which is therefore the supreme end."

FACT: **The content of the refinement**, which is the material that rescues Cārvāka ethics from caricature:

- Emphasis on **\*\*self-control (*brahmacarya*)\*\***, spiritual discipline (*dharma*) and **\*\*urbanity (*nāgarika-vṛtti*)\*\***, "without which human enjoyment of pleasure is reduced to the level of beastly enjoyment."
- All *kāma* is "ultimately reducible to the gratification of the five senses"; the satisfaction of the senses is "necessary for the very existence of the body (*śarīra-sthitī*)", like the satisfaction of hunger.
- The senses "must be **educated, disciplined and cultured** through a training in the sixty-four fine arts", given only after "absolute self-continence and study" in the earlier part of life.
- Against the impatient hedonist who will not "forgo present comfort" or "undergo any toil for future enjoyment", Vātsyāyana argues that such an attitude "would be **suicidal**", since it "would prevent a man even from the toil of cultivation and sowing seeds in the hope of the future enjoyment of a crop."
- **"\*\*Inordinate desire, inconsistent with the principles of *dharma* and wealth, leads to ruin and annihilates the chances of all enjoyment.\*\*"**
- He argues, "like a modern scientific man, that some science is at the root of every successful practice."

CAUTION: **The philosophical upshot, and it is important.** Point 4 is a **prudential** argument *internal* to hedonism: unregulated present gratification is self-defeating **on hedonistic grounds**. That is exactly the structure of Epicurus' argument in the West, and it means that the refined Cārvāka position is not a compromise with morality imported from outside — it is what consistent hedonism requires of itself. Chatterjee and Datta conclude that Vātsyāyana "represents Indian hedonism at its best", and that the name *suśikṣita-cārvāka* was "perhaps" applied to thinkers of this kind.

CAUTION: **The honest counterweight.** Sharma's verdict is far harsher and must be carried too: "The ethics of the Cārvāka is a **crude individual hedonism**"; "All values are mere phantoms created by a diseased mind"; and he locates the school's downfall not in its atheism or its materialism — which it shares with respected schools — but in "the Cārvāka's **denial of all human values** which make life worth living... Sensual pleasure is a very faint shadow of the supreme pleasure. There is a qualitative difference in pleasure. **The pleasure of the pig is certainly not the same as the pleasure of the philosopher.**"

CAUTION: **How to adjudicate in an answer.** The two verdicts are about different things and both are usable:

SHARMA'S TARGET : the doctrine as transmitted in the doxographies -- gross, egoistic, quantitative hedonism  
CHATTERJEE & DATTA'S : the historical breadth of the movement -- the TARGET susiksita strand, the fine arts, dandaniti and varta, the king-as-God report, Vatsyayana's discipline

VERDICT TO WRITE : the transmitted doctrine is vulnerable to Sharma's "pleasure of the pig" objection because it offers no QUALITATIVE distinction among pleasures; the refined strand supplies a PRUDENTIAL and CULTURAL regulation of pleasure but still no independent standard of value. Carvaka can be made prudent; it cannot easily be made moral.



4. The "debt and ghee" verse — and the source caution

QUESTION: **The verse**, as preserved in the *Sarva-darśana-saṃgraha* and reproduced by Sharma: **"While life remains let a man live happily, let him feed on ghee (clarified butter) even though he runs in debt; when once the body becomes ashes, how can it ever return here?"**

CAUTION: **The source caution, which must accompany every use of this verse.** This is:

- A verse preserved in a **fourteenth-century doxography** compiled by **Mādhava**, a Vedāntin — that is, by an opponent;
- Presented in a chapter whose purpose is refutation;
- Not attributable to any surviving primary Cārvāka text;
- Frequently paraphrased in exam scripts as *yāvaj jivet sukhaṃ jivet*, which the authored knowledge file itself flags as a **doxographical verse associated with the tradition, not a securely locatable quotation from an extant primary Cārvāka text.**

CAUTION: **How to use it correctly in an answer:** *"The often-quoted verse — live happily, feed on ghee even in debt, for the body once turned to ashes does not return — is preserved in the Sarva-darśana-saṃgraha, an opponent's compendium, and should be treated as a doxographical characterisation of the school's spirit rather than as its own scripture."* That single sentence signals scholarly care and forestalls the examiner's objection.

CAUTION: **The philosophical point beneath the rhetoric.** Strip away the polemic and the verse encodes a real argument: *if there is no post-mortem accounting, then the discounting of present goods in favour of future or other-worldly ones is irrational.* That is an argument about the **rationality of deferral under a finite horizon**, and it is answerable — Vātsyāyana himself answers it, in point 4 above, by observing that a refusal to defer would prevent even sowing a crop. Presenting the verse *with* its internal rebuttal is far better than quoting it as a slogan.



5. Positivistic, naturalistic, secular — a first pass at the 2024 label

CAUTION: Full treatment belongs to Subtopic 9 and the workbook, but the ethical material contributes three of the strongest points:

| Label        | Why it fits FACT:                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      | Why it must be qualified CAUTION:                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                     |
|--------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Naturalistic | <i>Svabhāvavāda</i> (doctrine that natural properties explain events); value grounded in embodied pleasure and pain; no supernatural sanction                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                          | The notion of "nature" is descriptive, not analysed into laws                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                         |
| Secular      | Morality is detached from scripture and priesthood; <i>daṇḍanīti</i> (science of punishment and government) and <i>vārttā</i> (livelihood sciences of agriculture, cattle and trade) enter the school; the king, not God, is the guarantor of order                                                                                                                                                                    | The detachment is polemical rather than institutional; no political theory survives                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                   |
| Positivistic | FACT: Chatterjee and Datta apply the word themselves: the theory "may also be called positivism, because it believes only in <b>positive facts or observable phenomena</b> "; they add that the Cārvāka (Indian materialist and perception-centred school) view "that no inference can yield certain knowledge is the view of many contemporary Western thinkers like the <b>pragmatists and logical positivists</b> " | CAUTION: Positivism venerates <b>science</b> , which is built on inference; Cārvāka (Indian materialist and perception-centred school) attacks inference. Positivism has a constructive programme; Cārvāka (Indian materialist and perception-centred school) has a polemical minimalism. And Comte's positivism carries a philosophy of history and a sociology entirely absent here |



Exam link

Primary routes: 2020 Q7(c) and 2024 Q5(a). Keep ethics source-critical, separate prudence from morality, and compare Cārvāka with Jainism or positivism only on named axes.



Traps and recap



UPSC traps

- CAUTION: Do not reduce Cārvāka ethics to reckless sensualism. The textbooks themselves distinguish *dhūrta* from *suśikṣita* Cārvākas.
- CAUTION: Do not say Cārvāka rejects *dharma* because he prefers pleasure. He rejects it because it is a **scriptural** category, and *śabda* is not a *pramāṇa*.
- CAUTION: Do not treat *artha* as a second end. It is explicitly a **means** to *kāma*.
- QUESTION: Do not quote the "ghee and debt" verse as Cārvāka scripture. It is preserved in the *Sarva-darśana-saṃgraha*, an opponent's compendium.
- CAUTION: Do not call Vātsyāyana a Cārvāka without qualification. He "believes in God and in life after death" and is a materialist only "according to a wider sense of the term".
- CAUTION: Do not omit *daṇḍanīti*, *vārttā* and the king-as-God report if the question touches the school's social or political meaning.
- CAUTION: Do not answer the 2020 Jainism comparison with "materialism versus spirituality". Run the axes: *pramāṇas*, definition of the real, constituents, *ākāśa*, soul, substance–mode, standpoint, karma, liberation.
- CAUTION: Do not forget that Jainism holds consciousness to be the soul's **inseparable essence**, expressly denying the Cārvāka view that it is "a mere accidental property, arising only under some conditions".
- CAUTION: Do not present Sharma's harsh verdict and Chatterjee and Datta's sympathetic one as a contradiction. They target different objects — the transmitted doctrine and the historical movement.



Revision notes

- FACT: *kāma evaikaḥ puruṣārthaḥ* — enjoyment is the only end; *artha* is its **means**; *dharma* and *mokṣa* are rejected.
- FACT: *Dharma* is rejected on **epistemic** grounds: virtue and vice are "distinctions made by the scriptures, whose authority cannot be rationally accepted".
- FACT: Criterion of right action: a good action yields a balance of pleasure; a bad one brings more pain than pleasure. Hence hedonism.
- FACT: **Dhūrta** (cunning/crude) versus **suśikṣita** (cultured/refined) Cārvākas — the textbooks refuse a single, gross portrait.
- FACT: Evidence for refinement: the sixty-four fine arts (*catuḥ-ṣaṣṭi-kalāḥ*); *daṇḍanīti* and *vārttā* incorporated into Lokāyata; some Cārvākas regard the **king as God**.
- FACT: **Vātsyāyana** is "the best positive evidence of refined hedonism" — but he believes in God and an afterlife and so is a materialist only "in a wider sense".
- FACT: Vātsyāyana's regulation: *brahmacarya*, urbanity (*nāgarika-vṛtti*), education of the senses, and the argument that refusing to defer would prevent even sowing a crop.
- FACT: Chatterjee and Datta: "Egoistic hedonism in its gross form is not compatible with social discipline."

- CAUTION: Sharma's counterweight: "crude individual hedonism"; the school fell through "the denial of all human values"; "the pleasure of the pig is certainly not the same as the pleasure of the philosopher."
- QUESTION: The "ghee and debt" verse comes from the *Sarva-darśana-saṃgraha* — an opponent's compendium; quote with caution, and extract the argument about deferral under a finite horizon.
- FACT: Chatterjee and Datta apply the word **positivism** to Cārvāka themselves — "because it believes only in positive facts or observable phenomena" — and compare its view of inference to the pragmatists and logical positivists.
- FACT: **2020 comparison:** one *pramāṇa* versus five kinds of knowledge · four *bhūtas* versus six *dravyas* · *ākāśa* rejected versus accepted · no soul versus infinite *jīvas* with consciousness as inseparable essence · single standpoint versus *anekāntavāda* and *syādvāda* · no karma versus **material** karma · no liberation versus *mokṣa* and *kevala-jñāna*.
- CAUTION: Shared ground with Jainism: both *nāstika*, both realist about the perceptible world, both reject a creator God.
- CAUTION: Verdict: Cārvāka's ethics is a coherent theory of **prudence** and an incomplete theory of **morality**.



9. Comparative Synthesis and Answer-Writing Architecture

**ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM:** Final verdict: Cārvāka (Indian materialist school) is philosophically strongest as a critique of dogmatism and weak inference, but its restriction of knowledge to perception is too narrow to explain science, ordinary reasoning and its own universal claims.



Plain-language visual - the complete answer spine

PERCEPTION ONLY  
|  
INFERENCE / TESTIMONY REJECTED  
|  
FOUR-ELEMENT MATERIALISM  
|  
BODY-SELF + NO TRANSCENDENT ENTITIES  
|  
ARTHA (material prosperity or practical means) AS MEANS + KAMA AS END  
|  
BALANCED VERDICT: critical empiricism, but too narrow for science

**In simple words:** every Cārvāka answer should show a chain, not a list. Begin with the epistemic rule, derive the metaphysics and ethics, then evaluate both the achievement and the cost.

| Marks | Fast structure                                          |
|-------|---------------------------------------------------------|
| 10    | Define -> derive -> one objection -> verdict            |
| 15    | Reconstruct -> example -> criticism/reply -> evaluation |
| 20    | Full dialectic -> comparison -> graded conclusion       |

**One-line memory:** ONE *pramāṇa*, FOUR elements, TWO accepted aims, ZERO transcendent entities.



VISUAL: MASTER CONCEPT MAP — the whole syllabus item on one page

+=====+  
| C A R V A K A / L O K A Y A T A |  
| Paper I . Section B . Syllabus item 12 .

9 owned PYQ parts |  
+=====+

[1] SOURCES [2] EPISTEMOLOGY [3] ANTI-INFERENCE  
Brhaspati-sutra LOST pratyaksa (perception) alone vyapti (invariable concomitance) unprovable:  
hostile doxography bahya + antara - not by perception  
Jayarasi = extreme "no doubt + true to - not by inference  
nastika (rejects Veda) reality" standard - not by testimony  
| | upadhi (hidden limiting condition): wet fuel  
| | deduction = circular  
| | induction = unwarranted  
+-----+-----+-----+  
| |  
[4] NYAYA (school of logic and epistemology) REPLY | | SELF-REFUTATION CHARGE  
anvaya-vyatireka (joint method of agreement in presence and absence) | | "the denial is itself  
upadhi-elimination| | a universal"  
tarka (hypothetical or reductio reasoning) (auxiliary) | | replies: no-thesis /  
samanyalaksana | | softened / level-distinction  
paramarsa | |  
warrant, not | |  
omniscience | |  
v v  
[5] METAPHYSICS -----> [7] REJECTION OF  
4 bhutas, NO akasa (ether or space as an element) TRANSCENDENT ENTITIES  
elements eternal, combinations not atman (enduring self or soul) . isvara (Lord or creator God) . karma (action and its morally consequential residue)  
bhuta-caitanya-vada adrsta . rebirth . svarga (heaven)  
betel (compositional emergence) naraka . moksa (liberation) .

Veda  
fermentation (transformational) ritual reductions:  
svabhavavada (doctrine that natural properties explain events) + yadrcchavada sraddha . upstairs . jyotistoma  
| |  
v v  
[6] SELF [8] ETHICS  
dehatmavada (doctrine that the conscious living body is the self) kama = end, artha (material prosperity or practical means) = means  
caitanya-visistah kayah purusah dharma (doctrine, duty or constitutive factor, as context requires) rejected (scriptural)  
"I am fat / lame / blind" moksa (liberation) rejected (dilemma)  
vs BUDDHISM: relocation vs dissolution dhurta vs susiksita  
vs NYAYA (school of logic and epistemology): no atman (enduring self or soul) at all Vatsyayana . 64 arts  
Sharma's 9 objections dandaniti . varta . King-as-God  
| |  
+-----+-----+-----+  
| |  
v  
[9] SYNTHESIS : positivistic? . vs Jainism . vs Buddhism . vs Nyaya (school of logic and epistemology)  
graded verdicts . 10/15/20 architecture . PYQ routing





1. The master comparison table

| Axis                                                    | Cārvāka (Indian materialist and perception-centred school)                                    | Nyāya (school of logic and epistemology)–Vaiśeṣika (school of categories and atomism)                                                                             | Buddhism                                                                                                                           | Jainism                                                                                                                       |
|---------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <i>Pramāṇas</i> (plural form: means of valid knowledge) | FACT: 1 — perception                                                                          | FACT: 4 — perception, inference, comparison, testimony                                                                                                            | FACT: 2 — perception, inference                                                                                                    | FACT: Fivefold knowledge; inference admitted                                                                                  |
| Elements / substances                                   | FACT: 4 <i>bhūtas</i> (material elements), no <i>ākāśa</i> (ether or space as an element)     | FACT: 9 <i>dravyas</i> (plural form: substance), including <i>ākāśa</i> (ether or space as an element), <i>ātman</i> (enduring self or soul), <i>manas</i> (mind) | CAUTION: <i>Dharmas</i> (plural form: doctrine, duty or constitutive factor, as context requires), momentary                       | FACT: 6 <i>dravyas</i> (plural form: substance), including <i>ākāśa</i> (ether or space as an element) and <i>kāla</i> (time) |
| Self                                                    | FACT: Living body ( <i>dehātmavāda</i> (doctrine that the conscious living body is the self)) | FACT: Eternal substantial <i>ātman</i> (enduring self or soul)                                                                                                    | FACT: No self; five <i>skandhas</i> (five aggregates constituting the person-process), <i>santāna</i> (causal continuum or stream) | FACT: Infinite <i>jīvas</i> (plural form: living soul or conscious being); consciousness their inseparable essence            |
| Consciousness                                           | FACT: Emergent by-product of matter                                                           | FACT: Adventitious quality of <i>ātman</i> (enduring self or soul)                                                                                                | FACT: <i>Vijñāna</i> (consciousness), one conditioned <i>skandha</i> (aggregate constituting the person-process)                   | FACT: Essence of the soul, obscured by karma (action and its morally consequential residue)                                   |
| God                                                     | FACT: Rejected; <i>svabhāva</i> (intrinsic own-nature) suffices                               | FACT: Proved by <i>kāryāt</i> , <i>āyojanāt</i> , <i>dhṛtyādeḥ</i> , <i>padāt</i> / <i>śruteḥ</i>                                                                 | FACT: Rejected; conditions suffice                                                                                                 | FACT: No creator; godhood attained by the <i>siddha</i>                                                                       |
| Karma (action and its morally consequential residue)    | FACT: Rejected as unseen                                                                      | FACT: Accepted; <i>adṛṣṭa</i> (unseen causal force), God as dispenser                                                                                             | FACT: Accepted; causal-moral continuity                                                                                            | FACT: Accepted; karma (action and its morally consequential residue) as <b>subtle matter</b>                                  |
| Rebirth                                                 | FACT: Rejected                                                                                | FACT: Accepted                                                                                                                                                    | FACT: Accepted, without a self                                                                                                     | FACT: Accepted                                                                                                                |
| Liberation                                              | FACT: None; <i>maraṇam eva apavargaḥ</i>                                                      | FACT: <i>Apavarga</i> (release or liberation) as cessation of pain                                                                                                | FACT: <i>Nirvāṇa</i> (cessation of craving and conditioned suffering)                                                              | FACT: <i>Mokṣa</i> (liberation); <i>kevala-jñāna</i> (perfect omniscience)                                                    |

| Axis              | Cārvāka (Indian materialist and perception-centred school)                 | Nyāya (school of logic and epistemology)–Vaiśeṣika (school of categories and atomism) | Buddhism                                                                       | Jainism                                                                                                                |
|-------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Vedic authority   | FACT: Rejected — hence <i>nāstika</i> (Veda-rejecting or heterodox school) | FACT: Accepted                                                                        | FACT: Rejected                                                                 | FACT: Rejected                                                                                                         |
| Standpoint theory | CAUTION: None; single standpoint                                           | CAUTION: None                                                                         | FACT: <i>Samvṛti</i> (conventional truth) / <i>paramārtha</i> (ultimate truth) | FACT: <i>Anekānta</i> (many-sidedness), <i>naya</i> , <i>syādvāda</i> (doctrine of qualified or conditional assertion) |



2. Criticisms and replies — the consolidated grid

| # | Criticism                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                            | Cārvāka (Indian materialist and perception-centred school)'s best reply                                                                                                                                                       | Residual assessment                                                                                                                            |
|---|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 1 | FACT: <b>Self-refutation</b> : the universal denial of inference is itself inferential; other minds and ideas are never perceived                                                                                                                                    | CAUTION: Soften the thesis to a denial of <i>apodictic certainty</i> , or restrict it to transcendental inference; or advance no thesis at all ( <i>vitaṇḍā</i> ( <i>destructive disputation without a positive thesis</i> )) | CAUTION: Decisive against the strong form; the softened form survives but is a much weaker doctrine                                            |
| 2 | FACT: <b>Science becomes impossible</b> : without induction, no stable knowledge beyond isolated perceptions                                                                                                                                                         | CAUTION: Practical expectations remain available, tied to future perceptual check                                                                                                                                             | CAUTION: Saves practice better than theory; narrows Cārvāka (Indian materialist and perception-centred school) into radical empiricist caution |
| 3 | FACT: <b>Perception itself errs</b> (flat earth, static earth, small sun) — and is corrected <i>by inference</i>                                                                                                                                                     | CAUTION: The corrections are ultimately perceptual and practical; and fallibility about <i>how</i> things appear does not license unperceivable entities                                                                      | CAUTION: Adequate for the flat-earth case, weak for heliocentrism; the hierarchy P over I is genuinely threatened                              |
| 4 | FACT: <b>Emergence does not explain subjectivity</b> : redness and intoxication are public; consciousness is private, and "neither smelt nor tasted nor seen nor touched nor heard"                                                                                  | CAUTION: Positing an immaterial soul renames the gap rather than closing it                                                                                                                                                   | CAUTION: Both sides face the gap; the Cārvāka (Indian materialist and perception-centred school) at least does not claim to have crossed it    |
| 5 | FACT: <b>Dependence is not production</b> : light is necessary for sight but is not its cause; the two horns of a bull are constantly conjoined but not causally related                                                                                             | CAUTION: The instrument-hypothesis needs a user, and no user is perceived; materialism is the more economical of two unproven options                                                                                         | CAUTION: Genuinely undecided; an honest answer says so                                                                                         |
| 6 | FACT: <b>Crude hedonism</b> : no qualitative distinction among pleasures — "the pleasure of the pig"                                                                                                                                                                 | CAUTION: The <i>suśikṣita</i> ( <i>cultivated or refined</i> ) strand, the sixty-four arts, and Vātsyāyana's prudential regulation of desire                                                                                  | CAUTION: Supplies prudence and culture, not an independent standard of value                                                                   |
| 7 | QUESTION: <b>Hostile sources make fair reconstruction impossible</b>                                                                                                                                                                                                 | CAUTION: Convergence across Buddhist, Advaita, Jaina and Vedāntic (relating to an Upaniṣad-based Vedānta tradition) doxographies fixes a doctrinal core                                                                       | CAUTION: Use caution without abandoning content                                                                                                |
| 8 | CAUTION: <b>Same-standpoint inconsistency</b> (Sharma): perception is accepted and inference rejected at the same level, with no <i>vyāvahārika</i> ( <i>practical or conventional level</i> ) / <i>pāramārthika</i> ( <i>ultimate level</i> ) distinction available | CAUTION: Adopt the level-distinction as a repair                                                                                                                                                                              | CAUTION: Effective, but the repair is the interpreter's, not the school's                                                                      |



Exam link

Use the complete 2018–2025 routing matrix and the 10/15/20-mark architecture. Every answer must end in a graded verdict tied to a named criterion.



Traps and recap

The synthesis-stage diagnostic questions are retained in the next section so that the complete Basic teaching remains separate from objective retrieval practice.

## OPTIONAL ADVANCED DEPTH — NOT REQUIRED FOR A CORE ANSWER

Enrichment only. A competent core answer does not require this block. Use it selectively for qualification, comparison, objections/replies and a higher-quality verdict after the Basic doctrine and answer structure are secure. Every substantive legacy Layer 3 point is retained below under the same nine subtopics.



### 1. Historical Reconstruction and the Source Problem



#### SOURCE: Advanced refinement

CAUTION: **Cārvāka was not marginal to Indian philosophy; it was structural.** Chatterjee and Datta make the point in their concluding section and it is worth reproducing as an evaluative sentence: "every system of Indian thought tried to meet the Cārvāka objections and made the Cārvāka a **touchstone** of its theories." They add that its value "lies directly in supplying fresh philosophical problems and indirectly in compelling other thinkers to give up dogmatism, and become critical and cautious in speculation as well as in the statement of views" — and they compare this to Kant's admission that "the scepticism of Hume roused me from my dogmatic slumber."

CAUTION: **Sharma's counterweight, which a balanced answer should also carry:** "Materialism in Indian Philosophy has never been a force. Born in discontent, it soon died in serious thought." The two verdicts are not contradictory: Cārvāka failed as a *positive system* while succeeding as a *critical function*. That two-sided judgement is exactly the graded verdict UPSC rewards.



#### □ Conceptual link (not a current-affairs item)

□ The reconstruction problem here belongs to a general class: how to state fairly a position preserved only in the words of those who rejected it. The same methodological question arises in reading the Greek Sophists through Plato, or the Presocratics through Aristotle. CAUTION: Use this as a *methodological* remark of one sentence. It is a conceptual parallel, **not** a dated development, and it must never be written as though it were news.



### 2. Epistemology — Perception as the Sole *Pramāṇa* (means of valid knowledge)



#### SOURCE: Advanced refinement

CAUTION: **\*\*Cārvāka's scepticism is selective, and Sharma turns that selectivity into an objection.\*\*** Śūnyavāda Buddhism and Advaita Vedānta also reject the *ultimate* validity of inference — but, as Sharma notes, "the Śūnyavādin and the Advaitin reject the ultimate validity of **all** means of knowledge as such **including perception**, though they insist on the empirical validity of all means of knowledge. The distinction between ultimate and empirical knowledge is **unknown to the Cārvāka**. To accept the validity of perception and, at the same time and from the same standpoint, to reject the validity of inference is a thoughtless self-contradiction."

CAUTION: This gives you a **three-way comparison** that very few candidates will produce:

| School                                                      | Perception                                                                  | Inference                                                                   | Level-distinction available?                                                                      |
|-------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Cārvāka (Indian materialist and perception-cent red school) | FACT: Valid, full stop                                                      | □ Rejected, full stop                                                       | □ None — hence Sharma's charge of "same standpoint" inconsistency                                 |
| Śūnyavāda (doctrine of emptiness)                           | CAUTION: Empirically valid, ultimately not                                  | CAUTION: Empirically valid, ultimately not                                  | FACT: <i>Samṃvṛti</i> (conventional truth) / <i>paramārtha</i> (ultimate truth)                   |
| Advaita                                                     | CAUTION: <i>Vyāvahārika</i> (practical or conventional level) validity only | CAUTION: <i>Vyāvahārika</i> (practical or conventional level) validity only | FACT: <i>Vyāvahārika</i> (practical or conventional level) / <i>pāramārthika</i> (ultimate level) |

CAUTION: **The Cārvāka's best available repair**, and you should offer it before evaluating: *adopt the level-distinction*. If the Cārvāka says "inference has *vyāvahārika* usefulness but no *pāramārthika* validity", Sharma's charge of same-standpoint inconsistency loses its grip — at the price of conceding that the doctrine is a thesis about certainty rather than about usability. That is precisely the softened reading defended in Subtopic 3.



□ **Conceptual link (not a current-affairs item)**

□ The Cārvāka analysis of *śabda* — that a hearer's acceptance of testimony always runs through a suppressed premise about the speaker's reliability — is the ancestor of the modern **reductionist** position in the epistemology of testimony, and it is the exact point at issue in contemporary debates about credibility and misinformation. CAUTION: Label it as a conceptual parallel in a single clause if at all; do not import modern examples into a Paper I answer in place of *pratyakṣa*, *anumāna* and *śabda*, and do not present it as a dated event.



**3. The Critique of Inference — *Vyāpti* (invariable concomitance), *Upādhi* (hidden limiting condition), the Socrates Syllogism and Self-Refutation**



**SOURCE: Advanced refinement**

CAUTION: **Distinguish two Cārvāka claims that are constantly run together in scripts:**

CLAIM A (epistemic) : inference does not GUARANTEE truth  
-> defensible; almost universally granted today  
CLAIM B (semantic/ : the words "wherever smoke, there fire" express ontological) no knowable proposition at all  
-> far stronger; hard to hold while doing philosophy

CAUTION: Most of the force of the Cārvāka critique lives in Claim A. Most of the vulnerability to self-refutation lives in Claim B. A first-class answer separates them and says which one it is defending.

CAUTION: **A further refinement on the target.** The Cārvāka's practical inferences are always **perceptually redeemable**: I infer fire, I climb the hill, I see fire. Transcendental inferences are **structurally unredeemable**: I infer heaven from *agnihotra*, and no perception could ever cash the claim. The Cārvāka's position becomes far more defensible when stated as: *an inference is worth something to the extent that its conclusion is in principle perceptually checkable* — which is a verificationist criterion in Indian dress, and is exactly the material needed for the 2024 "positivism" question.



□ **Conceptual link (not a current-affairs item)**

□ The *vyāpti* argument is a strikingly early and complete statement of what Western philosophy calls **the problem of induction**: that no finite set of observations entails an unrestricted universal, and that attempts to justify induction inductively are circular. The *upādhi* argument anticipates the modern problem of **confounding variables** — the possibility that an observed regularity tracks an unnoticed third factor. CAUTION: These are conceptual parallels for one clause of comparative colour, not dated developments, and they must never displace the Indian vocabulary in a Paper I script.



4. The Nyāya (school of logic and epistemology) Defence of Inference — and a Critically Balanced Verdict



SOURCE: Advanced refinement

CAUTION: **What the debate is really about, stated at the highest level.** Both sides agree that finite observation cannot logically entail an unrestricted universal. They disagree about what follows.

CARVAKA : entailment fails => no knowledge => no pramana-status  
NYAYA (school of logic and epistemology) : entailment fails => but WARRANT does not require entailment  
=> disciplined procedure yields knowledge  
=> pramana-status is preserved

CAUTION: The disagreement is therefore about the **concept of knowledge**, not about the logic of induction, on which the two are in near-agreement. Writing that sentence identifies the true locus of the dispute and is the mark of a top script.

CAUTION: **The honest residue against Nyāya**, which a balanced answer must supply so as not to look partisan: (i) *tarka* is admittedly not a *pramāṇa* and cannot by itself establish anything; (ii) *sāmānyalakṣaṇa-pratyakṣa* is defensible only inside Nyāya's realism about universals, so it is not a neutral answer; (iii) the elimination of *upādhis* is always elimination of **suspected** conditions, never a proof that none remains. Nyāya's inference is therefore highly disciplined but not indefeasible — which is precisely what a fallibilist Cārvāka wanted to hear.



□ **Conceptual link (not a current-affairs item)**

□ Nyāya's replacement of certainty by disciplined warrant, with negative-case testing and the systematic elimination of confounders, is conceptually parallel to modern accounts of **inference under uncertainty** — controlled comparison, elimination of alternative explanations, and degrees of confirmation rather than proof. CAUTION: Use at most one clause of this in an answer, explicitly as a conceptual analogy, never as a dated development or as authority.



5. Metaphysics and Materialism — Four *Bhūtas* (material elements), the Rejection of *Ākāśa* (ether or space as an element), and *Svabhāvavāda* (doctrine that natural properties explain events)



SOURCE: Advanced refinement

CAUTION: **Cārvāka materialism is not modern scientific materialism, and saying why is worth marks.**

| Axis                  | Cārvāka (Indian materialist and perception-centred school)       | Modern scientific materialism                            |
|-----------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------|
| Basic entities        | FACT: Four perceptible gross elements                            | Unobservable micro-entities: fields, particles, forces   |
| Attitude to inference | FACT: Denies it <i>pramāṇa</i> (means of valid knowledge)-status | Depends on it absolutely — theory is inference from data |

| Axis                      | Cārvāka (Indian materialist and perception-centred school)                              | Modern scientific materialism                            |
|---------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------|
| Attitude to unobservables | FACT: Refuses them as unwarranted                                                       | Admits them freely when they earn their explanatory keep |
| Method                    | CAUTION: Polemical minimalism                                                           | Experiment, prediction, controlled testing, revision     |
| Status of laws            | CAUTION: <i>Svabhāva</i> (intrinsic own-nature), with no guarantee of future uniformity | Law-like regularities, projectible and quantified        |

CAUTION: **The resulting paradox, which is the best single sentence in this subtopic:** *Cārvāka reaches a materialist conclusion by an anti-inferential route, whereas modern materialism reaches a materialist conclusion by a thoroughly inferential route. The agreement in ontology conceals a total disagreement in method.* That sentence is the pivot of any good answer on whether Cārvāka is "scientific" or "positivistic".



❑ **Conceptual link (not a current-affairs item)**

❑ *Bhūta-caitanya-vāda* is an early statement of what is now called **emergent physicalism**, and the objection pressed above — that redness and intoxicating power are third-person properties whereas consciousness is first-personal — is recognisably the modern **explanatory gap** objection. CAUTION: This is a conceptual parallel offered for one clause of comparative framing. It is not a dated development, it carries no authority, and in a Paper I script it must never displace *bhūta*, *caitanya*, *svabhāva* and the betel and fermentation analogies.



**6. Self, Body and Consciousness — *Dehātmavāda* (doctrine that the conscious living body is the self), and Cārvāka (Indian materialist and perception-centred school) versus Buddhist *Anātman* (no permanent self) (2024, 20 marks)**



**SOURCE: Advanced refinement**

CAUTION: **The point almost no candidate makes, and it is decisive.** Buddhism's *anātman* is **not** a weaker version of Cārvāka's denial; it is a **wider** one. *Rūpa* — material form — is itself one of the five *skandhas*, and is expressly declared not to be self. The Buddhist analysis therefore rules out the Cārvāka's body-self *by name*. Writing this sentence demonstrates that you understand the doctrines rather than the labels: *for the Buddhist, "I am this body" is one of the very identifications that anātman is formulated to dismantle.*

CAUTION: **A second refinement: the Puggalavāda foil.** The authored Buddhism file records that some Buddhists, associated with the Vātsīputrīyas, posited a *pudgala* "neither the same as nor different from the *skandhas*", and that the mainstream criticised this as a relapse towards self-theory. CAUTION: Use this to show that the pressure to preserve a bearer of moral continuity was felt *inside* Buddhism, and was refused — which makes the contrast with Cārvāka, who simply keeps a bearer and makes it material, doubly instructive.



❑ **Conceptual link (not a current-affairs item)**

❑ The Cārvāka–Buddhist–Nyāya triangle is the Indian version of the contemporary three-cornered debate between **substance dualism**, **reductive physicalism** and **bundle or process theories of the self**. CAUTION: Note it in a clause if it helps frame the answer; it is a conceptual parallel only, not a dated development, and the Sanskrit vocabulary must carry the answer.



**7. The Rejection of Transcendent Entities — God, Soul, Karma (action and its morally consequential residue), Rebirth, Heaven, Mokṣa (liberation), Veda and Ritual**



**SOURCE: Advanced refinement**

CAUTION: Cārvāka's atheism is structurally different from every other Indian denial of God, and this comparison is high-value in Paper I and Paper II alike.

| School                                                     | Denies a creator God because                                                                                                                                               | Accepts anumāna (inference)? | Accepts scriptural authority?                    |
|------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------|
| Cārvāka (Indian materialist and perception-centred school) | FACT: No <i>pramāṇa</i> (means of valid knowledge) establishes him, and <i>svabhāva</i> (intrinsic own-nature) suffices                                                    | <input type="checkbox"/> No  | <input type="checkbox"/> No                      |
| Sāṃkhya (dualistic enumeration school)                     | FACT: <i>Prakṛti</i> (primordial material nature) explains evolution; a God is superfluous and would compromise <i>puruṣa</i> (person or conscious principle)'s inactivity | FACT: Yes                    | FACT: Yes                                        |
| Mīmāṃsā (Vedic exegesis school)                            | FACT: The Veda is <i>apauruṣeya</i> (not authored by a human being) and <i>apūrva</i> (unseen ritual potency) matures without a dispenser                                  | FACT: Yes                    | FACT: Yes — supremely                            |
| Jainism                                                    | FACT: The world is uncreated; karma (action and its morally consequential residue) is material and self-operating; but godhood is attained by the liberated soul           | FACT: Yes                    | <input type="checkbox"/> Rejects Vedic authority |
| Buddhism                                                   | FACT: Dependent origination explains arising; an immutable cause cannot yield succession                                                                                   | FACT: Yes                    | <input type="checkbox"/> Rejects Vedic authority |

CAUTION: **The resulting single sentence, which is worth memorising:** *Cārvāka is the only Indian school whose atheism is generated by its epistemology rather than by its cosmology or its soteriology — which is why it also rejects the karma, rebirth and liberation that Sāṃkhya, Mīmāṃsā, Jainism and Buddhism all retain.* Non-theism is common in Indian philosophy; **this-worldliness is Cārvāka's alone.**



☐ **Conceptual link (not a current-affairs item)**

☐ The demand that a postulate be in principle checkable, and the treatment of unfalsifiable claims as unwarranted rather than merely unproved, is conceptually parallel to modern **scientific scepticism** and to verificationist criteria of meaning. CAUTION: Offer this as a labelled conceptual parallel only, and be careful: the parallel is exactly what makes the 2024 "positivism" question tempting *and* what makes an unqualified "yes" to it wrong, since Cārvāka rejects the very inferential machinery on which modern science runs.



8. Ethics and the Political-Social Meaning — and Cārvāka (Indian materialist and perception-centred school) versus Jaina Reality (2020, 15 marks)



SOURCE: Advanced refinement

CAUTION: **Was Cārvāka a social philosophy?** Two pieces of evidence, both from Chatterjee and Datta, suggest more than pure appetite: the incorporation of *daṇḍanīti* (political philosophy, the science of governance) and *vārttā* (economics, the science of livelihood) into the philosophy of the Lokāyatikas; and the report that some Cārvākas "regard the **king as God**". CAUTION: The natural reading is a **secular theory of political authority**: order is guaranteed not by cosmic *dharma* or divine sanction but by the sovereign, and prosperity by the productive arts. QUESTION: The evidence is thin and doxographical, and must be presented as suggestive rather than established — but it is precisely the material that saves a Cārvāka answer from ending in caricature, and it directly supports the "secular" half of the 2024 label.

CAUTION: **A final ethical refinement.** Cārvāka's ethics lacks two things that every rival supplies: a **qualitative** distinction among pleasures (Sharma's "pleasure of the pig") and an account of **other-regarding** obligation. Vātsyāyana supplies a partial answer to the first through cultivation and the fine arts, and Chatterjee and Datta gesture at the second through the necessity of social discipline and the king. But neither is derived from the Cārvāka's own value theory; both are added to it. CAUTION: **The honest verdict:** Cārvāka's ethics is a fully coherent theory of *prudence* and an incomplete theory of *morality*.



☐ **Conceptual link (not a current-affairs item)**

□ Cārvāka's grounding of value in embodied pleasure and pain, without supernatural sanction, is conceptually parallel to modern **secular and naturalistic ethics**; and the *dhūrta* / *suśikṣita* distinction mirrors the Western contrast between crude and refined, or quantitative and qualitative, hedonism. CAUTION: Conceptual parallel only, offered in a clause; not a dated development, and never a substitute for *puruṣārtha*, *kāma*, *artha* and the Sanskrit sources.



9. Comparative Synthesis and Answer-Writing Architecture



3. Five verdicts you may safely defend

- CAUTION: Each of these is defensible, criterion-named and examiner-friendly. Choose according to the question.
- "Cārvāka's epistemology is more successful as a critique of certainty than as a theory of knowledge."
  - "Cārvāka's ontology is impeccably derived from its epistemology; its vulnerability is therefore located entirely in that epistemology, not in its metaphysics."
  - "Cārvāka wins the argument that finite observation cannot entail an unrestricted universal, and loses the argument that this abolishes inference as a *pramāṇa* — because Nyāya replaces the demand for omniscient certainty with a demand for disciplined warrant."
  - "Cārvāka denies the transcendence of the self while retaining its substantiality; Buddhism denies its substantiality while retaining its moral continuity. The two denials are not species of one genus."
  - "Cārvāka is a complete theory of prudence and an incomplete theory of morality; its historical value is critical rather than constructive — it was, as Chatterjee and Datta put it, the touchstone on which every other system tested itself."



4. Is Cārvāka (Indian materialist and perception-centred school) positivistic? — the full treatment of the 2024 demand

CAUTION: The question ("Do you think Cārvāka's philosophy is positivistic in nature? Give reasons and justifications") invites a **graded** answer. A flat yes or a flat no both lose marks. Structure it as three movements.

CAUTION: **Movement 1 — establish that the label is not imported by the examiner.** FACT: Chatterjee and Datta apply it themselves: "The Cārvāka theory on the whole may also be called **positivism**, because it believes only in positive facts or observable phenomena." They also compare its view of inference to that of "the pragmatists and logical positivists". This is a decisive evidential point: you are not being asked to invent a comparison, you are being asked to test one already present in the tradition of exposition.

CAUTION: **Movement 2 — the case for the label:**

| Respect                   | Cārvāka (Indian materialist and perception-centred school)                                            | Positivism                                           |
|---------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------|
| Criterion of the knowable | FACT: Only what is presented in perception                                                            | Only what is empirically verifiable                  |
| Attitude to metaphysics   | FACT: Transcendent entities are rejected as unwarranted                                               | Metaphysical statements are rejected as unverifiable |
| Attitude to theology      | FACT: God and afterlife have no <i>pramāṇa</i> ( <i>means of valid knowledge</i> )                    | Theological statements are cognitively empty         |
| Attitude to authority     | FACT: Scripture is not an independent source                                                          | Revelation is not evidence                           |
| Register of dismissal     | CAUTION: Questions about rebirth and heaven become <b>"meaningless"</b> (Chatterjee and Datta's word) | Unverifiable statements are meaningless              |



| Respect      | Cārvāka (Indian materialist and perception-centred school) | Positivism                         |
|--------------|------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------|
| Value theory | FACT: Naturalistic, this-worldly, consequential            | Naturalistic and anti-transcendent |

CAUTION: **Movement 3 — the case against, and it is the stronger half:**

| Respect                  | Cārvāka (Indian materialist and perception-centred school)                                      | Positivism                                                                            |
|--------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Inference                | FACT: <b>**Denied <i>pramāṇa</i> (means of valid knowledge)-status**</b> — the fatal divergence | Depends utterly on inference; science is systematised inference                       |
| Unobservables            | FACT: Refused                                                                                   | Freely admitted when they earn their explanatory keep                                 |
| Programme                | CAUTION: Polemical minimalism; no method of confirmation                                        | A constructive programme: unified science, criteria of significance, logical analysis |
| Tools                    | CAUTION: None of formal logic, semantics or probability                                         | Formal logic, verification and confirmation theory, language analysis                 |
| Comte's specific content | CAUTION: Absent                                                                                 | Law of three stages, sociology, a philosophy of history                               |
| Fallibilism              | CAUTION: Demands indubitability, then finds nothing meets it                                    | Accepts corrigible, revisable knowledge as the norm                                   |

CAUTION: **The verdict formula.** *Cārvāka is positivistic in spirit — in its empiricist criterion, its anti-metaphysical temper and its suspicion of unverifiable authority, a resemblance Chatterjee and Datta themselves note. It is not positivistic in method, because positivism is built on the very inference Cārvāka refuses to certify, and possesses a constructive programme that Cārvāka wholly lacks. The safer and more accurate label is radical empiricism or naturalistic materialism; "positivism" is a useful analogy, not a historical identity.* CAUTION: Add the paradox from Subtopic 5: Cārvāka reaches a materialist conclusion by an anti-inferential route, whereas positivism reaches its conclusions by a thoroughly inferential one.



5. India and the West — convergence and divergence

| Western figure or movement | Convergence with Cārvāka (Indian materialist and perception-centred school) CAUTION: | Divergence CAUTION:                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                              |
|----------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Epicurus / Lucretius       | Materialist atomism; this-worldly ethics; freedom from fear of the gods and of death | Epicurus offers <i>ataraxia</i> and a theory of prudent, qualitatively ordered pleasure; Cārvāka (Indian materialist and perception-centred school) as transmitted offers no such refinement — though the <i>suśikṣita</i> ( <i>cultivated or refined</i> ) strand approaches it |
| Hume                       | Induction cannot be rationally justified; causal relation is not perceived           | Hume grounds inference in custom and treats it as psychologically indispensable, retaining it as knowledge; Cārvāka (Indian materialist and perception-centred school) denies it <i>pramāṇa</i> ( <i>means of valid knowledge</i> )-status outright                              |
| Logical positivism (Ayer)  | Suspicion of unverifiable metaphysics; the "meaningless" register                    | Ayer preserves scientific inference and analyses meaning through formal tools absent in India                                                                                                                                                                                    |
| Comte                      | Rejection of theological explanation in favour of observable phenomena               | Comte's positivism is a philosophy of history and a science of society; Cārvāka (Indian materialist and perception-centred school) has neither                                                                                                                                   |
| Contemporary physicalism   | Consciousness as arising from material organisation                                  | Modern physicalism is inference-driven and posits unobservables freely                                                                                                                                                                                                           |

CAUTION: **Chatterjee and Datta's own comparative line, which is safe to quote in substance:** the criticism of inference put in the Cārvāka's mouth "reminds us of similar criticism made in modern times against the soundness of deductive logic", and the Cārvāka view "that no inference can yield certain knowledge is the view of many contemporary Western thinkers like the pragmatists and logical positivists." They also compare the school's fate to that of the Epicureans of Greece, who "have been more hated than understood".



Canonical cross-school and answer-depth ledgers



6A. PRESUPPOSITION LEDGER CAUTION:

| Doctrine                                                                                | Presupposition                                                                                                                  | What collapses if denied                                                                                                                           |
|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Perception as sole pramāṇa (means of valid knowledge)                                   | Immediate presentation is the only secure mark of knowledge                                                                     | The entire anti-inference and anti-scripture programme loses its foundation                                                                        |
| Vyāpti (invariable concomitance) critique                                               | Universality must be certain, not merely probable, to ground pramāṇa-status (status as an independent means of valid knowledge) | Anumāna (inference) can be rehabilitated as disciplined fallible knowledge                                                                         |
| Upādhi (hidden limiting condition) problem                                              | Hidden conditions can always qualify observed regularities                                                                      | Nyāya-style upādhi-elimination (removal of hidden limiting conditions) can secure reliable universals                                              |
| Rejection of śabda (verbal testimony)                                                   | Words require independent proof of speaker competence and truth                                                                 | Veda, reliable testimony, and social knowledge regain pramāṇa-status (status as an independent means of valid knowledge)                           |
| Four bhūtas (material elements) and rejection of ākāśa (ether or space as an element)   | Only perceptibly grounded elements are ontologically admissible                                                                 | A fifth element can be inferred from sound or spatial accommodation                                                                                |
| Bhūta-caitanya (consciousness emergent from material elements) / emergent consciousness | Consciousness can arise from organized material elements                                                                        | A non-material self or consciousness-substance becomes necessary                                                                                   |
| Rejection of karma (action and its morally consequential residue) and rebirth           | No unseen moral continuity is perceptually established                                                                          | Dharma (doctrine, duty or constitutive factor, as context requires), rebirth, and liberation-soteriology regain metaphysical force                 |
| Svabhāvavāda (doctrine that natural properties explain events)                          | Observable natures are enough to explain regularity                                                                             | Divine will, adṛṣṭa (unseen causal force), karma (action and its morally consequential residue), or teleology may be invoked as deeper explanation |

| Doctrine                        | Presupposition                                                          | What collapses if denied                                                                                                                                                             |
|---------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Hedonist ethics                 | Value must be anchored in embodied this-worldly experience              | Dharma (doctrine, duty or constitutive factor, as context requires) and mokṣa (liberation) can override kāma (pleasure or desire) and artha (material prosperity or practical means) |
| Rejection of mokṣa (liberation) | Bondage and liberation require an unproved self and post-mortem destiny | The whole puruṣārtha (goal of human life) scheme beyond worldly life becomes defensible                                                                                              |



6B. PŪRVAPAKṢA (opponent's prima-facie position)–SIDDHĀNTA (established conclusion) LEDGER CAUTION:

| Objector                                                     | Objection                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                | Cārvāka (Indian materialist and perception-centred school) reply                                                                                                                                                                                                     | Residual force CAUTION:                                                                                                                                                                              |
|--------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Nyāya (school of logic and epistemology)                     | Self-refutation: rejection of inference is itself inferential. Vyāpti (invariable concomitance) is securable through upādhi-elimination (removal of hidden limiting conditions), tarka (hypothetical or reductio reasoning), and sāmānyalakṣaṇa-pratyakṣa (extraordinary perception of a universal character). The self is proved because desire, aversion, effort, pleasure, pain, and cognition inhere in a substance. | Dogmatic wing: inference never reaches certainty because vyāpti (invariable concomitance) cannot be secured. Sceptical/Jayarāśi (Cārvāka-associated radical sceptic) wing: the Naiyāyika (adherent of the Nyāya school)’s own definitions fail from within. CAUTION: | Nyāya (school of logic and epistemology) gives the strongest systematic defence of inference; Cārvāka (Indian materialist and perception-centred school) must either soften or face self-refutation. |
| Buddhism                                                     | Karma (action and its morally consequential residue) and rebirth are accepted without eternal ātman (enduring self or soul); momentariness does not imply materialism. Buddhists also accept inference as valid.                                                                                                                                                                                                         | CAUTION: Reconstructed reply: rebirth and karma (action and its morally consequential residue) still outrun perception; momentary streams are as unseen as souls when used to explain post-mortem continuity.                                                        | Buddhism avoids eternal soul while preserving moral continuity, making it a subtler opponent than theism.                                                                                            |
| Jainism                                                      | Consciousness cannot be a property of elements because elements individually lack it; an emergent property needs a bearer.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                               | CAUTION: Reconstructed reply: combinations may display novel properties absent in parts; positing jiva (living soul or conscious being) adds an unperceived substance.                                                                                               | Emergence is asserted more than explained; Jaina pluralism exposes the bearer-problem.                                                                                                               |
| Advaita / Vedānta (Upaniṣad-based end-of-the-Veda tradition) | Consciousness is self-luminous; the body is known by consciousness, so it cannot be the source of consciousness.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                         | CAUTION: Reconstructed reply: “self-luminosity” is a metaphysical description of experienced awareness, not proof of a disembodied ātman (enduring self or soul).                                                                                                    | The subject-object problem remains hard for materialist emergence.                                                                                                                                   |
| Mīmāṃsā (Vedic exegesis school)                              | The Veda’s authority is intrinsic; ridicule of ritual is not an argument against apauruṣeyatva (authorlessness) or dharma (doctrine, duty or constitutive factor, as context requires).                                                                                                                                                                                                                                  | Dogmatic reply: intrinsic authority is not perceived; testimony needs proof, and ritual results are unseen. CAUTION:                                                                                                                                                 | Mīmāṃsā (Vedic exegesis school) has a sophisticated theory of language and obligation; satire alone is insufficient.                                                                                 |
| Yoga / Sāṃkhya (dualistic enumeration school)                | Puruṣa (person or conscious principle) is distinct from prakṛti (primordial material nature); experience, agency, and liberation require a consciousness-principle beyond matter.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                        | CAUTION: Reconstructed reply: puruṣa (person or conscious principle) is not perceived apart from embodied awareness; liberation is a projection from metaphysical dualism.                                                                                           | Cārvāka (Indian materialist and perception-centred school) struggles to explain witness-consciousness, discipline, and the felt distinction between body and awareness.                              |



6C. INTER-SCHOOL POSITIONING CAUTION:

| School                                                                   | Pramāṇas (plural form: means of valid knowledge)                                                                                                     | Self                                                       | Consciousness                                                                                                        | Karma (action and its morally consequential residue)/rebirth | Scripture                                                  | God                                                                  | Puruṣārthas (goals of human life)                                                                                                                                                        | Liberation                                                  |
|--------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------|
| Cārvāka<br>(Indian materialist and perception-centred school)            | Pratyakṣa (perception) alone in strict doctrine; lokasiddha (established in ordinary worldly practice) inference only as practical habit<br>CAUTION: | Body-self; no surviving ātman (enduring self or soul)      | Emergent bhūta-caitanya (consciousness emergent from material elements)                                              | Rejected                                                     | Rejected as independent pramāṇa (means of valid knowledge) | Rejected                                                             | Kāma (pleasure or desire) and artha (material prosperity or practical means) emphasized; dharma (doctrine, duty or constitutive factor, as context requires)/mokṣa (liberation) rejected | Rejected                                                    |
| Nyāya-Vaiśeṣika<br>(combined realist traditions of logic and categories) | Perception, inference, comparison, testimony                                                                                                         | Enduring ātman-substance                                   | Quality of self, revealed through cognition                                                                          | Accepted                                                     | Accepted as reliable testimony                             | Generally affirmed in later Nyāya (school of logic and epistemology) | All four                                                                                                                                                                                 | Apavarga (release or liberation)                            |
| Buddhism                                                                 | Varies; perception and inference central in epistemological schools                                                                                  | No enduring ātman (enduring self or soul)                  | Stream of momentary consciousness/events                                                                             | Accepted without eternal self                                | Buddhist teaching accepted within its framework            | Creator-God denied                                                   | Path-oriented revaluation                                                                                                                                                                | Nirvāṇa (cessation of craving and conditioned suffering)    |
| Jainism                                                                  | Multiple pramāṇas (plural form: means of valid knowledge) with standpoint theory                                                                     | Plural jīvas (plural form: living soul or conscious being) | Intrinsic to jīva (living soul or conscious being), obscured by karma (action and its morally consequential residue) | Accepted                                                     | Jaina teaching authoritative                               | Creator-God denied                                                   | Ethical-spiritual discipline                                                                                                                                                             | Mokṣa (liberation) of jīva (living soul or conscious being) |

| School                                                                           | Pramāṇas (plural form: means of valid knowledge)                                                                                   | Self                                                                                      | Consciousness                                                | Karma (action and its morally consequential residue)/rebirth | Scripture                                                                                      | God                                                                                                     | Puruṣārthas (goals of human life)                                           | Liberation                                                                                            |
|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Sāṃkhya-Yoga (paired traditions of dualist enumeration and disciplined practice) | Perception, inference, reliable testimony                                                                                          | Puruṣa (person or conscious principle) distinct from prakṛti (primordial material nature) | Puruṣa (person or conscious principle) as pure consciousness | Accepted                                                     | Accepted                                                                                       | Classical Sāṃkhya (dualistic enumeration school) non-theistic; Yoga admits Īśvara (Lord or creator God) | All four subordinated to release                                            | Kaivalya                                                                                              |
| Mīmāṃsā (Vedic exegesis school)                                                  | Perception, inference, comparison, postulation, non-cognition, śabda (verbal testimony) in developed lists                         | Enduring self                                                                             | Attribute/manifestation tied to self                         | Accepted                                                     | Veda intrinsically authoritative                                                               | Creator-God not central                                                                                 | Dharma (doctrine, duty or constitutive factor, as context requires) central | Often secondary to ritual/dharma (doctrine, duty or constitutive factor, as context requires), varies |
| Advaita Vedānta (Upaniṣad-based end-of-the-Veda tradition)                       | Six pramāṇas (plural form: means of valid knowledge) commonly accepted, with śruti (revealed Vedic scripture) decisive for Brahman | Ātman (enduring self or soul) identical with Brahman                                      | Self-luminous consciousness                                  | Empirical-level acceptance                                   | Upaniṣadic (relating to the philosophical Upaniṣads) śruti (revealed Vedic scripture) decisive | Īśvara (Lord or creator God) at empirical level                                                         | Mokṣa (liberation) supreme                                                  | Liberation through knowledge                                                                          |

**Why Cārvāka matters structurally.** CAUTION: Cārvāka is the standing **pūrvapakṣa** of Indian philosophy. Nyāya clarifies vyāpti by answering it; Mīmāṃsā sharpens Vedic authority against it; Buddhism and Jainism defend karma without crude eternalism; Vedānta defends self-luminosity against body-materialism. Knowing Cārvāka well therefore improves answers on pramāṇa, scripture, karma, self, and liberation across the whole Indian syllabus.



6D. CONTROLLED WESTERN COMPARISON CAUTION:

| Western comparator                                         | Point of contact                                                                                                                                                                                             | Decisive disanalogy                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                           |
|------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Hume                                                       | Both question whether observed conjunctions establish necessary universal connection; both are suspicious of metaphysical entities such as substance, soul, and God when they outrun impressions/perception. | Hume does not deny that we should reason inductively; he denies its rational-demonstrative foundation while treating custom as the great guide of life. Cārvāka (Indian materialist and perception-centred school) draws the stronger normative conclusion that inference is not a pramāṇa (means of valid knowledge). Hume targets necessary connexion through impressions and ideas; Cārvāka (Indian materialist and perception-centred school) targets vyāpti (invariable concomitance) through regress and upādhi (hidden limiting condition). Hume’s bundle view of self differs from Cārvāka (Indian materialist and perception-centred school)’s positive deha-ātmavāda (doctrine identifying the conscious body with the self), and Hume has a developed moral psychology unlike Cārvāka (Indian materialist and perception-centred school) hedonism. |
| A.J. Ayer / logical positivism                             | Both reject metaphysics on experience-linked grounds and dismiss God, soul, and afterlife when not verifiable.                                                                                               | Ayer’s claim is semantic: unverifiable metaphysics is meaningless, neither true nor false. Cārvāka (Indian materialist and perception-centred school)’s claim is epistemic/ontological: such entities are not known and therefore not admitted. Ayer preserves scientific theoretical statements through indirect/weak verifiability; strict Cārvāka (Indian materialist and perception-centred school) anti-inference threatens science too. Ayer’s verification principle is charged with self-refutation, paralleling the self-refutation charge against Cārvāka (Indian materialist and perception-centred school).                                                                                                                                                                                                                                       |
| Epicurus / Lucretius                                       | Materialism, rejection of fear-based religion, and this-worldly pleasure make the comparison tempting.                                                                                                       | Epicurean pleasure is ascetic and calculative, aiming at ataraxia (tranquillity); Cārvāka (Indian materialist and perception-centred school) hedonism is usually presented as straightforward embodied enjoyment, though a refined prudential reading is possible.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                            |
| Pyrrhonism / Jayarāṣi (Cārvāka-associated radical sceptic) | Jayarāṣi (Cārvāka-associated radical sceptic)’s sceptical wing and Pyrrhonism both allow ordinary life to continue after suspension or collapse of foundations.                                              | Pyrrhonism seeks tranquillity through epochē (suspension), whereas Jayarāṣi (Cārvāka-associated radical sceptic) works through pramāṇa-definition destruction within Indian debate; do not merge the traditions.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                              |
| Feuerbach / Marx on religion’s social function             | Cārvāka (Indian materialist and perception-centred school)’s charge that ritual is the livelihood of priests anticipates a functional critique of religion as serving human/social interests.                | Feuerbach and Marx build broader theories of projection, alienation, ideology, and society. Cārvāka (Indian materialist and perception-centred school) offers sharp anti-ritual polemic without a historical-materialist theory.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                              |
| Locke / general empiricism                                 | Knowledge must be tied to experience; innate or purely speculative metaphysical claims are distrusted.                                                                                                       | Locke and most empiricists accept abstraction, probability, testimony, and science-friendly inference. Cārvāka (Indian materialist and perception-centred school)’s strict pratyakṣa-only (restricted to perception alone) thesis is much narrower and more disruptive.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                       |

**Rubric.** CAUTION: Western parallels are illustrative only, never a substitute for the Indian argument, and belong in at most one or two lines **after** the Cārvāka case is complete. These are conceptual analogies, not historical influences. Writing “Cārvāka is the Indian Hume” without stating the disanalogies is a marked weakness.



6E. DIRECTIVE DECODER CAUTION:

| Directive                       | What the examiner is testing      | Structural move for a Cārvāka (Indian materialist and perception-centred school) answer                                                                                                                                              | Closing verdict                                                                                                          |
|---------------------------------|-----------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Discuss                         | Breadth and balanced presentation | State doctrine -> explain pramāṇa (means of valid knowledge) basis -> show metaphysical consequences -> add one criticism                                                                                                            | "Cārvāka (Indian materialist and perception-centred school) is best read as radical epistemic economy, not mere denial." |
| Examine                         | Internal logic                    | Trace how pratyakṣa-only (restricted to perception alone) leads to anti-inference and anti-transcendence                                                                                                                             | "The conclusion follows if its strict perceptual premise is accepted."                                                   |
| Critically examine              | Doctrine plus objections          | Present Cārvāka (Indian materialist and perception-centred school) argument, then Nyāya (school of logic and epistemology)/Vedānta (Upaniṣad-based end-of-the-Veda tradition)/Mīmāṃsā (Vedic exegesis school) objections and replies | "Powerful as critique, unstable as complete system."                                                                     |
| Analyse                         | Component-wise causal logic       | Break into pramāṇa (means of valid knowledge), vyāpti (invariable concomitance), upādhi (hidden limiting condition), śabda (verbal testimony), ontology, ethics                                                                      | "Its metaphysics is generated by epistemology."                                                                          |
| Evaluate                        | Final judgement required          | Weigh strengths, weaknesses, and contested source-history                                                                                                                                                                            | "Valuable negative philosophy; limited positive account."                                                                |
| Compare                         | Relation with another school      | Use fixed axes: pramāṇa (means of valid knowledge), self, consciousness, karma (action and its morally consequential residue), liberation                                                                                            | "Similarity at one point must not hide doctrinal difference."                                                            |
| Distinguish                     | Sharp contrasts                   | Define both terms/schools first, then contrast on 4–5 axes                                                                                                                                                                           | "The safest answer is difference plus one connecting insight."                                                           |
| Elucidate / Comment / Bring out | Clarity of explanation            | Give thesis, one argument, one example, one implication                                                                                                                                                                              | "This shows why the doctrine matters in the larger system."                                                              |

| Directive                                                                                                           | What the examiner is testing                            | Structural move for a Cārvāka (Indian materialist and perception-centred school) answer                                                                                                                                                       | Closing verdict                                                                                                                               |
|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Do you agree?                                                                                                       | Reasoned personal verdict                               | State qualified agreement/disagreement after doctrinal exposition                                                                                                                                                                             | "Agree with its critique of unwarranted transcendence, not with its total pramāṇa (means of valid knowledge) restriction."                    |
| "Cārvāka (Indian materialist and perception-centred school)'s rejection of X is self-refuting — critically examine" | Ability to handle the recurring self-refutation pattern | Show why the dogmatic wing is vulnerable; then introduce lokasiddha (established in ordinary worldly practice) inference and Jayarāśi (Cārvāka-associated radical sceptic)'s prasaṅga-style (reductio-based argumentative style) escape route | "The charge is decisive only against an absolute denial of all reasoning; it is weaker against refined empiricism or dialectical scepticism." |



**6F. GRADED VERDICT ON CĀRVĀKA (Indian materialist and perception-centred school) CAUTION:****Strong FACT:**

- A genuine early principle of epistemic economy: do not multiply unseen entities without warrant.
- A real and still powerful problem about the warrant for universals and vyāpti.
- A valuable naturalistic check on speculative metaphysics, ritualism, and unverifiable claims.
- A functional critique of ritual religion as serving priestly livelihood rather than truth.
- In Jayarāśi, a serious dialectical scepticism that can challenge every pramāṇa-definition from within.

**Weak CAUTION:**

- The self-refutation problem is serious for the dogmatic wing.
- Svabhāvavāda gives no full account of why natures are stable.
- Bhūta-caitanya asserts emergence but does not adequately explain subjectivity.
- The ethics cannot easily distinguish prudence from impulse unless reconstructed charitably.

**Genuinely contested QUESTION:**

- What the school actually held, because no primary systematic text of the materialist wing survives.
- Whether dhūrta and suśikṣita Cārvāka name real internal schools or hostile doxographical types.
- Whether yadr̥cchāvāda belongs to Cārvāka or is a distinct ahetuvāda option.
- Whether Jayarāśi is properly a Cārvāka or an allied radical sceptic.

**Ready verdicts. CAUTION:**

- **10 marks:** Cārvāka is strongest as an epistemological protest against unverifiable metaphysics, but weakest when its rejection of inference becomes absolute.
- **15 marks:** Its pratyakṣa-only principle powerfully explains the rejection of ātman, karma, Īśvara, and mokṣa; yet Nyāya's self-refutation and vyāpti replies show why it cannot stand as a complete theory of knowledge.
- **20 marks:** The best verdict is graded: dogmatic Cārvāka is vulnerable, refined Cārvāka is a coherent empiricist restriction on supersensible inference, and Jayarāśi's wing is a serious prasaṅga-style scepticism rather than crude materialism.

**Anti-caricature warning. FACT:** A strong UPSC answer presents Cārvāka as a serious epistemological position and standing pūrvapakṣa, not as mere hedonism or a stock joke about pleasure.



# CONSOLIDATED REGISTER RETRIEVAL



## A. Source status

- The *Bṛhaspati-sūtra* is lost.
- Most doctrine survives through refutational doxographies.
- Convergence supports a recoverable core, but exact quotation requires caution.
- Jayarāśi is a sceptical witness associated with the stream, not a simple manual of standard doctrine.



## B. Epistemic thesis

- Standard reconstruction: perception alone is an independent *pramāṇa*.
- External and internal perception ground ordinary cognition.
- Testimony depends on prior trust and is not independently self-validating.
- Practical expectation may be admitted without granting certain inference.



## C. Critique of inference

- Inference requires universal *vyāpti*.
- Perception cannot survey all times, places and cases.
- Inference cannot prove *vyāpti* without circularity or regress.
- Testimony cannot rescue inference if testimony itself depends on inference.



## D. Upādhi (hidden limiting condition) and self-refutation

- Hidden conditions defeat over-broad universals.
- The Socrates syllogism is formally valid but its universal premise remains epistemically contested.
- Absolute denial of inference appears self-refuting.

- A softened reading restricts secure inference, especially about supersensible entities.



E. Nyāya (school of logic and epistemology) reply

- Repeated agreement and difference establish provisional concomitance.
- Elimination of suspected conditions and *tarka* strengthen *vyāpti*.
- Universal-character perception and *parāmarśa* explain inferential cognition.
- Nyāya offers disciplined warrant, not omniscient enumeration.



F. Material reality

- Four perceptible elements: earth, water, fire and air.
- Ether is rejected because it is imperceptible.
- *Svabhāvavāda* explains natural processes without transcendent agency.
- Modern scientific materialism must not be read back into the ancient position.



G. Self and consciousness

- *Dehātmavāda*: the conscious living body is the self.
- Consciousness emerges from material combination, often illustrated through fermentation or betel.
- Death ends the individual because no separable soul remains.
- The explanatory gap between matter and subjectivity remains a serious objection.



H. Transcendent denials

- No independently established ātman, Īśvara, karma, rebirth, heaven, hell or mokṣa.
- Vedic authority and sacrificial claims fail the perceptual test.
- Withholding assent and categorical denial should be distinguished.
- The epistemology drives the metaphysical rejection.



I. Ethics

- *Artha* is the practical means and *kāma* the operative end.
- Pleasure is not automatically momentary recklessness; consequences are perceptible.
- Famous “borrow ghee” style verses require source caution.
- Cārvāka is a this-worldly ethic, not merely an invitation to vice.



J. Comparative map

| Comparison                                         | Cārvāka (Indian materialist and perception-centred school) | Rival                                                                              |
|----------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Jainism                                            | four-element materialism                                   | many-sided realist pluralism                                                       |
| Buddhism                                           | body-self materialism                                      | no-self process theory                                                             |
| Nyāya (school of logic and epistemology)           | perception-only challenge                                  | four <i>pramāṇas</i> (plural form: means of valid knowledge) and inference defence |
| Vedānta (Upaniṣad-based end-of-the-Veda tradition) | no transcendent self                                       | self/Brahman as fundamental                                                        |



K. Labels and evaluation

- “Positivistic” is defensible only as qualified anti-metaphysical empiricism.
- “Naturalistic” fits the rejection of supernatural explanation.
- “Materialist” is central; “scientific materialist” is anachronistic.
- The strongest achievement is epistemic protest; the weakest point is absolute anti-inferentialism.



L. Final answer discipline

- Begin with the hostile-source qualification.
- State the perception-only thesis precisely.
- Reconstruct the *vyāpti/upādhi* argument in steps.
- Connect epistemology to materialism and transcendent denials.

- Present the strongest version before criticism.
  - Add the Nyāya reply or relevant comparative school.
  - End with a graded verdict: powerful critique, incomplete positive epistemology.
- Final judgement: Cārvāka is best read as a disciplined empiricist and materialist challenge to unsupported transcendence. Its historical source problem demands caution, and its absolute rejection of inference remains internally unstable.**



**Detailed inherited nine-subtopic register**

**Register-last rule satisfied. The first matrix separates what is required for a core answer from what is optional enrichment. The detailed nine-register legacy revision set follows, preserving source cautions, Sanskrit terminology, argument spines, comparisons, PYQ routes and rapid recall.**



| CORE BASIC versus OPTIONAL ADVANCED — nine-subtopic recall matrix |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                             |                                                                                                                                                                                                                   |
|-------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Subtopic                                                          | CORE BASIC — required for a competent answer                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                | OPTIONAL ADVANCED — enrichment only                                                                                                                                                                               |
| 1. Source problem                                                 | Lost <i>Bṛhaspati-sūtra</i> (lost aphoristic text traditionally attributed to <i>Bṛhaspati</i> ); hostile doxography; convergent core; cautious use of Jayarāśi (Cārvāka-associated radical sceptic).                                                                                                                                       | Selective transmission; Cārvāka (Indian materialist and perception-centred school) as structural <i>pūrvapakṣa</i> (opponent's <i>prima-facie</i> position) and critical touchstone.                              |
| 2. Sole pramāṇa (means of valid knowledge)                        | <i>Pratyakṣa</i> (perception) alone; external/internal perception; testimony derivative; practical expectation is not certainty.                                                                                                                                                                                                            | Strong versus softened thesis; possible level-distinction is a repair, not secure historical doctrine.                                                                                                            |
| 3. Inference critique                                             | <i>Vyāpti</i> (invariable concomitance) cannot be secured by perception, inference or testimony; <i>upādhi</i> (hidden limiting condition) threatens universality.                                                                                                                                                                          | Problem of induction; perceptual redeemability; self-refutation repairs and residual pressure.                                                                                                                    |
| 4. Nyāya (school of logic and epistemology) defence               | <i>Anvaya-vyatireka</i> (joint method of agreement in presence and absence), suspected- <i>upādhi</i> (hidden limiting condition) elimination, <i>tarka</i> (hypothetical or <i>reductio</i> reasoning), <i>sāmānyalakṣaṇa</i> (universal character), <i>parāmarśa</i> (reflective cognition linking the sign with the universal relation). | Knowledge as disciplined warrant rather than entailment; Nyāya (school of logic and epistemology) remains fallible, not indefeasible.                                                                             |
| 5. Materialism                                                    | Four <i>bhūtas</i> (material elements), no <i>ākāśa</i> (ether or space as an element); <i>bhūta-caitanya</i> (consciousness emergent from material elements); betel/fermentation; <i>svabhāva</i> (intrinsic own-nature).                                                                                                                  | Emergentism and explanatory gap; anti-inferential materialism differs from modern scientific materialism.                                                                                                         |
| 6. Body-self                                                      | <i>Dehātma</i> vāda (doctrine that the conscious living body is the self); conscious living body; first-person predicates; death ends the individual.                                                                                                                                                                                       | Personal identity, privacy, instrument-versus-cause objection, Buddhist process comparison and Puggalavāda (Buddhist personalist school) foil.                                                                    |
| 7. Transcendent denials                                           | No <i>ātman</i> (enduring self or soul), <i>Īśvara</i> (Lord or creator God), <i>karma</i> (action and its morally consequential residue), <i>adṛṣṭa</i> (unseen causal force), rebirth, heaven, hell, <i>mokṣa</i> (liberation) or Vedic authority.                                                                                        | Withholding versus denial; ritual reductios; epistemic atheism versus other Indian non-theisms.                                                                                                                   |
| 8. Ethics/social meaning                                          | <i>Artha</i> (material prosperity or practical means) as means, <i>kāma</i> (pleasure or desire) as end; refined versus crude hedonism; source caution for famous verses.                                                                                                                                                                   | Prudence versus morality; <i>daṇḍanīti</i> (science of punishment and government), <i>vārttā</i> (livelihood sciences of agriculture, cattle and trade), king-as-God report; positivism and naturalism qualified. |

| Subtopic     | CORE BASIC — required for a competent answer                                                                                           | OPTIONAL ADVANCED — enrichment only                                                                     |
|--------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 9. Synthesis | ONE pramāṇa (means of valid knowledge), FOUR elements, TWO operative aims, ZERO transcendent entities; reconstruct before criticising. | Cross-school positioning, controlled comparison, directive decoder and criterion-named graded verdicts. |



Rapid answer spine

SOURCE CAUTION

-> PRATYAKSA (perception) ALONE

-> VYAPTI (invariable concomitance) / UPADHI (hidden limiting condition) CRITIQUE

-> NYAYA (school of logic and epistemology) REPLY

-> FOUR-ELEMENT MATERIALISM

-> BODY-SELF AND EMERGENT CONSCIOUSNESS

-> NO TRANSCENDENT ENTITIES

-> ARTHA (material prosperity or practical means) AS MEANS, KAMA AS END

-> COMPARISON + CRITERION-NAMED VERDICT

Rapid recall: ONE *pramāṇa* · FOUR *bhūtas* · TWO operative aims · ZERO transcendent entities.



PYQ routes at a glance

| Route                         | Verified primary-owned questions                                                                                                                                |
|-------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Inference and consistency     | 2018 Q8(b); 2019 Q5(c); 2019 Q6(c); 2025 Q5(a)                                                                                                                  |
| Materialism and transcendence | 2020 Q6(b); 2021 Q5(e)                                                                                                                                          |
| Comparisons                   | 2020 Q7(c), Cārvāka (Indian materialist and perception-centred school)–Jainism; 2024 Q6(a), Cārvāka (Indian materialist and perception-centred school)–Buddhism |
| Comparative label             | 2024 Q5(a), positivistic nature                                                                                                                                 |



KEYWORD & STATEMENT BANK

| Term                                                                                                        | Rapid meaning                                                                   |
|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <i>Pratyakṣaika-pramāṇavāda</i> (doctrine that perception alone is an independent means of valid knowledge) | Perception alone is an independent <i>pramāṇa</i> (means of valid knowledge)    |
| <i>Vyāpti</i> (invariable concomitance)                                                                     | Exceptionless relation required by inference                                    |
| <i>Upādhi</i> (hidden limiting condition)                                                                   | Hidden qualifying condition that defeats an over-broad universal                |
| <i>Lokasiddha</i> (established in ordinary worldly practice) <i>anumāna</i> (inference)                     | Practical, perception-redeemable expectation; not secure proof of transcendence |
| <i>Dehātmavāda</i> (doctrine that the conscious living body is the self)                                    | The conscious living body is the self                                           |
| <i>Bhūta-caitanya-vāda</i> (doctrine that consciousness emerges from material elements)                     | Consciousness emerges from organised elements                                   |

| Term                                                                   | Rapid meaning                                                                                           |
|------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <i>Svabhāva</i> vāda (doctrine that natural properties explain events) | Natural own-natures replace divine or unseen governance                                                 |
| <i>Yadṛcchā</i> vāda (doctrine of chance or accidental occurrence)     | Accidentalism; association with Cārvāka (Indian materialist and perception-centred school) is contested |

| Term                                                                        | Rapid meaning                                                                                                                         |
|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <i>Dhūrta</i> (cunning or crude) / <i>suśikṣita</i> (cultivated or refined) | Opponent-preserved crude/refined differentiation; use cautiously                                                                      |
| Answer sentence                                                             | Cārvāka (Indian materialist and perception-centred school)'s ontology is the consequence of restricting valid knowledge to perception |



Detailed legacy consolidated register — preserved

Placement note: These register notes come after all teaching and practice, and cover every one of the nine subtopics taught in this session. They are the last-mile revision layer, not a substitute for the session above.



Register 1 — Sources, names and historical setting

| Item                                                                 | Register entry                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                         |
|----------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Syllabus wording                                                     | FACT: "Carvaka : Theory of Knowlegde; Rejection of Transcendent Entities" (printed wording retained)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                   |
| Names                                                                | FACT: <b>Cārvāka (Indian materialist and perception-centred school)</b> ( <i>carv</i> , to chew / <i>cāru-vāk</i> , sweet-worded) · <b>Lokāyata (worldly or common-people's doctrine)</b> ( <i>lokāyata-mata</i> (worldly or common-people's doctrine), view of common people) · <b>Bārhaspatya (tradition attributed to Bṛhaspati)</b> (of Bṛhaspati) |
| Traditional founder                                                  | FACT: Bṛhaspati; his <i>Sūtra</i> (concise aphoristic text) is lost; about a dozen <i>sūtras</i> (plural form: concise aphoristic text) survive as quotations                                                                                                                                                                                          |
| Transmission                                                         | FACT: Known "chiefly" from works that state the views <b>in order to refute them</b>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                   |
| Sharma's verdict on sources                                          | FACT: "The weak points ... are exaggerated and the strong points are omitted. So we get only a faint caricature and not a true picture"                                                                                                                                                                                                                |
| Key doxographies                                                     | FACT: <i>Sarva-darśana-saṃgraha</i> (Compendium of All Philosophical Systems) (Mādhava) · <i>Ṣaḍ-darśana-samuccaya</i> (Haribhadra) · <i>Prabodhacandrodaya</i> (a play, Kṛṣṇamiśra) · <i>Tattvasaṅgraha</i> (Compendium of Principles) (Śāntarakṣita) · <i>Vedāntasāra</i> (Essence of Vedānta) (Sadānanda)                                           |
| Only surviving text                                                  | FACT: <i>Tattvopaplavasīṃha</i> , <b>Jayarāśi (Cārvāka-associated radical sceptic) Bhaṭṭa</b> , c. 8th century CE, published Baroda 1940 — but he attacks <b>perception</b> too and admits not even the elements                                                                                                                                       |
| Six transmitted <i>sūtras</i> (plural form: concise aphoristic text) | FACT: four elements · bodies-senses-objects from combination · consciousness as intoxicating power · <i>caitanya-viśiṣṭaḥ kāyaḥ puruṣaḥ</i> · <i>kāma</i> (pleasure or desire) <i>evaikaḥ puruṣārthaḥ</i> · <i>maraṇam eva apavargaḥ</i>                                                                                                               |

| Item                                                              | Register entry                                                                                                                                                                     |
|-------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <i>Nāstika</i> (Veda-rejecting or heterodox school) — exact sense | FACT: Rejects the <b>authority of the Veda</b> (primary sense); also denies life after death (secondary sense); <i>nāstika</i> (Veda-rejecting or heterodox school) in <b>both</b> |

| Item                        | Register entry                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                               |
|-----------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Historical anchors          | FACT: <b>Ajita Kesakambali</b> ( <i>Majjhima Nikāya</i> (Collection of Middle-Length Discourses); believed only in perception and four elements) · Pūraṇa Kassapa · Makkhali Gosāla · Sañjaya Belaṭṭhiputta ( <i>Sāmaññaphala-sutta</i> (Discourse on the Fruits of the Contemplative Life)) |
| Causes of its rise (Sharma) | FACT: Protest against monkdom and ritual externals; Upaniṣadic (relating to the philosophical Upaniṣads) idealism unsuited to commoners; exploitation and social crisis                                                                                                                      |
| Two standing verdicts       | CAUTION: Chatterjee–Datta: the school was the <b>touchstone</b> of every system · Sharma: "Born in discontent, it soon died in serious thought"                                                                                                                                              |
| Mnemonic                    | MNEMONIC: <b>ONE, FOUR, TWO, ZERO</b> — one <i>pramāṇa</i> (means of valid knowledge), four elements, two <i>puruṣārthas</i> (goals of human life), zero transcendent entities                                                                                                               |



| Register 2 — Epistemology                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                     |
|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| • FACT: <b>Thesis:</b> <i>pratyakṣaika-pramāṇavāda</i> — perception alone is a <i>pramāṇa</i> .                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                               |
| • FACT: "The entire philosophy of the Cārvākas may be said to depend <b>logically</b> on their epistemology" (Chatterjee and Datta).                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                          |
| • FACT: <b>The standard demanded:</b> knowledge "about which we can have no doubt" and "which must be true to reality".                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                       |
| • FACT: <b>Both</b> external ( <i>bāhya</i> ) and internal ( <i>mānasa</i> ) perception are admitted.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                         |
| • FACT: Consciousness <b>is</b> established by perception; what is denied is the inference from consciousness to an immaterial bearer.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                        |
| • FACT: <b>The concession:</b> "in life we very often act unsuspectingly on inference" — but "truth is not an unfailing character of all inferences; it is only an <b>accident</b> , and a <b>separable</b> one."                                                                                                                                                                             |
| • CAUTION: <b>Laukika / vyāvahārika</b> inference (corrigible, perceptually redeemable) versus <b>alaukika / pāramārthika</b> inference (structurally uncheckable). The second is the real target.                                                                                                                                                                                            |
| • FACT: <b>Śabda in five steps:</b> words are heard, hence perceived -> what they <i>mean</i> is unperceived -> acceptance runs through "this authority is reliable; all reliable authority should be accepted" -> that is inference -> hence testimony is "as precarious as inference".                                                                                                      |
| • FACT: <b>The Veda:</b> "the works of some cunning priests who earned their living by duping the ignorant and the credulous".                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                |
| • FACT: Sharma's reductio: if testimony proved <i>vyāpti</i> , "none would be able to infer anything by himself".                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                             |
| • CAUTION: <b>One template kills the rest:</b> <i>upamāna</i> , <i>arthāpatti</i> and <i>anupalabdhi</i> each require an unperceived universal.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                               |
| • CAUTION: <b>Sharma's same-standpoint charge:</b> Śūnyavāda and Advaita reject the <i>ultimate</i> validity of <b>all</b> <i>pramāṇas</i> including perception while retaining empirical validity; the <i>vyāvahārika</i> / <i>pāramārthika</i> distinction is "unknown to the Cārvāka", so accepting perception and rejecting inference at one level is "a thoughtless self-contradiction". |
| • MNEMONIC: <b>Ledger to reproduce:</b> Cārvāka 1 · Vaiśeṣika and Buddhism 2 · Sāṃkhya-Yoga 3 · Nyāya 4 · Prābhākara 5 · Bhāṭṭa and Advaita 6.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                |



| Register 3 — The critique of inference |
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|----------------------------------------|

|                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                 |
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| • FACT: Inference is "a leap in the dark"; some inferences are true only "accidentally".                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                        |
| • FACT: The attack targets the <b>major premise</b> ( <i>vyāpti</i> ), never syllogistic form.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                  |
| • FACT: <b>Door 1 — perception</b> : all cases past, present and future can never be surveyed.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                  |
| • FACT: <b>**The class-character (<i>sāmānya</i>) exchange:**</b> even <i>dhūmatva</i> cannot be perceptually known, since not all smokes are perceived; and a universal-to-universal relation does not license a particular-to-particular inference. "The difficulty of passing from particulars to the universal ... remains here as before." |
| • FACT: <b>Door 2 — inference</b> : <i>petitio principii</i> or regress. Sharma: "Induction is uncertain and deduction is argument in a circle. The logicians, therefore, find themselves stuck up in the mud of inference."                                                                                                                    |
| • FACT: A <b>causal</b> relation is only a species of invariable relation and inherits the same defect.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                         |
| • FACT: <b>Door 3 — testimony</b> : its own validity is inferred; and if inference depended on testimony, no one could infer by himself.                                                                                                                                                                                                        |
| • FACT: <b>Upādhi</b> : the wet-fuel condition — one who infers <b>smoke from fire</b> errs, because fire is attended with smoke only where fuel is wet. Unconditionality "cannot be established beyond doubt by perception, as some conditions may always remain hidden".                                                                      |
| • CAUTION: <i>Upādhi</i> is a problem of the <b>right variable</b> , not of sample size — which is why more observation alone cannot answer it, and why Nyāya must bring in <i>tarka</i> .                                                                                                                                                      |
| • FACT: <b>2019 Socrates syllogism</b> : the form is granted; "All men are mortal" is the <i>vyāpti</i> ; it fails the three doors; the deduction merely re-states an unestablished universal.                                                                                                                                                  |
| • FACT: <b>Self-refutation (Sharma)</b> : the denial is itself a universal; thoughts, ideas and other minds are never perceived; "the self-refuted Cārvāka position is called sheer nonsense and no system of philosophy".                                                                                                                      |
| • CAUTION: <b>Three replies</b> : <i>vitaṇḍā</i> / no-thesis · softened certainty-thesis (strongest) · level-distinction (a repair, not a historical doctrine).                                                                                                                                                                                 |
| • CAUTION: <b>Sharma's tu quoque</b> : flat earth, static earth, small solar disc — perception errs and is corrected <i>by inference</i> ; and mere sensation is not knowledge "unless conception or thought has arranged into order ... the loose threads of sense-data" ( <i>Tattvasaṅgraha</i> ).                                            |
| • MNEMONIC: <b>Verdict formula</b> : the Cārvāka may be <b>consistent</b> or <b>radical</b> , but not both.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                     |



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| <b>Register 4 — The Nyāya (school of logic and epistemology) defence</b>                                                                                                                                                           |
| • FACT: <b>The eight-stage ladder</b> : <i>bhūyodarśana</i> -> <i>upādhi</i> -elimination -> <i>tarka</i> -> <i>sāmānyalakṣaṇa-pratyakṣa</i> -> <i>vyāptigraha</i> -> <i>līṅga-darśana</i> -> <i>parāmarśa</i> -> <i>anumiti</i> . |
| • FACT: <b>Anvaya</b> (wherever <i>hetu</i> , there <i>sādhya</i> ) and <b>vyatireka</b> (where no <i>sādhya</i> , no <i>hetu</i> ) — the joint method; systematic search for negative cases, not mere counting.                   |
| • FACT: <b>Upādhi</b> is a condition that pervades the <i>sādhya</i> but not the <i>hetu</i> ; a defective universal is <b>restated</b> at the correct level — "fire joined with wet fuel".                                        |
| • FACT: <b>Tarka</b> is <i>pramāṇa-anugrahaka</i> , not a <i>pramāṇa</i> : it assumes the contradictory and exhibits <i>aniṣṭa-prasaṅga</i> , removing the doubt that blocks <i>vyāptigraha</i> .                                  |
| • FACT: <b>Sāmānyalakṣaṇa-pratyakṣa</b> : the universal is presented through the particular — Nyāya's direct answer to the class-character objection.                                                                              |
| • FACT: <b>Parāmarśa</b> : the cognition of the mark as qualified by concomitance is the <i>karaṇa</i> of <i>anumiti</i> — hence, for Nyāya, no "leap" occurs at all.                                                              |
| • FACT: <b>Nirvikalpaka / savikalpaka</b> : determinate perception is already conceptually qualified, so the Cārvāka's "pure given" is either pre-cognitive or not pure.                                                           |



- CAUTION: **The decisive move:** replace **omniscient certainty** with **disciplined rational warrant**. "The Nyāya point is not infallibilism but disciplined justificatory practice."
- CAUTION: **Honest residue:** *tarka* proves nothing alone; *sāmānyalakṣaṇa* presupposes realism about universals; only **suspected** *upādhis* can be eliminated.
- FACT: **Cross-school survey (2018 Q8(b)):** Nyāya, Sāṃkhya-Yoga, Mīmāṃsā, Jainism and Buddhism all retain inference; Advaita retains it *vyāvahārika*ally while denying ultimate validity to all *pramāṇas*.
- MNEMONIC: **Verdict:** Cārvāka loses the war and wins a battle — inference survives as **warranted**, not as **indubitable**.



Register 5 — Metaphysics and materialism

- FACT: **Bridging principle:** ontological commitment must not outrun the accepted *pramāṇas*. Name it as a **presupposition**.
- FACT: *pr̥thivyāptejovāyuriti tattvāni* — four *bhūtas*; *tatsamudāye śarīrendriya-viśaya-saṃjñā* — bodies, senses and objects from their combination.
- FACT: Living organisms too are elemental combinations, "reduced on death" to the elements.
- FACT: **The elements are eternal; only their combinations arise and perish** (Sharma). Hence Cārvāka is a **realist** materialism, not a flux doctrine.
- FACT: **Ākāśa rejected** "because it is not perceived but inferred" — the Vaiśeṣika inference from sound to an imperceptible substrate is refused.
- CAUTION: Cārvāka's most defensible line on sound: naturalise it into the perceptible air, rather than abandon the substance–quality scheme he uses for the four elements.
- FACT: *kiṇvādibhyo madaśaktivad vijñānam* — consciousness arises as intoxicating power arises from fermenting agents.
- FACT: **Betel** (leaf, lime, nut -> red): **compositional** emergence. **Fermentation** (*guḍa* -> intoxicant): **transformational** emergence. Two analogies, two distinct objections answered.
- FACT: Consciousness is an "**epiphenomenon** or bye-product of matter"; "matter secretes mind as liver secretes bile".
- CAUTION: **Explanatory gap:** redness and intoxication are public, third-person qualities; consciousness is private and first-personal. Best Cārvāka reply: the soul-hypothesis **renames** the gap rather than closing it.
- FACT: **Pot and potter:** clay is the material cause and the potter the efficient cause; the Cārvāka answers with *svabhāva* — "there is no proof that the objects of the world are the products of any design".
- FACT: **Three labels from the textbook:** naturalism (*svabhāvavāda*) · mechanism (*yadṛcchāvāda*) · **positivism** ("believes only in positive facts or observable phenomena").
- CAUTION: **\*\*Two uses of *svabhāva*:**\*\* deflationary (regularity, with "neither any guarantee that uniformity perceived in the past would continue in future") and substantive (nature in place of God). The "empty label" objection bites only on the second.
- FACT: **\*\*Sadānanda's *Vedāntasāra*:**\*\* four materialist schools identify the self with the gross body, the senses, the vital breaths, or *manas*. Śāntarakṣita reports *Kambalāśvatara* holding that consciousness arises from the body **associated with vital breaths**.
- CAUTION: Cārvāka reaches materialism by an **anti-inferential** route; modern materialism by a thoroughly **inferential** one.



Register 6 — Self, body and consciousness

- FACT: *caitanya-viśiṣṭaḥ kāyaḥ puruṣaḥ* / *caitanya-viśiṣṭa deha eva ātmā* — the person is the **living** body qualified by consciousness. Not the corpse; not "no self at all"; not identity with any single element.
- FACT: **Negative argument:** "the non-material soul is **never perceived**".
- FACT: **Positive argument:** "I am fat", "I am lame", "I am blind" — if the "I" were different from the body these would be **meaningless**.
- FACT: **Covariation:** injury, intoxication, ageing, sleep and disease visibly alter awareness.
- FACT: **Consequence:** "death of the body means the end of the individual"; questions of previous life, after-life, rebirth, heaven and hell "become meaningless".
- FACT: **Sharma's objection battery:** self-consciousness versus animal life · swoon, fits, epilepsy and dreamless sleep = body without consciousness · dreams = consciousness "without the living body", and the waking dreamer disowns the dream-body but **owns** the dream-consciousness · subject cannot be reduced to object · **co-existence is not causation** (light and sight; the two horns of a bull) · consciousness is "neither smelt nor tasted nor seen nor touched nor heard" · consciousness is **private** · the self-manifestation regress · the non-existence of a surviving soul is equally undemonstrable.
- CAUTION: **Best evaluative line:** the evidence establishes **dependence**; dependence is compatible with the body being the **instrument** rather than the cause.
- FACT: **Memory:** Nyāya/Vedānta invoke *ātman* · Cārvāka invokes bodily-psychological continuity of one organism · Buddhism invokes *santāna*, *pratisandhāna* and (Yogācāra) *ālaya-vijñāna* carrying *bījas*.
- FACT: **2024 core contrast:** Cārvāka **relocates** the self into matter; Buddhism **dissolves** the self into process. Substance retained versus substance abolished.
- FACT: **Grounds:** Cārvāka's is epistemic (never perceived); Buddhism's is ontological (*pratītyasamutpāda*, *kṣaṇikavāda*) and soteriological (self-belief breeds *trṣṇā*).
- FACT: **Aftermaths:** Cārvāka ends the moral narrative at death; Buddhism preserves karma, rebirth and *nirvāṇa* without an owner.
- CAUTION: **The decisive refinement:** *rūpa* is itself one of the five *skandhas*, so Buddhist *anātman* rules out the Cārvāka body-self **by name**.
- CAUTION: **Foils:** *Puggalavāda* (Vātsīputriya) inside Buddhism; **Sadānanda's four materialisms** inside Cārvāka.



Register 7 — Rejection of transcendent entities

- FACT: **The template:** X is imperceptible -> only inference or testimony could reach X -> neither is a *pramāṇa* -> X is unwarranted -> X is rejected.
- CAUTION: Note the gap between **withholding assent** and **denying**; the doxographies attribute denial ("the Cārvākas, therefore, prefer atheism"), the argument licenses only the weaker conclusion.
- FACT: **God falls twice:** epistemically (no *pramāṇa*) and explanatorily (*svabhāva* suffices; the world's objects are "fortuitous products of the elements").
- FACT: **Adṛṣṭa** is named among the casualties — "any unperceived law (like *adṛṣṭa*)". Its very name means "the unseen", making it the perfect test case.
- FACT: **Transmigration requires** a separable self, its survival, a carrier of desert, and knowledge of all three. Cārvāka cuts every one.
- FACT: **Heaven and hell** are "the inventions of the priests"; *svarga* rests on "the unproved existence of a life after death".
- FACT: **The liberation dilemma:** freedom of a soul (absurd — there is no soul) · freedom from all pain in this life (impossible — embodiment mixes pleasure and pain) · residue: *maraṇam eva apavargaḥ*, which "no wise man would willingly work for".
- CAUTION: *Maraṇam eva apavargaḥ* is a **reductio of the concept of mokṣa**, not a recommendation of death.

- FACT: **Three ritual reductions:** *śrāddha* and the traveller's food · food downstairs feeding a person upstairs · *jyotiṣṭoma* — "why do they not rather sacrifice their own old parents?" The last is an argument from **revealed preference**.
- FACT: *Sarva-darśana-saṃgraha*: the Agnihotra, the three Vedas, the three staves and ashes were "made by Nature as the livelihood of those destitute of knowledge and manliness"; "the three authors of the Vedas were buffoons, knaves and demons". QUESTION: Quote with a source-caution.
- CAUTION: **Cārvāka's uniqueness:** Sāṃkhya, Mīmāṃsā, Jainism and Buddhism are also non-theistic. Cārvāka alone derives its atheism from its **epistemology**, and alone discards *karma*, rebirth and liberation as well.
- CAUTION: Internal tension worth flagging: *svabhāva* grounds regularity in fixed natures; *yadṛcchāvāda* calls the world "fortuitous".



Register 8 — Ethics and social meaning

- FACT: *kāma evaikaḥ puruṣārthaḥ* — enjoyment is the only end; **artha is its means**; *dharma* and *mokṣa* are rejected.
- FACT: *Dharma* falls on **epistemic** grounds: "virtue and vice are distinctions made by the scriptures, whose authority cannot be rationally accepted".
- FACT: **Criterion:** a good action yields a balance of pleasure; a bad one brings more pain than pleasure. Hence hedonism.
- FACT: **Dhūrta** (cunning / crude) versus **suśikṣita** (cultured / refined) Cārvākas — "the Cārvākas were not all of the same gross, uncultured type".
- FACT: **Evidence for refinement:** sixty-four fine arts (*catuḥ-ṣaṣṭi-kalāḥ*) · *daṇḍanīti* and *vārttā* incorporated into Lokāyata · some Cārvākas "regard the **king as God**", implying faith in society and its head.
- FACT: **Vātsyāyana** is "the best positive evidence of refined hedonism", but he "believes in God and in life after death" and is a materialist only "according to a wider sense of the term" — one who explains higher phenomena by lower.
- FACT: **Vātsyāyana's regulation:** *brahmacarya*, urbanity (*nāgarika-vṛtti*), education of the senses through the arts; and the prudential argument that refusing to defer "would prevent a man even from the toil of cultivation and sowing seeds".
- FACT: Chatterjee and Datta: "Egoistic hedonism in its gross form is **not compatible with social discipline**."
- CAUTION: **Sharma's counterweight:** "crude individual hedonism"; the school's downfall lay in "the denial of all human values"; "**the pleasure of the pig is certainly not the same as the pleasure of the philosopher**."
- QUESTION: **The "debt and ghee" verse** — "let him feed on ghee even though he runs in debt" — is preserved in the *Sarva-darśana-saṃgraha*, an opponent's compendium. Use with an explicit source-caution; its buried argument concerns the rationality of deferral under a finite horizon, and Vātsyāyana himself answers it.
- CAUTION: **Verdict:** Cārvāka's ethics is a coherent theory of **prudence** and an incomplete theory of **morality** — it supplies no qualitative ordering of pleasures and no independent account of other-regarding obligation.



Register 9 — Comparative synthesis and answer craft

| Item                                  | Register entry                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      |
|---------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 2020 Jainism axes                     | FACT: 1 <i>pramāṇa</i> (means of valid knowledge) vs fivefold knowledge · 4 <i>bhūtas</i> (material elements) vs 6 <i>dravyas</i> (plural form: substance) · <i>ākāśa</i> (ether or space as an element) rejected vs accepted · no soul vs infinite <i>jīvas</i> (plural form: living soul or conscious being) with consciousness as <b>inseparable essence</b> · no <i>guṇa</i> (quality)– <i>paryāya</i> (changing mode) vs <i>utpāda-vyaya-dhrauvya</i> (origination, decay and persistence) · single standpoint vs <i>anekānta</i> (many-sidedness), <i>naya</i> , <i>syādvāda</i> (doctrine of qualified or conditional assertion) · no karma (action and its morally consequential residue) vs <b>material</b> karma (action and its morally consequential residue) ( <i>bhāva-bandha</i> (psychic or intentional bondage), <i>dravya-bandha</i> ) · no liberation vs <i>mokṣa</i> (liberation) and <i>kevala-jñāna</i> (perfect omniscience) |
| Shared ground with Jainism            | FACT: Both <i>nāstika</i> (Veda-rejecting or heterodox school); both realists about the perceptible world; both reject a creator God                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                |
| 2024 positivism verdict               | CAUTION: Positivistic in <b>spirit</b> (empiricist criterion, anti-metaphysics, "meaningless" register — and the textbook itself applies the word), <b>not</b> in <b>method</b> (positivism runs on inference and has a constructive programme). Safer labels: <b>radical empiricism</b> , <b>naturalistic materialism</b>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                          |
| The paradox to quote                  | CAUTION: Cārvāka (Indian materialist and perception-centred school) reaches materialism by an anti-inferential route; modern materialism by an inferential one                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      |
| Western convergences                  | CAUTION: Epicurus and Lucretius (materialism, this-worldliness) · Hume (induction unjustifiable) · Ayer (unverifiable metaphysics) · Comte (observable phenomena). Chatterjee and Datta themselves compare the Cārvāka (Indian materialist and perception-centred school) view of inference to "the pragmatists and logical positivists" and the school's reputation to that of "the Epicureans of Greece"                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                          |
| 10-mark spine                         | Thesis -> three doors -> one sharp addition ( <i>upādhi</i> (hidden limiting condition) or self-refutation) -> verdict linking epistemology to the denial asked about                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                               |
| 15-mark spine                         | Frame with the source caution -> full anti-inference argument -> the rival's positive case -> Cārvāka (Indian materialist and perception-centred school)'s best reply and its cost -> graded verdict with a named criterion                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                         |
| 20-mark spine                         | Classify (epistemology generating metaphysics) -> theory of knowledge in full -> ontological consequences -> the demanded comparison on <b>named axes</b> -> two objections with replies and residual pressure -> criterion-named verdict                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                           |
| Item                                  | Register entry                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      |
| PYQ centre of gravity                 | FACT: <b>5 of 9</b> owned parts concern <b>inference</b> ; 2 the self and transcendent entities; 1 the Jaina comparison; 1 the positivism label                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                     |
| Criteria to name in verdicts          | CAUTION: Evidential economy · explanatory adequacy · internal consistency · perceptual redeemability · moral sufficiency · historiographical reliability                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                            |
| The five safe verdicts                | CAUTION: Critique of certainty, not a theory of knowledge · ontology impeccably derived, so vulnerability lies in the epistemology · wins on entailment, loses on <i>pramāṇa</i> (means of valid knowledge)-status · relocation versus dissolution of the self · complete prudence, incomplete morality                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                             |
| Final memory spine                    | MNEMONIC: <b>ONE, FOUR, TWO, ZERO</b> · three doors · wet fuel · betel and fermentation · "I am fat, I am lame, I am blind" · <i>maraṇam eva apavargaḥ</i> · <i>dhūrta</i> (cunning or crude) and <i>suśikṣita</i> (cultivated or refined) · touchstone                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                             |
| End of the complete learning session. |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                     |

## PYQ ROUTES, COMPARISON & ANSWER SPINE

Use: identify the directive -> state the thesis -> define the doctrine -> derive the mechanism -> present objection and reply -> compare only where demanded -> qualify the verdict. Full solved prose remains in the workbook.



2018 · Q8(b) · 15 marks



### Demand decoding

| Element         | Requirement                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                        |
|-----------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Directive       | Three-limbed: a factual survey, an explanatory account, and an evaluative judgement in the candidate's own voice                                                                                                                                                                                                                   |
| Limb 1          | <b>Is it accepted?</b> — a cross-school survey; the answer is overwhelmingly no                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                    |
| Limb 2          | <b>If not, why not?</b> — the <i>reasons</i> , school by school, not a single generic reason                                                                                                                                                                                                                                       |
| Limb 3          | <b>Are they justified?</b> — the candidate's graded verdict, with reasons                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                          |
| Scope boundary  | Stay on <b>inference</b> ; do not drift into Cārvāka (Indian materialist and perception-centred school) ethics or the ritual polemic                                                                                                                                                                                               |
| Ideal thesis    | The other systems are justified against the <b>strong</b> thesis, but the Cārvāka (Indian materialist and perception-centred school)'s residual point — that finite observation cannot entail an unrestricted universal — survives, and Nyāya (school of logic and epistemology) concedes it by shifting from certainty to warrant |
| Non-negotiables | <i>Vyāpti</i> ( <i>invariable concomitance</i> ); the three doors; <i>upādhi</i> ( <i>hidden limiting condition</i> ); at least three named schools with their distinct reasons; the self-refutation charge; a criterion-named verdict                                                                                             |

**No system accepts this.** Nyāya replies that *vyāpti* is built by *anvaya-vyatireka*, elimination of suspected *upādhis*, *tarka* and *sāmānyalakṣaṇa-pratyakṣa*, and that *parāmarśa* — the mark cognised as qualified by concomitance — means no "leap" occurs. Sāṃkhya must reject it, since *prakṛti* and *puruṣa* are established only inferentially. Mīmāṃsā must, since injunction and *apūrva* presuppose it. Buddhism, through Dignāga and Dharmakīrti, constructs an entire logic, and the *Tattvasaṅgraha* attacks Cārvāka's naïve perceptualism directly. Jainism needs inference for *matī* and *śruta*. Advaita alone partly agrees, but denies **ultimate** validity to perception as well — a level-distinction, as Sharma observes, "unknown to the Cārvāka".

CAUTION: **Verdict:** they are justified against the strong thesis but not entitled to complacency, since Nyāya answers only by replacing omniscient certainty with disciplined warrant — a substitution that concedes the Cārvāka's logical point while denying his epistemological conclusion.



### Why this earns marks

- **Structure:** state the Cārvāka thesis with its argument -> survey the schools with **distinct** reasons -> the self-refutation charge -> the candidate's graded verdict. All three limbs must be visibly answered.
- **Comparison:** at least four schools with school-specific reasons. A generic "all schools accept inference" earns half the marks.



2019 · Q5(c) · 10 marks

**Question:** Are the Cārvākas consistent when they hold that inference is not a source of knowledge? Discuss.



Demand decoding

| Element         | Requirement                                                                                                                                      |
|-----------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Directive       | Discuss with an explicit verdict on <b>consistency</b> — a yes/no question that requires a qualified answer                                      |
| Core issue      | Whether the denial of inference can be stated and defended without using inference                                                               |
| Scope boundary  | This is about <b>internal coherence</b> , not about whether inference is in fact valid                                                           |
| Ideal thesis    | Inconsistent on the strong reading; consistent on the softened reading — but the softened reading is a much weaker doctrine                      |
| Non-negotiables | The charge reconstructed as steps; at least two of the three replies; the point that other minds and ideas are never perceived; a graded verdict |

**The replies.** CAUTION: Three are available. (i) *Vitaṇḍā*: the Cārvāka advances no thesis, only destroys the opponent's claim to certainty — but he does assert four elements and a body-self, so this cannot be global. (ii) The **softened thesis**: he denies not inference itself but its capacity to yield **apodictic certainty**, especially about the transcendent. (iii) The **level-distinction**: concede *vyāvahārika* validity, deny the *pāramārthika* — though Sharma notes this distinction is "unknown to the Cārvāka".

CAUTION: **Verdict**: inconsistent as an unrestricted denial; consistent as a fallibilist warning. The Cārvāka may be **radical or consistent, but not both**.

**Depth refinement.** A practical concession needs an epistemic status: if successful worldly inference is knowledge, the absolute thesis contracts; if it is only expectation, Cārvāka must explain why rational action may trust what philosophy disqualifies.



Why this earns marks

- **Structure:** state the charge as numbered steps -> give the replies -> deliver the verdict. Do not narrate the *vyāpti* argument at length; the question presupposes it.
- **Doctrine:** the exact form of the thesis being tested — "no inference is a *pramāṇa*" — and its universality.



2019 · Q6(c) · 15 marks



Demand decoding

| Element        | Requirement                                                                                                                                 |
|----------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Directive      | Diagnose a specific argument, then <b>justify</b> the diagnosis — application, not recitation                                               |
| Core issue     | Whether the candidate attacks the right thing: the <b>major premise</b> , not the form                                                      |
| Scope boundary | Use the smoke-and-fire material only as illustration; the syllogism itself must stay in focus                                               |
| Ideal thesis   | The syllogism is <b>valid but epistemically empty</b> — it transmits a certainty in the major premise that was never independently acquired |

| Element         | Requirement                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                              |
|-----------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Non-negotiables | Explicit refusal to attack validity; the major premise identified as <i>vyāpti</i> ( <i>invariable concomitance</i> ); the three doors applied to "All men are mortal"; <i>petitio principii</i> ; <i>upādhi</i> ( <i>hidden limiting condition</i> ); one line of self-critical balance |

The Cārvāka objection is **not** that the argument is formally invalid. If the premises hold, the conclusion follows; the Cārvāka concedes this and attacks elsewhere.

Hence, in Sharma's formulation, the syllogism is an **argument in a circle**: the conclusion "Socrates is mortal" is already contained in "All men are mortal". Deduction merely extracts what induction never established. *Upādhi* deepens the charge: perhaps what is genuinely invariable is not man-ness with mortality but organic embodiment under conditions never fully surveyed.

CAUTION: **Verdict**: the syllogism is valid but epistemically empty. The charge is a serious one about induction — though the Cārvāka must still explain how his own universal denial of inference is known.



Why this earns marks

• **Structure**: disclaim the attack on validity -> identify the major premise as *vyāpti* -> run the three doors **on this premise** -> *petitio principii* -> *upādhi* -> verdict.



2020 · Q6(b) · 15 marks

**Question**: Critically evaluate Cārvākas' rejection of Ākāśa as one of the elements of reality and examine their criticism of transmigration of Soul.



Demand decoding

| Element         | Requirement                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                    |
|-----------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Directive       | <i>Critically evaluate and examine</i> — two tasks, both requiring two-sided assessment                                                                                                                                                                        |
| Core issue      | That both rejections are the <b>same argument applied twice</b> , once to cosmology and once to soteriology                                                                                                                                                    |
| Scope boundary  | Two halves, roughly balanced; do not let <i>ākāśa</i> ( <i>ether or space as an element</i> ) consume the answer                                                                                                                                               |
| Ideal thesis    | The rejections are impeccably consistent with the epistemology, and are therefore exactly as strong — and as vulnerable — as that epistemology                                                                                                                 |
| Non-negotiables | The Vaiśeṣika (school of categories and atomism) sound-to- <i>ākāśa</i> ( <i>ether or space as an element</i> ) inference named and refused; the four requirements of transmigration each cut; at least two objections with replies; a criterion-named verdict |

**Ākāśa**. FACT: Most Indian schools admit five elements; Cārvāka admits four — earth, water, fire and air. The reason is exact: *ākāśa* "is not perceived but **inferred**" (Sharma). The Vaiśeṣika reaches it by argument — sound is a quality; qualities inhere in substances; sound belongs to no other admitted substance; therefore *ākāśa* exists as its substrate. Since inference is not a *pramāṇa*, that route is closed.

**Transmigration**. FACT: Transmigration requires (a) a self distinct from the body, (b) its survival after death, (c) a carrier of moral desert, and (d) knowledge that these obtain. Cārvāka cuts each: *dehātmavāda* makes the self the living body — *caitanya-viśiṣṭaḥ kāyaḥ puruṣaḥ*; "death of the body means the end of the individual"; *karma* and *adr̥ṣṭa* are unperceived; and only scripture or inference could supply the knowledge.

CAUTION: **Verdict**: one epistemic cut, applied twice — and its force is exactly the force of that cut.



Why this earns marks

• **Criticism:** at least two — the instrument objection and the unestablished/unreal slide; ideally Sharma's symmetry point too.



2020 · Q7(c) · 15 marks



Demand decoding

| Element         | Requirement                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                            |
|-----------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Directive       | <i>Explain the differences</i> — a sustained axis-by-axis comparison, not two mini-essays                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                              |
| Core issue      | Conceptions of <b>reality</b> : what exists, how it is known, and how change and persistence are accommodated                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                          |
| Scope boundary  | Metaphysics and its epistemology; ethics only if it illuminates the ontology                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                           |
| Ideal thesis    | The deepest difference is not materialism versus spiritualism but the <b>number of standpoints</b> each admits — Jainism multiplies both entities and viewpoints; Cārvāka (Indian materialist and perception-centred school) admits one of each                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                        |
| Non-negotiables | <i>Pramāṇas</i> (plural form: <i>means of valid knowledge</i> ); the definition of <i>sat</i> ( <i>being or reality</i> ); four <i>bhūtas</i> ( <i>material elements</i> ) versus six <i>dravyas</i> (plural form: <i>substance</i> ); <i>ākāśa</i> ( <i>ether or space as an element</i> ); soul and consciousness; <i>anekāntavāda</i> ( <i>doctrine of many-sided reality</i> ) and <i>syādvāda</i> ( <i>doctrine of qualified or conditional assertion</i> ); karma (action and its morally consequential residue); liberation; and the shared <i>nāstika</i> ( <i>Veda-rejecting or heterodox school</i> ) ground |

**Soul and consciousness.** FACT: Cārvāka: no *jīva*; the self is the living body, and consciousness an emergent by-product. Jainism: infinitely many *jīvas*, with consciousness their **inseparable essence** — expressly denying, as the sources put it, the Cārvāka view that it is "a mere accidental property, arising only under some conditions".

CAUTION: **Verdict.** Their agreement is instructive: both are *nāstika*, both realists about the perceptible world, both reject a creator. The divergence is over standpoints and substances — which is why Jainism can hold change and persistence together while Cārvāka can only assert them side by side.



Why this earns marks

• **Structure:** named axes, each carrying both positions in the same sentence or row; then the unifying thesis; then the shared ground.

• **Comparison:** at least seven axes; fewer looks thin at 15 marks.



2021 · Q5(e) · 10 marks

**Question:** Comment on the bearing of Cārvāka epistemology on the rejection of transcendental entities by them.



Demand decoding



| Element         | Requirement                                                                                                                                                                                |
|-----------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Directive       | <i>Comment on the bearing</i> — the examiner wants the <b>derivation</b> , not two lists                                                                                                   |
| Core issue      | That a single epistemic premise severs every transcendent entity at once                                                                                                                   |
| Scope boundary  | Do not narrate the <i>vyāpti</i> ( <i>invariable concomitance</i> ) argument at length; compress it and spend the words on the derivation                                                  |
| Ideal thesis    | Cārvāka (Indian materialist and perception-centred school) ontology is the exact ontological shadow of its epistemology, so the denials are consequences and not separate acts of unbelief |
| Non-negotiables | The compressed epistemic argument; the bridging principle named as a presupposition; at least five entities derived; one line of evaluation                                                |

For Cārvāka, ontology is the shadow cast by epistemology. Perception alone is a *pramāṇa*: *anumāna* fails because *vyāpti* is established neither by perception (all cases are never surveyed), nor by inference (*petitio principii*), nor by testimony (whose own validity is inferred); *śabda* fails because words certify only that something was said. Chatterjee and Datta accordingly state that the Cārvāka theory of reality “**follows from**” this epistemological conclusion.

The **bearing** is systematic. The bridging principle — ontological commitment must not outrun the accepted *pramāṇas* — is then applied without exception. *Ākāśa* falls, being inferred from sound. *Ātman* falls, never being perceived apart from the living body. *Īśvara* falls, being reached only by design-inference while *svabhāva* discharges the explanatory work. *Karma*, *adr̥ṣṭa*, rebirth, *svarga* and *mokṣa* fall as unseen forces or post-mortem states no perception could present. Vedic authority falls with *śabda*, and ritual loses its rationale with it.

CAUTION: **Comment:** the derivation is impeccably consistent; its cost is that the whole ontology stands or falls with the rejection of inference.



Why this earns marks



2024 · Q5(a) · 10 marks



Demand decoding

| Element         | Requirement                                                                                                                                                                 |
|-----------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Directive       | An explicit personal verdict with <b>reasons and justifications</b> — a graded answer, never a flat yes or no                                                               |
| Core issue      | Whether an empiricist criterion and anti-metaphysical temper suffice for the label, given that Cārvāka (Indian materialist and perception-centred school) rejects inference |
| Scope boundary  | Comparative epistemology and method; do not turn it into a history of logical positivism                                                                                    |
| Ideal thesis    | Positivistic in <b>spirit</b> , not in <b>method</b> ; “radical empiricism” is the safer label                                                                              |
| Non-negotiables | The evidential point that the textbooks themselves apply the word; at least three points for and three against; the inference divergence; a named alternative label         |

**The case for.** FACT: The label is not imported by the examiner: Chatterjee and Datta write that the Cārvāka theory “may also be called **positivism**, because it believes only in **positive facts or observable phenomena**”, and compare its view of inference to that of “the pragmatists and logical positivists”. Cārvāka restricts the knowable to what perception presents; rejects God, soul, *karma* and heaven as unwarranted; refuses scriptural authority; grounds value in this-worldly pleasure and pain; and even adopts a quasi-verificationist register, since questions about rebirth and heaven are said to become “**meaningless**”.

CAUTION: **Verdict:** an illuminating analogy, not a historical identity. **Radical empiricism** or **naturalistic materialism** is the more accurate description. The paradox is that Cārvāka reaches a materialist conclusion by an **anti-inferential** route.



Why this earns marks

• **Structure:** verdict first -> case for -> case against -> refined label. A graded verdict announced early controls the whole answer.



2024 · Q6(a) · 20 marks



Demand decoding

| Element         | Requirement                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                           |
|-----------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Directive       | <i>Differentiate</i> — sustained contrast on named axes; separate descriptions will not do                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                            |
| Core issue      | That two denials of <i>ātman</i> ( <i>enduring self or soul</i> ) can be philosophically opposite in target, ground, aftermath and metaphysical price                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                 |
| Scope boundary  | The self; bring in karma (action and its morally consequential residue), rebirth and liberation only as <b>consequences</b> of the two denials                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                        |
| Ideal thesis    | Cārvāka (Indian materialist and perception-centred school) <b>relocates</b> the self into matter; Buddhism <b>dissolves</b> it into process. Substance retained versus substance abolished                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                            |
| Non-negotiables | <i>Dehātmavāda</i> ( <i>doctrine that the conscious living body is the self</i> ) with its formula; the five <i>skandhas</i> ( <i>five aggregates constituting the person-process</i> ); <i>santāna</i> ( <i>causal continuum or stream</i> ); the epistemic versus ontological-soteriological grounds; the point that <i>rūpa</i> ( <i>material form</i> ) is itself a <i>skandha</i> ( <i>aggregate constituting the person-process</i> ); the divergent aftermaths |

**Cārvāka: relocation.** FACT: The doctrine is *dehātmavāda* — *caitanya-viśiṣṭaḥ kāyaḥ puruṣaḥ*, the person is the body qualified by consciousness. The **ground is epistemological**: perception alone is a *pramāṇa*, and "the non-material soul is never perceived". The positive argument is drawn from ordinary speech: we say "I am fat", "I am lame", "I am blind", and if the "I" were distinct from the body these would be meaningless. Consciousness is admitted, but as an **emergent by-product** of the organised elements — as the betel leaf, lime and nut together yield a redness none possesses, and as molasses becomes intoxicant on fermenting. Since no self survives the body's dissolution, "death of the body means the end of the individual"; *karma*, rebirth, *svarga* and *mokṣa* all lapse, and *maraṇam eva apavargaḥ*.

CAUTION: **The four differentiating theses.** (i) **Targets** differ: Cārvāka substitutes a material self, whereas Buddhism denies substantiality of any kind — and since *rūpa* is itself one of the *skandhas*, Buddhist analysis refutes the Cārvāka body-self **by name**. (ii) **Grounds** differ: epistemic versus ontological-soteriological. (iii) **Aftermaths** differ: Cārvāka terminates the moral narrative at death; Buddhism is engineered precisely to continue it. (iv) **Prices** differ: Cārvāka must explain how matter yields subjectivity; Buddhism must explain how an ownerless stream yields memory, desert and liberation.

CAUTION: **Verdict:** Cārvāka denies the self's **transcendence** while retaining its **substantiality**; Buddhism denies its substantiality while retaining its **moral continuity**.



Why this earns marks

• **Structure:** the two positions stated compactly -> four explicit differentiating theses -> a one-line verdict. Do not write two biographies.



2025 · Q5(a) · 10 marks



| Demand decoding |                                                                                                                                                                                                                |
|-----------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Element         | Requirement                                                                                                                                                                                                    |
| Directive       | Explain the ground — a focused, architecturally clean exposition; evaluation is secondary                                                                                                                      |
| Core issue      | The impossibility of establishing <i>vyāpti</i> (invariable concomitance)                                                                                                                                      |
| Scope boundary  | Stay on the ground for rejection; do not survey the other schools' replies at length                                                                                                                           |
| Ideal thesis    | The ground is that <i>vyāpti</i> (invariable concomitance), without which inference cannot claim certainty, is unobtainable by any means the Cārvāka (Indian materialist and perception-centred school) admits |
| Non-negotiables | <i>Vyāpti</i> (invariable concomitance) defined; the three doors; <i>upādhi</i> (hidden limiting condition); the "accident and separable" line; one closing sentence of balance                                |

FACT: The ground is the **impossibility of establishing *vyāpti***. Inference moves from a perceived mark to an unperceived *sādhya*, and is licensed only by an invariable concomitance — "wherever smoke, there fire". For inference to be a *pramāṇa*, that universal must be beyond doubt.



Why this earns marks

- **Structure:** define *vyāpti* -> three doors -> *upādhi* -> the "accident and separable" conclusion. Clean, fast, complete.
- **Comparison:** at most one clause on Nyāya's reply; the question does not ask for it.

These six questions are original practice prompts, not UPSC PYQs. Each model is written independently for learner use.



Original 1 · 10 marks

Question: Explain why the Cārvāka rejects *śabda* as an independent *pramāṇa*, and assess whether the rejection is consistent with his acceptance of perception. (10 marks, ~150 words)



| Demand decoding |                                                                                                                                  |
|-----------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Element         | Requirement                                                                                                                      |
| Directive       | Explain then assess — exposition plus a consistency verdict                                                                      |
| Core issue      | Whether admitting words-as-sounds while refusing words-as-evidence is coherent                                                   |
| Ideal thesis    | The rejection is internally consistent, since the perceived item is the <b>sound</b> and the disputed item is the <b>content</b> |



Why this earns marks

- A verdict that distinguishes **inconsistency** from **impracticality**.



Original 2 · 10 marks

**Question:** Distinguish *svabhāvavāda* from *yadṛcchāvāda* in Cārvāka metaphysics and examine whether they are consistent. (10 marks, ~150 words)



Demand decoding

| Element      | Requirement                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                 |
|--------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Directive    | <i>Distinguish</i> then <i>examine</i> consistency — a conceptual distinction put to critical work                                                                                                                                                          |
| Core issue   | Whether fixed natures and fortuitous combination can both be asserted                                                                                                                                                                                       |
| Ideal thesis | They are compatible only if <i>svabhāva</i> ( <i>intrinsic own-nature</i> ) governs the <b>behaviour</b> of elements while <i>yadṛcchā</i> ( <i>chance or accidental occurrence</i> ) governs their <b>initial concurrence</b> ; otherwise there is tension |



Why this earns marks

• A verdict that identifies **teleology**, not regularity, as the common target.



Original 3 · 15 marks

**Question:** Examine the Cārvāka doctrine that consciousness is an emergent by-product of the four elements, with the objections it faces. (15 marks, ~230 words)



Demand decoding

| Element      | Requirement                                                                                                                                                                                     |
|--------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Directive    | <i>Examine ... with the objections</i> — exposition plus a serious objection set and replies                                                                                                    |
| Core issue   | Whether the emergence analogies establish emergence of the right logical <b>type</b>                                                                                                            |
| Ideal thesis | The analogies establish that novel <b>public</b> qualities emerge; consciousness is <b>private</b> and first-personal, so the explanatory gap remains — though dualism does not close it either |

FACT: **The doctrine.** *Kiṃvādibhyo madaśaktivad vijñānam*: consciousness arises from matter as intoxicating power arises from fermenting agents. The objection it answers is stated by Chatterjee and Datta: "we do not perceive consciousness in any of the four material elements. How can it then come to qualify their product, the body?" The reply uses two analogies with distinct functions. **Betel** — leaf, lime and nut, "none of which is originally red", yielding a reddish tinge when chewed together — establishes **compositional** emergence. **Fermentation** — molasses, "originally non-intoxicant", becoming intoxicant when allowed to ferment — establishes **transformational** emergence. Consciousness is accordingly "an **epiphenomenon** or by-product of matter".

CAUTION: **Objections.** (i) The analogies concern **public, third-person** qualities; consciousness is **private** — Sharma notes it "is neither smelt nor tasted nor seen nor touched nor heard", and "consciousness of an individual cannot be shared by others". (ii) In swoon, epilepsy and dreamless sleep the living body persists **without** consciousness, so the property is not inseparable. (iii) Constant co-occurrence is not causation: "the eye cannot see in darkness ... yet light cannot be regarded as the cause of sight", and the two horns of a bull are conjoined without being causally related — so the body may be the **instrument** of consciousness rather than its cause.

CAUTION: **Replies and verdict.** The Cārvāka may answer that the property is essential to a specific **organisation** rather than to bare bodily existence, and that positing an immaterial soul merely **renames** the gap. The honest verdict: the evidence establishes **dependence**, not production; both sides face the gap, and only one claims to have crossed it.



Why this earns marks

- At least three objections, at least two of them from the standard battery.
- The Cārvāka's replies given before the verdict.
- A verdict distinguishing **dependence** from **production**.



Original 4 · 15 marks

**Question:** "The Cārvāka's *upādhi* objection is a stronger argument than his objection from incomplete enumeration." Critically discuss. **(15 marks, ~230 words)**



Demand decoding

| Element      | Requirement                                                                                                                                      |
|--------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Directive    | <i>Critically discuss</i> an evaluative comparison between two of the Cārvāka (Indian materialist and perception-centred school)'s own arguments |
| Core issue   | Sample size versus identification of the relevant variable                                                                                       |
| Ideal thesis | The claim is correct: enumeration is curable in principle by more observation, whereas <i>upādhi</i> ( <i>hidden limiting condition</i> ) is not |

FACT: **The enumeration objection.** *Vyāpti* requires knowledge of all cases, and "we cannot perceive even all the cases of smoke and fire existing now ... to speak nothing of those which existed in the past or will exist in the future".

FACT: **\*\*The *upādhi* objection.\*\*** Even where two things are repeatedly observed together, an unnoticed condition may be operating. One who has often seen fire accompanied by smoke may infer smoke from fire and err, having failed to notice the *upādhi* of **wetness of fuel**, on whose presence alone fire is attended with smoke. Hence "so long as the relation between two phenomena is not proved to be **unconditional**, it is an uncertain ground for inference" — and unconditionality "cannot be established beyond doubt by perception, as some conditions may **always remain hidden**".

CAUTION: **Counter-consideration and verdict.** Nyāya may reply that a relation surviving systematic negative-case testing plus *tarka* is rationally warranted even if not indefeasible. That defends inference; it does not refute the *upādhi* point. The claim therefore stands: *upādhi* is the deeper argument, and it is the one that forces Nyāya to change the standard from certainty to warrant.



Why this earns marks

- Both objections stated accurately, with the *upādhi* example running **fire -> smoke**.

- The dialectical proof: Nyāya's differential response to the two objections.
- A verdict that concedes Nyāya's warrant-based defence while upholding the comparison.



Original 5 · 20 marks

Question: "Cārvāka's metaphysics is nothing but its epistemology written out as a list of denials." Critically evaluate. (20 marks, ~340 words)



Demand decoding

| Element      | Requirement                                                                                                                                                                                                |
|--------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Directive    | Critically evaluate a strong interpretive claim — say how far it is true and where it fails                                                                                                                |
| Core issue   | Whether the metaphysics is wholly derivative or contains independent positive commitments                                                                                                                  |
| Ideal thesis | Largely true of the <b>denials</b> , false of the <b>affirmations</b> — the four elements, emergence and <i>svabhāva</i> (intrinsic own-nature) are positive theses not entailed by the epistemology alone |

FACT: **The case for the claim.** Chatterjee and Datta state that the Cārvāka theory of reality "**follows from**" the epistemological conclusion: if perception is the only reliable source of knowledge, "we can rationally assert only the reality of perceptible objects. God, soul, heaven, life before birth or after death, and any unperceived law (like *adr̥ṣṭa*) cannot be believed in, because they are all beyond perception."

The derivation is exact. *Ākāśa* falls because it is inferred from sound. *Ātman* falls because no soul is perceived apart from the living body. *Īśvara* falls because he is reached only by design-inference. *Karma*, *adr̥ṣṭa*, rebirth, *svarga* and *mokṣa* fall as unseen forces or post-mortem states. Vedic authority falls with *śabda*, and ritual with it. One cut, seven casualties.

CAUTION: **Verdict.** The claim is **true of the negative half and false of the positive half**. Cārvāka's denials are indeed epistemology written out as a list — which is why they stand or fall entirely with the rejection of inference. But its affirmations are a materialist research programme in miniature, and they carry explanatory burdens of their own: chiefly the explanatory gap between public emergent qualities and private consciousness, which no epistemic restriction can discharge. CAUTION: Criterion named: **derivational economy** supports the claim, **explanatory content** refutes it.



Why this earns marks

- A split verdict — true of the denials, false of the affirmations — with a named criterion.



Original 6 · 20 marks

Question: Compare the Cārvāka and Nyāya positions on *vyāpti*, and assess whether Nyāya successfully answers the Cārvāka. (20 marks, ~340 words)



Demand decoding

| Element   | Requirement                                                                  |
|-----------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Directive | Compare then assess success — the assessment must name a standard of success |

| Element      | Requirement                                                                                                                                                                       |
|--------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Core issue   | Whether replacing certainty with warrant answers the objection or changes the subject                                                                                             |
| Ideal thesis | Nyāya (school of logic and epistemology) succeeds against the practical challenge and concedes the logical point; the dispute is ultimately about the <b>concept of knowledge</b> |

FACT: **Nyāya**. *Vyāpti* is **assembled**, not intuited in one act. Repeated observation (*bhūyodarśana*) is disciplined as **anvaya** (co-presence) and **vyatireka** (co-absence), making it a structured search for counter-instances. Suspected *upādhis* are identified and the universal restated at the correct level — "fire joined with wet fuel, there smoke". **Tarka** — not a *pramāṇa* but a *pramāṇa-anugrahaka* — assumes the contradictory and exhibits an unacceptable consequence, removing the doubt that blocks *vyāptigraha*. **Sāmānyalakṣaṇa-pratyakṣa** answers the class-character objection by presenting the universal through the particular. Finally, **parāmarśa** — the mark cognised as qualified by concomitance — shows that no "leap" occurs at all.

CAUTION: **Assessment**. Nyāya succeeds on three counts. *Tarka* has real bite against Cārvāka specifically, since the Cārvāka's own acting, expecting and arguing presuppose the regularities he refuses to certify. *Parāmarśa* dissolves the "leap" picture on which the objection trades. And Sharma's counter-attack reverses the hierarchy: perception errs — the flat earth, the static earth, the small solar disc — and is corrected **by inference**, while "mere sensation cannot be regarded as a means of knowledge unless conception ... has arranged into order ... the loose threads of sense-data".

CAUTION: **Verdict**. Nyāya answers the Cārvāka **by changing the standard** — from omniscient certainty to disciplined rational warrant, since "the Nyāya point is not infallibilism but disciplined justificatory practice". Judged by **warrant**, Nyāya wins; judged by **entailment**, the Cārvāka's logical point survives untouched. The real disagreement is therefore about the concept of knowledge, not about the logic of induction, on which both agree.



Why this earns marks

- A verdict that names **two** criteria and delivers a different result under each.

| FINAL RAPID-RECALL SEQUENCE                                                                                       |                                                                                                                                                                         |
|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 01. 0. ONE-SCREEN MAP                                                                                             | 02. 1. Historical Reconstruction and the Source Problem                                                                                                                 |
| 03. 1. The three names, and what each one tells you                                                               | 04. 2. The source problem, stated precisely                                                                                                                             |
| 05. 3. The surviving fragments — what is actually quoted                                                          | 06. 4. Why Cārvāka (Indian materialist and perception-centred school) is <i>nāstika</i> ( <i>Veda-rejecting or heterodox school</i> ) — and the exact sense of the word |
| 07. 5. Why materialism arose — the historical setting                                                             | 08. 6. Jayarāśi (Cārvāka-associated radical sceptic) Bhaṭṭa — the one surviving text, and why it must be handled carefully                                              |
| 09. 2. Epistemology — Perception as the Sole <i>Pramāṇa</i> ( <i>means of valid knowledge</i> )                   | 10. 1. The core thesis, stated exactly                                                                                                                                  |
| 11. 2. Two kinds of perception, and why the Cārvāka (Indian materialist and perception-centred school) needs both | 12. 3. Certainty versus practical belief — the distinction that saves the position                                                                                      |